THE BOOK OF

CONCENTRATION

Mount Qaf Companion Handbook
Second Edition

Suluk Global 2025–2027 · Inayatiyya

Kabir · Class of Mount Qaf

Three Parts
Part I — Pir Zia Inayat Khan
Part II — Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg
Part III — Personal Transmissions by Guide Mansur

Pod Mentor: Farzana

September – December 2025

291 Teachings · 26 Chapters · 3 Parts · 20 Sessions

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim

In the Name of God, the All-Compassionate, the All-Merciful.

Dedicated to the lineage of teachers through whom the spirit of guidance has shone forth — Hazrat Inayat Khan, Pir Vilayat Inayat Khan, Pir Zia Inayat Khan — and to Mansur, whose guidance illuminates the personal path.

Toward the One

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INTRODUCTION

Concentration is the first stage of the Suluk — the spiritual journey of the Inayatiyya. The word Suluk means 'to travel' — not an outer pilgrimage, but the soul's journey from the periphery of consciousness to its luminous center. Concentration is the gathering of scattered attention, the training of the sovereign faculty that makes all other inner work possible.

This handbook is organized in three parts, each preserving the voice and teaching arc of a single instructor:

Part I — Pir Zia Inayat Khan taught Concentration I (C1–C10) across two retreat weekends in September and October 2025. His teachings ground the student in the prayers, breath practices, sensory concentration, and the deep wisdom of the Inayati lineage.

Part II — Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg taught Concentration II (C11–C20) across two retreat weekends in November and December 2025. His approach centers on the body as vessel, the five elements, and the gentle art of attention.

Part III — Guide Mansur provides personal transmissions outside the classroom — the most intimate layer of the Suluk journey. His prescribed practices, counsel, and wisdom form the daily practice backbone.

The handbook contains 291 teachings extracted from class transcripts, organized into 26 topic chapters across the three parts. Within each part, chapters are organized by topic — Prayers, Practices, Breath, Teachings, Stories, and more — so you always know whose voice you are reading while still being able to find any teaching by subject.

"Concentration is not merely a practice — it is a way of life."

— Pir Zia Inayat Khan

May this handbook serve as a living reference — not a museum of words, but a doorway back into the practices and states from which they arose. Return to it often. The teachings deepen with every reading.

PART I

THE TEACHINGS OF PIR ZIA INAYAT KHAN

Concentration I · September–October 2025 · 5 Classes · 10 Sessions

Pir Zia Inayat Khan is the spiritual leader of the Inayatiyya and grandson of Hazrat Inayat Khan. He taught Section I of the Concentration program (C1–C10) across two retreat weekends: September 12–14 and October 11–12, 2025.

Weekend 1: September 12–14, 2025 (C1–C6)
Weekend 2: October 11–12, 2025 (C7–C10)

134 Teachings · 9 Chapters

Part I · Chapter 1

PRAYERS & INVOCATIONS

The Sacred Words That Open the Way

Prayer in the Sufi tradition is the soul's conversation with the Divine. Pir Zia taught the foundational prayers of the Inayatiyya — the Invocation, Aman, Saum, Salat, and Salawat — with their physical movements, inner orientations, and progressive layers of meaning across his 10 sessions.

9 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Saum and Salat — The Two Daily Prayers

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Two prayers transmitted through Pir-o-Murshid Inayat Khan form the daily foundation of Suluk practice. These are Saum and Salat (also called Salawat). Both involve specific postures, gestures, and words.

THE TWO DAILY PRAYERS

Prayer · Meaning & Addressed To · Description

Saum · Repose · Addressed to the One Divine Being · Prayer of repose addressed to the One. Deepens relationship with the divine being.

Salat / Salawat · Benediction · Addressed to the Light of the Rasool · Benediction addressed to the Spirit of Guidance — the first manifested light. Brings travelers closer to each other in the inner worlds.

IMPORTANT NOTE ON PRACTICE

> *"These prayers are not intended to displace the prayers of the religion to which you belong, but rather to shine a light that reveals the depths of your faith even more clearly than ever before."*

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Salat — Prayer of Benediction

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

DISTINCTION BETWEEN SALAT AND SALAWAT

Salat is the foundation, the form given by Murshid, invoking the light of the prophet — the figure that functions through all the prophets and saints and sages of all time and all space. Here, the beings who are named are fewer.

Salawat — the very name of which suggests a kind of multiplication — we invoke more beings. We recognize that in each dispensation of prophecy, there is a syzygy, a constellation of beings working together. The prophetic impulse is carried by a constellation of historical figures. It's never just one human individual.

“There is more than one version of the pluralized invocation of the multiple figures of multiple syzygies. And we'll have a chance to speak about how we experience these, including male as well as female exemplars.”

SALAT - FULL TEXT

Most gracious Sovereign,

Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,

We greet Thee with all humility.

Thou art the First Cause and the Last Effect,
the Divine Light and the Spirit of Guidance,
Alpha and Omega.
Thy Light is in all forms,
Thy Love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.
Allow us to recognize Thee in all Thy holy names and forms:
as Rama, as Krishna, as Shiva, as Buddha.
Let us know Thee as Abraham, as Solomon, as Zarathushtra,
as Moses, as Jesus, as Muhammad,
and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy Past,
Thy Presence deeply enlightens our being,
and we look for Thy blessing in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God!
Thou Whose heart constantly reaches upward,
Thou comest on earth with a message,
as a dove from above, when Dharma decays,
and speakest the Word that is put into Thy mouth,
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Let the star of the Divine Light shining in Thy heart
be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees.
May the Message of God reach far and wide,
illuminating and making the whole humanity
as one single Family in the Parenthood of God.
Amen.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

- **Saum** — the opening prayer of each session; involves more movements; opening invocation

- **Salat** — the closing prayer; simpler form given by Murshid; invokes the light of the Prophet (the spirit of guidance flowing through all prophets, saints, and sages of all times and spaces)
- **Salawat** — from the root suggesting multiplication and plurality; invokes more beings — the constellation (syzygy) of illuminated souls in each dispensation of prophecy

Spiritual guidance is never carried by a single individual. In each age, there is a syzygy — a constellation of beings working together to transmit divine wisdom, including male and female exemplars, functioning on subtle levels even today. In Suluk 2025, we begin with the original simplest form of Salat.

Most gracious Sovereign, Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,

We greet Thee with all humility.

Thou art the First Cause and the Last Effect, the Divine Light and the Spirit of Guidance, Alpha and Omega.

Thy Light is in all forms, Thy Love in all beings: in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child, in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.

Allow us to recognize Thee in all Thy holy names and forms: as Rama, as Krishna, as Shiva, as Buddha. Let us know Thee as Abraham, as Solomon, as Zarathushtra, as Moses, as Jesus, as Muhammad, and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.

We adore Thy Past, Thy Presence deeply enlightens our being, and we look for Thy blessing in the future.

O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God! Thou Whose heart constantly reaches upward, Thou comest on earth with a message, as a dove from above, when Dharma decays, and speakest the Word that is put into Thy mouth, as the light filleth the crescent moon.

Let the star of the Divine Light shining in Thy heart be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees. May the Message of God reach far and wide, illuminating and making the whole humanity as one single Family in the Parenthood of God.

Pir Zia's teaching on the deeper meaning of Salat before closing the session.

“Salat is a practice of giving one's attention to the ONE — the collectivity of beings who serve the furtherance of creation in God's name.”

The Divan is the vast network of illuminated beings — of various kinds: Jalali, Jamali, and Kamali; some physically incarnate, most existing on other planes — who work together, each with a particular mission, to advance the disclosure of the divine in creation.

- Together they manifest the mind of the Spirit of Guidance — the soul of the universe
- The more we are aware of them and align our lives with their work, the more we participate in that work

- Sacred knowledge and sacred service go hand in hand

Salat invokes the Spirit of Guidance as Alpha and Omega — first and culmination of creation — and then affirms how the light of the universe manifests through human expressions: loving mother, kind father, innocent child, helpful friend, inspiring teacher — and most emphatically, in those beings who become the path itself.

Salat acknowledges 180,000 prophets — impossible to name all — as an image of the vast network of sacred service. Names open into syzygies (constellations of beings), which are mutually interrelated, linking unnamed syzygies, comprising the circuitry of a vast luminous mind. This cosmological vision is implicit in every recitation of Salat.

"Sacred knowledge is given to those who are sworn to sacred service — to go hand in hand."

"Those beings who, in following the path, become the path, become expressions of the path, become guides on the path — and every culture knows their names because those names are remembered with reverence."

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Amān — The Prayer of Sanctuary

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Aman is not one of the 99 Names of God — it is a mantric word expressing a deep aspiration. Murshid gave it specifically for times of extreme suffering, calamity, and communal pain in the world.

AMAN VS FAZAL

Fazal — a universal practice of blessing; creates an atmosphere of benediction and positive vibration; used regularly.

Aman — more specific; invoked when witnessing great calamities, communities experiencing extreme harm, deprivation, and suffering.

WHAT AMAN AFFIRMS

- We witness suffering without turning away — refusing to insulate ourselves from the pain of others.
- We stand in solidarity with all who suffer, treating every life as precious and sacred.
- We commit to justice, healing, and transformation — not as abstraction, but as living intention.
- Whatever happens to one being happens to all of us spiritually — we are one human family.

- Prevents spiritual numbness — keeps the heart awake to the world's condition.
- Music supports the practice by uplifting and attuning the heart to compassion.

KEY TEACHINGS

"We wish to be part of a transformation that heals these insufferable wounds, that mends the breaches, that doesn't allow any life to be disregarded as less than precious."

"Whatever we do, bring our heart to it."

"We want to witness what others are going through, we don't want to turn away from it, we want to be in solidarity, and we take it very seriously."

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Each day of Suluk begins with the prayer **Amān** — acknowledging that all is not well in the world, that there is great suffering, violence, and injustice in our time. Amān is the prayer that holds the earth's heartbreak with compassion before turning toward the divine.

This prayer serves as a bridge between worldly awareness and divine connection, honoring the reality of suffering while seeking divine protection and guidance.

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Prayer of the Artificer — Blessing Devices

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

Our devices (computers, phones) are vibrationally near to our aura and consciousness. They are made of metallic ores from the earth, shaped by generations of human ingenuity — and can be regarded as having spiritual quality.

THE PRAYER

Place fingertips on the device and recite:

"Oh, Artificer of the heavens and the earth, bless this artifact. Shower it with Thy love and light, and let it glorify Thy holy name. Amen."

UNDERSTANDING

Our homes and devices become extensions of ourselves, imbued with our thoughts and intentions — and can be treated as mirrors of our consciousness.

The internet is a mirror of the human condition — full of troubled impressions and unawakened impulses. Rather than fleeing it, the path calls us to meet it wisely and transformatively, navigating it with awareness.

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Saum — Prayer of Repose

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia gave line-by-line commentary on the Saum prayer, illuminating the meaning of each phrase. The prayer can be performed with or without movements; the movements make it embodied.

FULL TEXT OF SAUM

Praise be to Thee, Most Supreme God,

Omnipotent, Omnipresent, All-pervading, the Only Being.

Take us in Thy Parental Arms, Raise us from the denseness of the earth.

Thy Beauty do we worship, To Thee do we give willing surrender.

Most Merciful and Compassionate God, The Idealized Sovereign of the whole humanity,

Thee only do we worship, and toward Thee alone do we aspire.

Open our hearts toward Thy Beauty, Illuminate our souls with Divine Light.

O Thou, the Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty!

All-powerful Creator, Sustainer, Judge, and Forgiver of our shortcomings,

Sovereign God of the East and of the West, of the worlds above and below,

And of the seen and unseen beings.

Pour upon us Thy Love and Thy Light,

Give sustenance to our bodies, hearts, and souls,

Use us for the purpose that Thy Wisdom chooseth,

And guide us on the path of Thine Own Goodness.

Draw us closer to Thee every moment of our life,

Until in us be reflected Thy Grace, Thy Glory, Thy Wisdom, Thy Joy, and Thy Peace. Amen.

LINE-BY-LINE COMMENTARY

"Praise be to Thee, Most Supreme God"

The first gesture opens the chest — a physical act of glorification, not intellectual. Gather all impulses of thankfulness and adulation from throughout your life and offer them in the most universal, unbounded terms. We were born for this.

"We were born for this — born for glorification, and in the absence of it, we desiccate, we dry out, become brittle."

"The praise that we offer to the One comes from the One, returns to the One, flows through all things."

"Omnipotent, Omnipresent, All-pervading, the Only Being"

Omnipotent — all energy in the universe is endlessly transferred and ricochets through the cosmos; all emanations of one Kudrat (power/nature). This is the one's constant expression.

Omnipresent — not far away; closer to us than we are to ourselves; equally close to someone on the other side of the world.

All-pervading — not confined to spirit or matter; ubiquitous throughout the entirety of the tricosm.

"Take us in Thy Parental Arms"

Parental arms are a code for nurturance itself, love itself — invoking our first experience of being held. Not sentimental but deeply cosmic — the embrace of the soul by its Source.

"Parental arms are a code for nurturance itself, love itself."

"Raise us from the denseness of the earth"

Not a rejection of material existence — a call to remember the subtle while living in the dense. We have undergone incarnation from sheer spiritual light, through the imaginative self (nafs), into physical form. Too often we suffer forgetfulness and become alienated from the formless dimension of our being. This prayer calls us to reintegrate all levels.

"Through an imaginative form, the soul began to think itself. And in the process, too often we've suffered forgetfulness — we've become alienated from the formless dimension of our being."

"Thy Beauty do we worship — To Thee do we give willing surrender"

All surrender to beauty willingly and to power unwillingly. The surrender evoked here is chosen — moved by the splendor and meaningfulness of the divine. This is the surrender of beauty.

"All surrender to beauty willingly and to power unwillingly. Unwilling surrender is disgrace, is humiliation, a violation of our freedom. But that surrender which is chosen — because one is moved by the splendor — that is the surrender of beauty."

"Most Merciful and Compassionate God (Rahman and Rahim)"

These two attributes signify the primal motive of creation itself. Mercy (Rahman) — the outpouring of existence. Compassion (Rahim) — the nurturing care that sustains it.

"This whole world could have had no other cause, no other motive force, than that of mercy and compassion."

"The Idealized Sovereign of the whole humanity"

None of us can see the Divine as it is — it would be like looking into the sun. Instead, we each look into the lake of our heart and find the reflection particular to our own need and aspiration. The Divine ideal is mirrored uniquely in each heart.

"We each look into the lake of our heart to seek your reflection — and the reflection that meets us there is our own highest vision of truth."

AFTER THE PRAYER

After every practice, linger with what has arisen. The radiance, the atmosphere, the silence that follows is just as valuable as the practice itself.

"What comes at the end of the prayer is just as valuable — the radiance, the atmosphere, the silence — just as valuable as what is happening during the practice."

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

"Find the place of your strength — and then offer your obeisance."

1. **Palms forward** — releasing weight from the shoulders, opening the chest, letting air in. *"Praise be to the most supreme God."*
2. **Hands draw closer together** — *"Omnipotent, omnipresent, all-pervading."*
3. **Hands come down to sides** — *"The Only Being. Take us in Thy parental arms."*
4. **Bend forward, hands on knees** — *"Raise us from the denseness of the earth."*
5. **Rise, then lean forward with palms extended toward the ground** — *"The only do we worship. Toward the alone do we aspire."*
6. **Hands together at waist** — *"Most merciful and compassionate God, the idealized sovereign of the whole humanity."*
7. **Open the heart center (Qalb)** — *"Open our hearts toward Thy beauty. Illuminate our souls with divine light."*
8. **The Qalb-Ruh connection, then Khafi-Nafs connection** — invoking the subtle anatomy.
9. **Final surrender** — *"Pour upon us Thy love and Thy light… Draw us closer to Thee every moment of our life until in us be reflected Thy grace, Thy glory, Thy wisdom, Thy joy and Thy peace. Amen."*

Pir Zia mentions that there are two versions of the Saum prayer:

1. **Standing version** — the version practiced in these classes, where the prostration is performed *"in the air"* with a bow while standing
2. **Prostrating version** — where *"one is going right down onto the ground and prostrating with your forehead"*

"Thy beauty do we worship — now that the hands are forward, palms facing the ground. There's another version of Saum in which one is going right down onto the ground and prostrating with your forehead. We're doing the standing version for now. So even the prostrating is just in the air. Thy beauty do we worship. To thee do we give willing surrender."

The prostration — whether standing or full — enacts a surrender to divine beauty:

"All surrender to beauty willingly and to power unwillingly. But as we're bowing down, it's the beauty of the divine that's eliciting our found surrender."

"Unwilling surrender is disgrace, it's humiliation, it's a violation of our freedom. But that surrender which is chosen, and it's chosen because one is moved by the splendor, by the meaningfulness of what sweeps you up and brings you back to the truth of it all, that is the surrender of beauty."

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The Invocation

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Toward the One, the Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty, the Only Being, United with all the Illuminated Souls Who form the Embodiment of the Messenger, the Spirit of Guidance.

Pir Zia gave an extended teaching on the meaning of each phrase of the Invocation.

TURNING TOWARD THE ONE

The Invocation turns attention toward the Oneness that excludes nothing — everywhere, always. It names three qualities that naturally align us with this Oneness:

Love — self-overcoming devotion; the melting away of self-regard in encounter with what lifts consciousness to its highest awareness.

Harmony — when self and other exist, they discover a music of unfolding melodies and relationships, not static but alive.

Beauty — what is born of love and harmony; mysterious and yet intimately present; spellbinding and transformative.

"The ways of being that naturally bring us closest to the oneness are the qualities of love, harmony, and beauty."

NATURE OF THE SOUL — ALL SOULS ARE LUMINOUS

The phrase *"United with all the illuminated souls"* does not mean only some souls are illuminated. Every soul is light by essence — already luminous. Awakening is the process of coming to terms with this truth, embodying it, and enacting it.

"The soul itself is light. All souls are luminous and illuminated. Awakening is the process of coming to terms with this, embodying it, enacting it."

AWAKENING AS COMPANIONSHIP

Turning toward the One is not an isolated act — it puts us in the company of all beings on all planes who are awakening. We are inspired by those who have awakened and transmitted this reality; together all beings are advancing toward this realization, each at a different juncture.

THE RASOOL — THE MESSENGER

The Divan of Bodhisattvas, prophets, saints, and sages — past, present, and future, on all planes — forms the embodiment of the Messenger. Each has a particular gift and work, but the common ground is Awakening itself, wakefulness, and the glorification of the divine.

- The Rasool embodies the soul, mind, and body of the universe — together as a tricosm
- The Rasool is the mirror in which the Divine Being beholds Divinity's own face
- The common ground among all prophets, saints, sages, and bodhisattvas is Awakening itself

"Each bodhisattva has a particular gift and a particular work, but there is a common ground which is universally shared, which is Awakening itself."

"The messenger embodying the spirit of guidance — the mirror in which the Divine Being beholds Divinity's own face."

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

"The Spirit of Guidance is the first of creation, the cosmic being — the mirror of the Absolute."

The Invocation first invokes the One Being — the absolute — and then evokes the light of guidance that is the essence of creation. There is a soul of souls, a mind of minds, a body of bodies: not the infinite absolute itself, but the wholeness composed of all souls, all minds, all bodies — the cosmic being that is the first of creation and the mirror of the absolute.

The criterion for right from wrong is the wholeness of the cosmic being — in whom all poles are balanced and every individual has a place within the totality. The Spirit of Guidance is personified in those human beings who awaken to life's purpose, work together, serve, and advance the ongoing revelation of the divine in creation.

"There's a soul of souls, a mind of minds, a body of bodies — still created, still ephemeral, not the infinite one that is all and everything, but rather the essence of creation."

We say the Invocation to crystallize this vision — to orient ourselves at the start of each session toward the absolute and the soul of creation.

Morning Practice: Pir Zia recommends saying the invocation when you wake up — so the very first idea, the very first words that come from your mouth consist of this orientation to the absolute and to the soul of creation.

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Khatum — The Closing Prayer

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

All Suluk gatherings close with the Khatum — a prayer of gratitude toward everyone visible and invisible who has enabled the work, ultimately toward the One beyond all names and forms.

O Thou, Who art the Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty,

The Sovereign of heaven and earth,

open our hearts, that we may hear Thy Voice,

which constantly cometh from within.

Disclose to us Thy Divine Light,

which is hidden in our souls,

that we may know and understand life better.

Most Merciful and Compassionate God,

give us Thy great Goodness,

Teach us Thy loving Forgiveness,

Raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us,

Send us the Peace of Thy Divine Spirit,

And unite us all in Thy Perfect Being.

Amen.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

O Thou,

Who art the Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty,

The Sovereign of heaven and earth,
open our hearts, that we may hear Thy Voice,
which constantly cometh from within.
Disclose to us Thy Divine Light,
which is hidden in our souls,
that we may know and understand life better.
Most Merciful and Compassionate God,
give us Thy great Goodness,
Teach us Thy loving Forgiveness,
Raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us,
Send us the Peace of Thy Divine Spirit,
And unite us all in Thy Perfect Being.
Amen.

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The Amen Gesture - Physical Cascade Practice

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

At the end of the daily prayers, we always say Amen and lift our hands as if to take the whole sum of resonance that has emerged in the prayer. You take it into your hands as in a vessel and lift it up over your head and pour it down as a cascade.

The cascade washes over the body in sequence:

- Face
- Neck
- Shoulders
- Chest

The accumulated resonance of the entire prayer is physically received through this gesture.

UNDERSTANDING AMEN

The word Amen is shared across the three Abrahamic traditions: Amin (Judaism), Amen (Christianity), Ameen (Islam) — the same root, the same word.

"It comes from the same root as the word Aman that we just intoned. It's related to the word Amana — the Covenant. It bespeaks faithfully upholding a trust, respecting a covenant older than time, a fundamental agreement between ourselves and the Absolute."

You'll notice that the syllables themselves have an effect — the vibrational impact of Amen is experiential, not merely semantic.

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Salawat — The Complete Form

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The class rose and the full Salawat was offered — the gender-inclusive prayer of the Inayatiyya, naming the divine through feminine and masculine sacred figures across all traditions.

SALAWAT

Most gracious Sovereign,
Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,
we greet Thee with all humility.
Thou art the First Cause and the Last Effect,
the Divine Light and the Spirit of Guidance,
Alpha and Omega.
Thy Light is in all forms,
Thy Love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.
Allow us to recognize Thee in all Thy holy names and forms:
as Sita and Rama, as Radha and Krishna,
as Parvati and Shiva, as Tara and Buddha.
Let us know Thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham,
as Deborah and Solomon, as Anahita and Zarathustra,
as Asiya, Aaron, Maryam and Moses,
as Mary and Jesus, Khadija and Muhammad,
and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy Past,
Thy Presence deeply enlightens our being,
and we look for Thy blessing in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God!

Thou Whose heart constantly reaches upward,

Thou comest on earth with a message,

as a dove from above, when Dharma decays,

and speakest the Word that is put into Thy mouth,

as the light filleth the crescent moon.

Let the star of the Divine Light shining in Thy heart

be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees.

May the Message of God reach far and wide,

illuminating and making the whole humanity

as one single family in the Parenthood of God.

Amen.

MURSHID'S CLOSING PRAYER

"Thou art the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty. The liege of heaven and earth."

"Open our hearts that we may hear thy voice, which constantly cometh from within."

"Disclose to us thy divine light, which is hidden in our souls, that we may know and understand life better."

"Most merciful and compassionate God, give us thy great goodness, teach us thy loving forgiveness, raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us."

"Send us the peace of thy divine spirit and unite us all. Thy perfect being."

CLOSING BLESSING — PIR ZIA

May your heart be filled with heavenly joy.

May your soul be illuminated with divine light.

May your spirit unfold the divine message.

May you go on in the spiritual path.

May God's peace abide with you. Forever and evermore.

Amen.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Pir Zia explains: *"Salawat is an expansion of the original form [Salat] in which some of the syzygy, some of the constellations of beings who stood at the center of the dispensation of a wave of prophetic revelation at various times and places in history — that these beings are mentioned."*

Syzygy = celestial alignment — constellations of sacred beings at the center of each wave of prophetic light.

Most gracious Sovereign,
Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,
we greet Thee with all humility.
Thou art the First Cause and the Last Effect,
the Divine Light and the Spirit of Guidance,
Alpha and Omega.
Thy Light is in all forms,
Thy Love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.
Allow us to recognize Thee in all Thy holy names and forms:
as **Sita and Rama**, as **Radha and Krishna**,
as **Parvati and Shiva**, as **Tara and Buddha**.
Let us know Thee as **Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham**,
as **Deborah and Solomon**, as **Anahita and Zarathustra**,
as **Asiya, Aaron, Maryam and Moses**,
as **Mary and Jesus, Khadija and Muhammad**,
and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy Past,
Thy Presence deeply enlightens our being,
and we look for Thy blessing in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God!
Thou Whose heart constantly reaches upward,
Thou comest on earth with a message,
as a dove from above, when Dharma decays,
and speakest the Word that is put into Thy mouth,
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Let the star of the Divine Light shining in Thy heart
be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees.
May the Message of God reach far and wide,
illuminating and making the whole humanity
as one single family in the Parenthood of God.

Hindu Tradition:

- Sita and Rama
- Radha and Krishna
- Parvati and Shiva
- Tara and Buddha

Abrahamic Traditions:

- Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham
- Deborah and Solomon
- Asiya, Aaron, Maryam and Moses
- Mary and Jesus
- Khadija and Muhammad

Zoroastrian Tradition:

- Anahita and Zarathustra

The expanded Salawat that names the Ahl al-Bayt constellations explicitly, including female figures alongside the named prophets:

Most gracious Sovereign, Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,

We greet Thee with all humility.

Thy Light is in all forms, Thy Love in all beings:

in a loving mother, in a kind father,

in an innocent child, in a helpful friend,

in an inspiring teacher.

Let us know Thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham;

as Deborah and Solomon;

as Anahita and Zarathustra;

as Asiya, Aaron, Maryam, and Moses;

as Mary and Jesus;

Khadija and Muhammad —

and in many other names and forms,

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Most gracious Sovereign, Messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,

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Thy Light is in all forms, Thy Love in all beings:

in a loving mother, in a kind father,
in an innocent child, in a helpful friend,
in an inspiring teacher.

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Part I · Chapter 2

CHIVALRIC RULES & IRON RULES

The Ethical Foundation of the Path

The Chivalric Rules and Iron Rules form the moral skeleton of the Suluk journey. Pir Zia introduced these rules as mirrors for self-refinement — each one revealing a subtler layer of the ego's tendency and the soul's aspiration.

6 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The Chivalric Rules Overview and Rule 1 - Make No False Claims

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

OVERVIEW OF THE 40 RULES

40 rules over 40 days: 10 Iron, 10 Copper, 10 Silver, 10 Golden. Each rule is a choice, not an obligation.

"These rules are yours to pledge yourself to when and if the rule lights up your conscience. No one is enforcing these ways of being. The rules consist of reminders of possibilities which, if we choose to pledge to them, will remind us in times when we might be likely to become distracted."

"Each rule is a prism, a magnifying glass, for investigating how we truly wish to live — and then living it."

RULE 1: MY CONSCIENTIOUS SELF, MAKE NO FALSE CLAIMS

"My conscientious self, make no false claims."

Personal Reflection

"You could just look back over the last week or so. Is there something that you might have said — and now you look back and you see: why did I say that, it wasn't really true? Just said it. It seemed the easiest thing to say, or some part of me wanted to make a good impression."

Application

- The rule doesn't require saying harsh things — staying discreetly quiet is always an option
- It does mean always speaking in sincere accordance with all that one knows
- Consider the *"cost to the light of your own integrity — that pure transparency that is available to you when you are aligned, when your speech actually lines up with your true experience of reality."*

THE PLEDGE RITUAL

"I'm going to say the rule once, and we're going to close our eyes. No one is looking at anyone else. And then if you've come to the decision that you'd like to take this on — then the second time I say it, you say it too. You join your voice with mine. And if you feel you're not sure that you want to make that commitment, then it's just fine. Just don't say it and just listen and take it into your own reflection."

"Those commitments that truly do represent your ideal and which move you and which you know will bring into blossom with greater fullness who you truly are — making that commitment is a very powerful thing."

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The Chivalric Rules and Day 1 Rule

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The Chivalric Rules are a daily spiritual and ethical practice for the 40 days of Suluk. There are 40 rules in four categories of 10 each: Iron Rules, Copper Rules, Silver Rules, and Golden Rules.

NATURE OF THE RULES

- **Not about obedience** — each rule is a choice, a personal pledge, not an external imposition
- **Each rule is a prism** — a magnifying glass to investigate how one truly wishes to live
- **The purpose** — to unite our ideals with our day-to-day way of being
- **Rules begin with "My conscientious self"** — no one is imposing; one is inviting oneself

THE RULE FOR C2 — DAY 1

"My conscientious self, make no false claims."

This rule concerns authenticity in speech: how we represent ourselves and reality to others. It is a commitment to speak truthfully, sincerely, and honestly — not to say what is not true, even for short-term personal benefit or convenience.

Guidelines

- **Silence is always an option** — the rule does not require harshness, only the absence of untruth
- **Applies only to oneself** — we are not involved in anyone else's decisions
- **Even non-adoption becomes a contemplation** — what are the circumstances where untruth seems justified?
- **The cost of false claims** — even when no one is harmed, there is a cost to the light of one's own integrity

How the Rule is Received

The rule is received communally: Pir Zia says it once with eyes closed; those who choose to pledge join their voice the second time. Those who are uncertain simply listen and reflect.

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Iron Rule 2 - Speak Not Against Others in Their Absence

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"My conscientious self, speak not against others in their absence."

This rule addresses the common tendency to make critical or mocking remarks about someone when they are not present — reasoning that *"no harm is done"* since they cannot hear. Pir Zia dismantled this reasoning:

WHY THIS RULE MATTERS

- We are all interconnected — thoughts and words carry vibrations that reach others even across distance, consciously or not.
- Beneath the visible surface, life is a web of pulsing vibrations. When we think harshly of someone and verbalize it, it is heard one way or another.
- The keyword is *"against"* — not all speech about others is forbidden, but speech that diminishes, mocks, or criticizes in ways one would not say in their presence.

THE CRITERION

"If we're going to speak about someone, is it possible to imagine them in the room and think of them as a soul as well as a body — and then speak?"

"How would you speak about someone in the presence, not only of that person, but of the human being who is the exemplar of your highest ideals — and in the presence of all the bodhisattvas, and in the awareness of the divine immanence?"

NUANCE IN PROFESSIONAL CONTEXTS

In positions of responsibility, addressing problematic behavior involving colleagues — sometimes confidentially — may be necessary. This rule does not prohibit that. It calls for clarity, dignity, and mindfulness: free of unnecessary negativity or surplus sentiment, speaking as one would speak in the person's presence.

THE SPIRIT OF THE RULE

- Not a prohibition only — each rule is a contemplation, an invitation to refined ethical attention.
- Naturalness and consideration are not opposites — speak with friends, be merry, speak of life, but with a wakeful heart.
- Speak with recognition of the divinity in every human being.

INSPIRATION FROM NOOR-UN-NISA

Noor-un-Nisa Inayat Khan's saying, recalled by her friend Jeanne Overton Fuller:

"I never speak ill of a flower for fear of offending the fairy that is doing its best to make the flower beautiful."

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Iron Rule 3 - Do Not Take Advantage of Ignorance

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"My conscientious self, do not take advantage of a person's ignorance."

The first two rules relate to speech: make no false claims (Rule 1), and speak not against others in their absence (Rule 2). A person might take refuge from both by simply staying silent. But silence is not always the ethical position.

WHEN TRANSPARENCY IS REQUIRED

If you are trading or selling something and know a salient fact the other person would need in order to make an informed decision — staying silent is itself a form of deception. If they would not have made the transaction knowing this fact, they must be told.

- Transparency and fairness in all dealings
- Truth will eventually be revealed — attempts to conceal are ultimately futile
- The rule is a reminder to be forthcoming, transparent, and fair, not merely to avoid outright lies

"Everything's eventually going to come to light — whether it's in this world or in the next world, it doesn't matter. So trying to hide a relevant fact… there's going to be a reckoning sooner or later."

THE POWER OF COMMITMENT

These rules may seem obvious. But that is precisely the point — taking up a rule and practicing it magnifies our choices in a way we might otherwise overlook. Making a commitment to what we already know is right is a very powerful act.

"Taking up the rule, practicing it, magnifies our choices in a way that otherwise we might overlook. Things that are self-evident — making a commitment to them is a very powerful thing."

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The Fourth Iron Rule - Do Not Boast of Your Good Deeds

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"My conscientious self, do not boast of your good deeds."

These rules are really contemplations. They're opportunities for reflection rather than merely do's and don'ts.

LEARNING FROM ALL — EVERYONE IS A TEACHER

"We can find the path of beauty by studying the beauty shown to us in the way of life of those who inspire us. And when a way of being is not so beautiful — there too is a lesson. Instead of blaming a person or succumbing to alienation, we could simply see that in their various ways of being, people are teaching us many things. We have many teachers. Everyone is a teacher."

WHEN DEEDS LOSE THEIR GLOW

When someone performs a genuinely inspiring act and then claims credit for it, the beauty diminishes:

"The deed seems to lose its glow. One isn't so very moved anymore. Whereas that which was done and forgotten, done and left unheralded — it retains a place in our heart. There's a greater elegance in it because it was understated. The action spoke for itself. It didn't need magnifying."

Reflective Questions

- Why is it that one feels the need to call attention to one's actions?
- Whose approval are we seeking?
- And even if one gains the attention of any number of people — what naturalness is lost? What simplicity is lost?

THE OMNISCIENT WITNESS

"That which is widely observed in the world is unheeded by the angels, and that which no one in the world notices, the angels notice."

"When God is the omniscient, omnipresent witness — who else do we need to inform of our actions and intentions?"

"All is already understood from first to last. And when we understand this, we can relax in a certain way. This approval-seeking, this attention-seeking, can relax. There's no one to impress."

"Give so that the left hand doesn't know what the right hand has given."

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The Fifth Iron Rule - Do Not Claim What Belongs to Another

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"My conscientious self, do not claim that which belongs to another."

"These rules, these contemplations can be understood on more than one level."

LEVEL 1 — MATERIAL OWNERSHIP

The obvious level: something is yours only if you were given it, inherited it, purchased it fairly, found it ownerless, or created it yourself. Otherwise — do not claim it. It belongs to another. It would be theft.

- Given / inherited / purchased fairly → yours
- Found with no owner → yours
- Created by you → yours
- None of the above → not yours — do not arrogate it

LEVEL 2 — OWNERSHIP OF IDEAS, TEACHINGS, EXPERIENCE

"How do you know what really belongs to you — in your mind, in your heart? It becomes a living question."

"Just repeating what someone else has said or what someone else has done doesn't seem to suffice. It's not yours — at least not yet."

"Is there a way of living it, of being it, of embodying it, of enacting it? That means you're not just latching on to someone else's experience — you've found your own experience of something, you're really living it."

"It's one thing to be attracted by something interesting, something inspiring, and to identify with it, to quote it, and to associate with it. But is it yours?"

"It can only be yours when you own it, when you stand for it, when it effervesces in the cells of your skin."

WHAT WE TAKE WITH US

"At the moment that we leave this world, the material objects that we've collected — we won't be able to take them with us. They will end up with a relative or sold at a thrift store."

"What will be ours on that day? What will we take with us? Only that which we've taken into our hearts. And nothing else can be claimed."

"Claims are notoriously dubious. Making assertions, making pronouncements — just because one argues something doesn't make it real. What is real? How we live. How we love."

THE COMMITMENT — TWO LEVELS

The commitment operates at two levels:

1. **Material**: not taking anything that isn't yours; being absolutely punctilious in all dealings
2. **Deeper**: being very careful about any kind of assertion — whether verbally or internally — and instead living in the ownership of what is immediately your own felt, tasted apperception of being

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Part I · Chapter 3

BREATH PRACTICES

The Bridge Between Worlds

Breath is the medium through which the soul touches the body and the body touches the soul. Pir Zia taught the soles-breathing practice, the Nazar Par Kadam principle, and the foundational breath teachings across his sessions.

5 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Rightful Breathing Practice

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia led a guided breathing practice with these instructions:

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Sit upright** — shoulders open and relaxed, spine elongated naturally, tailbone rooted to earth, crown lifted to sky
2. **Let the breath enter without forcing** — observe its flow through the nostrils, down the windpipe, filling the lungs and bloodstream
3. **Do not be in a hurry to exhale** — give the whole process its natural time
4. **Observe the exhalation as expansion** — the exhaled breath disperses into the atmosphere; the inhalation as contraction — surrounding air spirals inward, penetrating the cells
5. **Let all muscles, tendons, and bones yield to this flow** — without collapsing — to maximize refreshment, invigoration, calm energy, and clarity

KEY INSIGHT

The chest and belly expand with inhalation and contract with exhalation, while the *"aerial body"* of breath moves in the opposite direction — a vortex flowing in and out.

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The Invisible Rain - Full Body Breath Practice

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia led a guided breath practice using the image of invisible rain — a subtle, continuous flow streaming through the sky, entering through every pore.

THE PRACTICE STEPS

1. **Invisible Rain Visualization** — sense a subtle rain always falling, flowing into you through all pores, the body opening to receive it.
2. **Breath Awareness** — feel a wave coming in with each inhalation; guide breath down the windpipe, filling the lungs.
3. **Postural Alignment** — adjust every vertebra, rib, and muscle gently; find spaciousness without rigidity.
4. **Full-Body Breath** — sense the breath traveling down the arms, through the hips and thighs, into the feet, up through the neck, head, and scalp.

5. **Cellular Awareness** — recognize the body as a vast congregation of cells, floating, humming, thirsting for breath.
6. **Quenching** — feel the thirst of each cell satisfied by the inhalation, cascading right down to the tips of the toes.
7. **Exhalation as Communion** — the cells release what is superfluous to this body, but thirsted for by the green beings — trees, algae, plants. We breathe in concert with all plant life.

KEY IMAGERY

"Each inhalation cascading through the body right down to the tips of the toes, satisfying a deep thirst."

"In this communion, in this participation, breath by breath, there is joy for the cells, and peace, and an inkling of the oneness of all being."

CONNECTION TO DAILY LIFE

Breath shares the characteristics of water — it flows and moves in tides, waves, ripples, and surges.

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Purification Breathing Practice with Emotional Stages

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

POSTURE & AWARENESS

- Sit upright — shoulders open, chest open, eyes closed
- Watch the belly rise and fall; observe the ribs expand on the sides

EXHALATION — RELEASING MURKINESS

“As you breathe out, let the breath go all the way out, gradually rolling out into the distance, like a long carpet unrolling.”

“As you exhale, you're aware of the dust that is flowing out on your exhalation — there's a certain murkiness in the exhalation, a certain opacity. It's not entirely transparent. But you let that murkiness filter out, let it dissipate.”

Emotional dimension of release: *“And it's a relief to let it go. At first when you see it, it might be startling because you didn't realize it was in you — but now you're just happy that it's resolving.”*

INHALATION — INFLUX OF RADIANCE

“Let the incoming breath fill you, pervade you, reaching right down into every cell — as far as the tips of your toes.”

THE SPONGE ANALOGY

"If you would rub a dusty surface with a sponge, the grime would fill the sponge, and then if you would squeeze the sponge in water, the water would become murky."

The body-mind is that sponge. Each exhalation squeezes out what is heavy or clouded. The murky water = impurities being released.

STAGES OF PURIFICATION — PROGRESSIVE

1. **Murkiness visible on breath** — a signal it is departing: 'The very fact that you see it on the breath means that it's departing.'
2. **Murkiness decreasing:** 'The more that you squeeze a sponge, the less dust comes out of it.'
3. **Clear channel:** 'It's just breath itself that's going out. Just a clear channel.'
4. **Emergence of radiance:** 'There's a definite light in the breath, a glow.'

"This wakeful breath is a form of purification — we're washing ourselves."

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The Elemental Purification Ritual

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

STEP 1 — DISCERN THE ELEMENTAL CHARACTER

"Since the character of the burden that you're holding — is it earthy? Is it gritty? Like sand and stone? Or is it aqueous? Is it damp? Perhaps it's fiery — it's hot to the touch. Blistering. Or is it aerial? As light as a breeze and yet heavier than anything else."

- **Earth** — earthy, gritty, like sand and stone
- **Water** — aqueous, damp
- **Fire** — hot to the touch, blistering
- **Air** — as light as a breeze and yet heavier than anything else

Identify the elemental quality and then go to that element in nature to perform the transmutation.

🌿 EARTH — BURIAL

1. Go to a place and ask its permission — address the spirit of the place: 'Will you receive and break down, transform this piece of energy I've been carrying?'
2. If there is no assent, respect the answer and find another place until you find the place that will accept it

3. Dig a hole. Give the energetic imprint — that charge, that impression — into a form already on the brink of dissolution. Something ready to rot into the earth: an autumn leaf, whatever form is willing to partner in the transmutation
4. Bury it. Cover the whole with earth. Feel with conviction: you have finished something, you have ended something
5. Walk away. Do not turn and look back

🌊 WATER — POURING

1. Go to a stream or the seashore. Bring a little portion of water willing to carry with it what you are letting go
2. Go to a place where the assent is there
3. Pour it out — into the stream, into the ocean — to be washed, dissolved, and swept away on the current
4. Walk away. Do not look back

🔥 FIRE — BURNING

1. Inscribe the impression in some form on a bit of paper — a word, words, a symbol, or any rendering. The inscription could even be entirely by way of concentration
2. The impression is given over to the paper
3. Build a fire when it is there and willing to receive it
4. **GREAT VIGILANCE IS NEEDED**: take great care that your clothing and hair are protected
5. With vigilance and care, give this impression over to the fire. Let it burn away, then let the fire burn down
6. Ensure it is fully extinguished
7. The matter is finished. Do not look back

🌬️ AIR — RELEASE INTO WIND

1. On a windy day, perhaps on a hilltop — find permission
2. Give the impression to something very light: like the seeds of a dandelion — something you can cast into the wind to be swept away
3. Let it go into the current of the wind. Let it be swept into the sky and dissolved into the vast blue
4. Turn without looking back. It is finished

THE POST-RITUAL PURIFICATION PRAYER

After completing the elemental ritual, these words are to be spoken:

I come from a perfect source,
and I am bound for a perfect goal.
The light of the perfect being is kindled in my soul.
I live, move, and have my being in God.
And nothing in the world of the past or present
has power to touch me if I rise above all.

SAFETY AND REVERENCE

"Take care whether you're working with fire or water or air or any element. It's a moment of profound mystical awareness — but also great vigilance — so that you are fully safe and so that the place is respected to the utmost and there is no pollution, physically or subtly."

"There's no pollution because the intention of the giving over of the impression is so clear — and because you are so clear in finding alignment with the place and with the forces that will expeditiously transform the substance."

NATURE'S CYCLICAL WISDOM

"Nature works in cycles, and that which is one creature's refuse can be the basis of the fertility that nourishes another — but only within bounds that are mutually agreeable."

"Everything goes back to the earth. But the question is: what is the manner of giving it back? What is the intention? What is the method? And if it's done with reverence, the Earth powerfully works with us to transform us, purify us."

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Five Aspects of Breath — Complete Review

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia reviewed all five aspects of breath as they had been developed across the five days:

FIRST ASPECT — EXHALATION

"Noticing the breath going out, the exhalation. Letting it go far and wide."

SECOND ASPECT — DEPTH AND BREADTH

"The depth of the inhalation. The breadth of the exhalation — the range of the exhalation."

THIRD ASPECT — CENTERING IN THE BELLY

"Not just breathing shallowly up here, but breathing through the diaphragm right down into the place where etherically the breath begins — and that is just beneath the navel."

FOURTH ASPECT — RHYTHM

"Not only that the out-breath goes out and the in-breath comes in, but that those two answer each other, enhance each other. And a rhythm develops."

"You come to feel it and to know its naturalness — so that when you're far from that rhythm, you're aware you've stepped out of balance."

FIFTH ASPECT — SCOPE OF BREATH

"The scope of the breath is discerning the breath not only in the movement of the air filling you and emptying you, but in the whole life field."

"The physical breath, the movement of the air, is just one example — one effect of an oscillation, a fluctuation that is actually operating on multiple planes of being."

"Not only is your body breathing, your heart is breathing, your soul is breathing. Breathing is this continuous give and take."

"The awareness of the movement of your breath opens you up to the awareness of subtler currents — the electricity in your body, the flashing of electromagnetism, and the tides of the inner worlds."

This fifth aspect of breath is where physical practice opens into the mystic field. The body's breath becomes a window onto the breathing of the soul itself.

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Part I · Chapter 4

CONCENTRATION, VISUALIZATION & MEDITATION

Training the Sovereign Attention

Concentration — the first stage of the Suluk path — is the art of gathering scattered attention into a single point. Pir Zia's sessions covered color concentration, sensory practices, gemstone visualization, jalali and jamali objects, and the multi-dimensional vision teachings.

32 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Standing Posture for Prayer - The Alif Position

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE COMPLETE STANDING POSTURE

Before prayer, establish this foundational posture that embodies the sacred letter Alif:

1. **Feet**: Firmly rooted in the earth
2. **Spine**: Erect like the trunk of a tree
3. **Tailbone**: Send a root deep into the earth
4. **Crown**: Open to the vastness of the sky

THE SYMBOLISM OF ALIF

This posture embodies the **Alif** — the Arabic upright line that symbolizes the number One.

> *"The upright line suggests heaven, perfection, straightforwardness, firmness, life, rising, and unity — as it shows oneness with the whole. The upright line is the first line, and all forms and figures are nothing but the change of direction of that line."*

The Alif position connects earth and heaven, representing the seeker's role as a bridge between the material and spiritual realms.

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The Four Stages of Suluk Method

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Suluk works through four progressive stages, each building upon the previous. These are not separated from daily life but are rehearsals for bringing attentive, heartful presence to every moment.

THE FOUR STAGES

Stage · Name · Description
1 · **Concentration** · Returning scattered attention to presence. The whole of you gathered in one place. Foundation of all prayer, meditation, creation, and love.
2 · **Contemplation** · Dwelling with a quality or state of being. Moving beyond imagery into subtler domains of sensation and feeling.
3 · **Meditation** · Tasting pure essence — beyond quality and form. Experiencing the uncolored essence of being.
4 · **Realization** · Re-entering the visible world with the invisible essence illumining all. Marriage of the visible and the invisible.

THE FOUNDATION: CONCENTRATION

> *"Concentration means the whole of you is in one place. You are not scattered. You are not dispersed. You are not diffused. You are gathered. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can pray. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can meditate. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can create. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can love. The whole of life depends on concentration."*

KHALWAT DAR ANJUMAN

The concept of **Khalwat dar Anjuman** — 'solitude in the crowd' — means that even when meditating in silence, one is never alone. The class meets in the inner worlds through the intention that joins them.

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Color Black Concentration Practice

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

"Attention is a substance that can be moulded into any form, can be given any colour. So let's give it a colour — not a form in this case, just a colour. Colour black. Fill your mind with the colour black. Be blackened inside and out. No other colour appears now, just black itself — ebony, obsidian."

Instructions

1. This is not a time to think about the meaning of black or imagine black things — simply visualize blackness
2. If the mind wanders, return calmly to black, even if it happens 10, 100, 1000 times
3. Let the black dissolve — allow other colours to come
4. At this transition, notice resonances, associations, moods

MURSHID'S NATURE MEDITATIONS ON BLACK

"In the colour black, I feel the depth of Thy being."

"Thou showest in black Thy eternal being."

"In black Thou givest me a proof of being above all changes."

"Who is behind utter darkness? Thy endless self."

"Black is death. Yet life eternal."

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Color Visualization: Black

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"Attention is a substance that can be molded into any form, can be given any color."

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Close the eyes** — settle into stillness
2. **Gather attention** — recognize it as a moldable substance
3. **Fill the mind completely with the color black** — ebony, obsidian. No meanings, no black things, just pure blackness
4. **If the mind wanders** — gently return to black, no matter how many times
5. **Let the black dissolve** — allow other colors or impressions to arise naturally
6. **Notice resonances** — feel associations, moods, or shifts at the transition

MURSHID'S NATURE MEDITATION ON BLACK

"In the colour black I feel the depth of thy being. Thou showest in black thy eternal being. In black thou givest me a proof of being above all changes. Who is behind utter darkness? Thy endless self. Black is death, yet life eternal."

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Gemstone Concentration Practice

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

1. Close the eyes
2. Let a crystalline, translucent gemstone appear before the mind's eye
3. Observe its facets, shape, lustre, glow, and specific hue
4. Let it slowly revolve so it is seen from all sides
5. Avoid associations (value, stories, history) — only direct encounter
6. Let it fade
7. Notice any resonance remaining

“See it as clearly as you can — not by forcing it into a shape, but by inviting its disclosure.”

MURSHID'S GEMSTONE PROPERTIES

"Murshid has given a few indications about the effects of some of them:

- **Sapphire** is conducive to art and inspiration
- **Diamond** promotes righteousness, integrity
- **Topaz** breeds harmony"

UNDERGROUND CAVERNS

"Under the earth, there are whole vast caverns of gemstones, unbeknownst to human beings."

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Gemstone Visualization Practice

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A visualization practice using a translucent precious stone as the object of concentration:

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Close the eyes** — imagine a translucent gemstone (sapphire, diamond, ruby, emerald, or any crystalline stone)
2. **Observe its qualities** — shape, facets, glow, specific hue
3. **Let it slowly revolve** — observing from all sides
4. **Avoid associations** — no thoughts of monetary value or story. Stay with direct perception only
5. **Let the stone fade naturally** once the image is complete
6. **Notice resonances** — subtle feelings, moods, or impressions that arise when the stone disappears
7. **Rest in the afterglow** — without overthinking, simply receiving

NOTES ON STONE QUALITIES FROM MURSHID

- **Sapphire** is conducive to art and inspiration
- **Diamond** promotes righteousness and integrity
- **Topaz** breeds harmony

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Rightful Breathing Practice - The Aerial Body

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

BASIC POSTURE AND APPROACH

- Sit upright — shoulders open, spine elongated, tailbone rooted to earth, crown open to sky
- Watch as breath enters — don't suck it in, let it enter gradually

- Air moves through the nostrils, glides down the windpipe, fills the lungs, fills the bloodstream
- Don't be in a hurry to breathe out — give the whole process its natural time

VISUALIZATION OF EXHALED AIR

“One can almost imagine the molecules of the exhaled air flying out in all directions up into the sky, some resulting down the street.”

THE AERIAL BODY PARADOX

“So the exhalation is a great movement of expansion, even though your chest and belly are contracting as you exhale. And the inhalation is a contraction — the surrounding air spirals in and penetrates your very cells while the chest and belly widen. Can you feel both aspects — the contracting and expanding of the trunk of your body — and at the same time, in a converse direction, the contracting and expanding of your aerial body, that vortex of breath that whirls in and out again?”

PHYSICAL YIELDING

“Let all of your muscles and tendons and bones yield themselves to this flow. By no means collapsing, but adjusting so as to maximize the movement of breath through the body — and the refreshment that this brings, the invigoration, the calm energy, the clarity.”

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Sandpaper Exercise — Touch Practice

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A practice in pure tactile attention:

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Take the sandpaper in your hand**
2. **Close the eyes** — let sight, sound, and other senses fall away
3. **Give whole attention to the fingertips** — feel every ridge, every grain, every prick
4. **Stop rubbing** — remain with the tactile memory
5. **Set it down** — sense the state that remains

MURSHID'S TEACHING ON OBSERVATION

"The first step to concentration is observation. The one who lacks observation cannot concentrate well. Observation depends upon steadiness of mind. And this steadiness can be brought about by interest."

"There is no better way of cultivating one's memory than observation of a single object at a certain time."

KEY INSIGHT: CONCENTRATION AND ETERNITY

"That which your heart meets, in some mysterious way, is introduced into eternity."

- What we attend to with genuine interest lives on in the soul's lasting memory
- What we touch mechanically — without care — leaves no imprint and is gone
- Beings without bodies wonder what it would be like to wear a hand of flesh — reminding us to cherish our human senses

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Sandpaper Touch Concentration and Beings Without Bodies

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

1. Hold the sandpaper
2. Close the eyes and let all other senses fall away
3. Give whole attention to the little ridges of the fingertips and thumb rolling across the sandpaper
4. Feel acutely every little prick, every stab of a minute grain of sand
5. Stop, set it down, and sense your state

MURSHID ON OBSERVATION AND CONCENTRATION

“The first step to concentration is observation. The one who lacks observation cannot concentrate well. Observation depends upon steadiness of mind. And this steadiness can be brought about by interest. Those who have no interest in anything or anybody have no steadiness of mind.”

“As long a time a person observes an object, so long in proportion its memory lasts. There is no better way of cultivating one's memory than observation of a single object at a certain time. The observant show by their very looks a powerful will, a steady mind, and a capacity for concentration.”

Traditions That Teach This Secret

Murshid names two traditions: **Bhakti Yoga** (Hindu) and **Tasawur Murshid** (Sufi).

BEINGS WITHOUT BODIES - A PROFOUND TEACHING

"There are beings who don't wear bodies. If they haven't yet incarnated — maybe some of them never will incarnate. They wonder very much what it would be like to wear a hand of flesh and to have in their fingers the grid of sand and to rub it. That's something that right now we can feel. And we won't always be able to feel this. The sand may go numb. We may — the body itself may dissolve. We don't know when."

"But wherever we are, in whatever realm, to meet that realm with the whole of our being, with the whole of our interest, with the whole of our love — that's concentration."

THE ETERNITY OF HEART-MET EXPERIENCE

"That which you experience but you don't really experience because your heart's not in it — when it's gone, it's gone. But that which your heart meets — in some mysterious way, it's introduced into eternity."

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Sensus Communis — The Common Sense

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia introduced the classical philosophical concept of Sensus Communis (Latin: the sense within all senses) as the foundation of concentration.

KEY PRINCIPLES

- **Five senses** — sight, hearing, taste, smell, touch — are all channels of one sensation
- **Sensation converges at one point** — the Sensus Communis, the common sense
- **Synesthesia** — when the senses criss-cross (hearing a color, seeing a taste) — is evidence of their common root
- **Ilm-e-Huzuri** — knowledge by presence — is the Sufi name for this faculty of pure attention
- **Even in sleep or death**, the light of attention continues, turned inward

"If you give attention to attention, then it flourishes, it blossoms, it becomes very luminous."

CONNECTION TO HAZRAT (PRESENCE)

This is why great beings are addressed as Hazrat (from Huzur, meaning presence). Murshid is Hazrat Inayat Khan — one in whom presence is profoundly embodied.

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The Invisible Rain Breath Practice

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia led this guided breath practice using the image of invisible rain — a subtle, continuous flow streaming through the sky, entering through every pore.

THE COMPLETE PRACTICE

1. Invisible Rain Visualization

Sense a subtle rain always falling, flowing into you through all pores, the body opening to receive it.

2. Breath Awareness

Feel a wave coming in with each inhalation; guide breath down the windpipe, filling the lungs.

3. Postural Alignment

Adjust every vertebra, rib, and muscle gently; find spaciousness without rigidity.

4. Full-Body Breath

Sense the breath traveling down the arms, through the hips and thighs, into the feet, up through the neck, head, and scalp.

5. Cellular Awareness

Recognize the body as a vast congregation of cells, floating, humming, thirsting for breath.

6. Quenching

Feel the thirst of each cell satisfied by the inhalation, cascading right down to the tips of the toes.

7. Exhalation as Communion

The cells release what is superfluous to this body, but thirsted for by the green beings — trees, algae, plants. We breathe in concert with all plant life.

KEY QUOTES

"Each inhalation cascading through the body right down to the tips of the toes, satisfying a deep thirst."

"In this communion, in this participation, breath by breath, there is joy for the cells, and peace, and an inkling of the oneness of all being."

CONNECTION TO WATER

Breath shares the characteristics of water — it flows and moves in tides, waves, ripples, and surges.

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Visualization - Calling a Loved One

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A concentration practice led by Pir Zia:

THE PRACTICE

1. **Think of a person dear to you**
2. **Let their name resound in the mind**
3. **Allow their face and form to emerge from the name**
4. **Let the form dissolve back into the name**
5. **Rest with the residue of the encounter**

This practice demonstrates how concentration can work with memory, visualization, and the subtle connections between beings.

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Visualization Practice — Calling a Loved One

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

Pir Zia led this brief concentration practice as an exercise in visualization and mental focus.

STEPS

1. **Think of a person dear to you**
2. **Let their name resound in the mind**
3. **Allow their face and form to emerge from the name**
4. **Let the form dissolve back into the name**
5. **Rest with the residue of the encounter**

PURPOSE

This practice develops the faculty of concentration through the natural magnetism of love and connection, using visualization to strengthen mental focus and inner sight.

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Breath Visualization Through Soles of Feet

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A lying-down practice for developing wakeful sleep — the foundation of all future contemplation and meditation work.

PREPARATION

- Lie down on the ground — not on a bed. The ground enhances connection to the earth and stabilizes subtle energy flow
- Lie on your back with arms and legs fully extended. Do not bend knees or elbows — let all limbs rest completely
- Enter the deepest possible relaxation while remaining fully awake — this is wakeful sleep

THE PRACTICE

1. **Become aware of breath** — not merely as air in and out, but as a larger cosmic process: expansion and contraction, assimilation and disgorgement
2. **Recognize breath** as the medium linking all cycles: spring and fall, sleeping and waking, birth and death, inner and outer worlds
3. **Place attention** on the soles of the feet as a passageway between inside and outside
4. **Inhale through the soles** — receive an influx of subtle breath, prana, etheric breeze. Let it flow up the legs, through the midsection, chest, arms, and head, filling the body completely
5. **Gentle transition** — do not hold the breath, do not rush the exhale. A smooth, unhurried flow between inhalation and exhalation
6. **Exhale through the soles** — trace the departure of energy as it drains down the legs and out through the feet into the ground

Duration: approximately 10 minutes at a time. No note-taking during practice — simply be with the experience.

KEY TEACHING

"As though you would lie down on the seashore with your feet pointing out to the sea — a wave comes in, washes over you, fills you, first striking the soles of your feet and then pervading you completely. And then the wave drains back out into the sea."

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Color Visualization Practice - White

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A visual concentration exercise using the color white as the focal point to train the mind in focus, steadiness, and self-observation.

THE TWO APPROACHES

Approach 1 — Replace: Leave behind all the hues seen behind closed eyelids and replace them with white, summoned from memory or from within.

Approach 2 — Amplify: From the medley of colors naturally visible, pick out the grains of white and promote, increase, and maximize white until it prevails and all other colors fade away.

THE PRACTICE

1. Close the eyes — observe the natural mixture of hues behind the eyelids
2. Choose your approach (replace or amplify) and bring white to the foreground
3. Rest patiently in the vision of pure white — without commentary or elaboration
4. When distracted, return to white gently and patiently, as many times as needed
5. Finally, let the white fade back into the mixture or disappear entirely
6. Sense the impact: how do you feel? What arose — memory, image, or emotion?

SELF-OBSERVATION QUESTIONS

- What thoughts intervened — were they genuinely urgent or simply habitual?
- Did attention leave the color completely, or was the color still present alongside the thought?
- Which was foremost — the color or the thought?
- Were you aware of the switch in the moment, or only afterward?
- How did you return to the color white?

THE ROLE OF LOVE IN ATTENTION

"What enables keen attention is essentially love. We can call it interest, but interest is a manifestation of love."

"Every object that I choose or that is given to me is another opportunity to discover a relationship and a light that was otherwise hidden — light that was hidden until I gave it my care."

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Concentrating on a Flower Practice

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A Jamali-natured concentration object. Even with a Jamali object, both Jalali and Jamali must be brought to the practice.

THE PRACTICE

1. **Settle into ease** — *"There is nowhere to go, nothing to do, no hurry about anything."*
2. **Notice the spirit of agitation** — the impulse that insists the mind must be busy. Simply observe it without obeying.
3. **Be like a calm person in a busy train station** — thoughts are busy travelers; you stand calmly in the center, unaffected.
4. **Jalali:** give attention to a plant — roots in the ground, stalk rising, leaves unfurled. Trace all the way to the flower. Actively observe the shape of petals, the stamen, color, texture, fragrance.
5. **Jamali:** let the active portrayal give way to a gentle embrace of what is shown — an easeful meeting.
6. **Give your goodbye** to the flower. Return to your own quality of attention.

TRANSITION: MOUTH AND NECTAR

After the flower practice, attention shifts inward to the Sensus Communis concentrated in the mouth:

- Move the Sensus Communis inward — bring attention to the tongue and the water of the mouth
- Gently touch the tip of the tongue to the roof of the mouth, then lower it — notice the subtle tang
- *"The yogis call it a nectar — one of the fundamental nectars of the body."*

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Tasting Practice with Cardamom Seed

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A practice in pure sensory awareness using taste as the concentration object — the deepest possible immersion in direct experience.

THE PRACTICE

1. Place a cardamom seed on the tongue
2. Bite once to release the spice — allow the sharp taste to fill the mouth
3. If no cardamom is available — taste the water of the mouth instead

4. At this moment: no thought, no speculation. Only the encounter between awareness and taste
5. Let the taste fill time and space — there is no taster and no tasted. There is only the tasting

WORKING WITH DISTRACTION

The key instruction: **do not fight distractions.** Fighting distractions binds you more tightly to what you are trying to push away.

Instead, cultivate a combination of **interest and indifference:**

Interest — concentrated engagement; drawing awareness inward; making attention palpable.

Indifference — non-attachment; not being consumed by what arises; not grasping or pushing.

"If you fight those distractions, you move further away from the sheer experience."

"What we have to cultivate is a combination of interest and indifference."

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Avoiding the Word "I" - 24 Hour Practice

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

REFLECTION ON THE PREVIOUS TASK

The 24-hour practice of avoiding the word *"I"* revealed two key insights:

1. **How words roll off our tongue** — choosing words requires great and constant attention
2. **How often the self is the constant reference point** in all speech

THE DEEPER QUESTION

The practice opened a deeper question: What is this *"I"* we use so casually hundreds of times a day?

- On one level — the I is a construct, an illusion, a figment of inter-subjective perceptions, all transitory
- On another level — the I is being itself, the fundament of the universe
- It is the whole spectrum — everything in between these two poles

"Who is this I? What is this I?"

"On the one hand, the I is just a construct, just an illusion. On the other side, the I is being itself, the fundament of the universe. And it's everything in between. This word that we use a hundred times a day — its meanings are immense."

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Geographical Orientation - Daily Task

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Know where you stand on the Earth — and stay oriented for 24 hours.

THE TASK

Determine which way is north, south, east, and west. Then stay continuously aware of your geographical situation throughout the day — without relying on technology.

THE PRACTICE

1. Determine which direction is north, south, east, and west from where you are now
2. Know: which way would you walk to reach the nearest seashore?
3. Know: in which direction do the nearest mountains loom?
4. Know: where is the river that runs near your city?
5. Wherever you are — in whatever room, on whatever street — remain situated. Know where you stand on your continent

THE DEEPER TEACHING

Geographical Awareness — knowing directions and locating natural features (rivers, seas, mountains) around oneself.

Embodied Orientation — moving through daily life with spatial consciousness; staying aware of one's place in relation to the continent and Earth.

Technology vs Natural Attunement — GPS and phones have replaced instinctual orientation; we risk losing the felt sense of our place on Earth.

Spiritual Lesson — to be grounded in the world, one must consciously situate the self. Orientation is not just geographical but existential: knowing one's place in the larger whole.

"Take responsibility for our own situatedness on the earth."

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Color Visualization: Yellow - Alchemical Sequence

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The third in the alchemical color sequence: black → white → yellow. This sequence is rooted in Khem (ancient Egypt) and is the basis of alchemy. Yellow symbolizes illumination, clarity, and awakening.

THE PRACTICE

1. **Close the eyes** — invite yellow into the mind's eye
2. **Let yellow gradually fill** the entire field of inner vision — like daylight shining behind the eyelids
3. **Immerse in yellow** — become tinctured by it, like a piece of cloth soaked in golden light. Be stained, dyed, saturated by yellow from within
4. **Observe the precise shade** — ochre, gold, canary yellow. Don't analyze; simply see and experience yellow as purely as possible
5. **Maintain concentration** — whenever the mind wanders, gently return to yellow without frustration
6. **Let go** — after a few minutes, release yellow. Allow it to fade naturally, noticing any lingering afterimage or mood
7. **Reflection** — what did yellow evoke? How would you move through the day in a *"yellow mood"* — radiant, open, bright?

MURSHID'S REFLECTIONS ON YELLOW

- *"In yellow I see the flame of Thy light."*
- *"I see in yellow Thy love and Thy light."*
- *"Thou hast ordained with yellow the earth and Thy heavens."*
- *"Let my heart ripen as a green leaf ripens to yellow."*
- *"I see Thy two wings in the green water and the yellow earth."*
- *"Let the yellow flames of Thy divine light turn my false ego into ashes."*

DAILY PRACTICE EXTENSION

Throughout the day, notice every yellow hue in your environment — a practice of attention.

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Jalali and Jamali: The Star - Celestial Practice

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Building on previous practices with terrestrial objects (gemstone = Jalali / flower = Jamali), we turn to a celestial object — the star — to experience Jalali energy at its most radiant.

THE PROGRESSION

- **Day 1** — Jalali terrestrial: gemstone — firmness, structure, strength, enduring radiance of the earth
- **Day 2** — Jamali terrestrial: flower — delicacy, fragrance, grace, the soft beauty of creation
- **Day 3** — Jalali celestial: star — fierce, radiant, actively burning, the luminous power of divine majesty

TEACHING ON STARS AND FLOWERS

The flowers of the earth and the stars of the sky mirror each other: as starlight shines down, the earth lifts up flowers that beam back at the stars. Flowers are star-shaped. Stars are Jalali; the crescent moon is Jamali.

"The stars are more Jalali than Jamali. The crescent moon is reflective, but the star is actively radiant."

"Earth lifts up flowers that beam back at the stars — so the flowers of the sky are the stars."

STAR VISUALIZATION PRACTICE

1. **Close the eyes** — envision the vast night sky
2. **Choose one shining star** — blazing, burning, radiant with fierce Jalali energy
3. **Come face to face with it** — feel its intensity illuminating your entire being
4. **Breathe in the starlight** — clarity, strength, illumination entering with each inhalation
5. **Breathe out** — dissolve into the star; you become the star you gaze upon
6. **The star recedes** — withdrawing into the night sky as dawn approaches
7. **Rest in the afterglow** — the quiet luminosity that remains within

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Building on previous practices with terrestrial objects (gemstone = Jalali / flower = Jamali), this practice turns to a celestial object — the star — to experience Jalali energy at its most radiant.

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Journey Through the Mind: Sensation → Memory → Imagination

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A guided exploration of the three faculties of mind, building sequentially through the retreat.

THE THREE FACULTIES

1. **Sensation** — the first faculty: presence functioning through the five senses, bringing us face to face with what is physically here now.
2. **Memory** — the second faculty: carrying prior embodied experiences into the present; moving in Malakut, where images no longer wear matter.
3. **Imagination** — the third faculty: creating and discovering images in Malakut; the bridge between the seen and unseen, the known and the becoming.

STEP 1: SENSATION — GATEWAY OF PRESENCE

Bring awareness to the present moment. Notice what the senses are perceiving — temperature, weight, texture, sound.

"Sensation functions through the five senses, bringing us face to face with what is physically here before us — an encounter attended to by presence."

STEP 2: MEMORY — THE LIVING ARCHIVE

Bring to mind a memory that left a deep impression. Let it unfold naturally. The vividness of the memory depends on two things: how present you were then, and how present you are now.

"The more present we were at that time, and the more present we are now, the more vivid the revival of the memory — so much so that one can enter a memory and feel oneself completely there."

Memory is not mere fantasy — it is movement into Malakut, where images exist without physical substance. What once existed outwardly still exists inwardly as image and meaning.

"In memory, we're moving away from what is physically right before us. We're actually moving in the realm of Malakut, where images don't wear matter."

STEP 3: IMAGINATION — ACTIVE PERCEPTION IN MALAKUT

Imagination does not mean unreal whimsy — it means active perception and discovery of images in Malakut. It is the bridge between seen and unseen, known and becoming.

"The third faculty of mind is imagination — which doesn't mean unreal whimsy; it means creating and discovering images in Malakut."

The Exercise: Think of someone you have never met — a teacher, historical figure, or beloved artist. Let their name arise. The name becomes a herald announcing the one it designates. A presence forms. See them vividly — expression, height, color of apparel. If the

picture fades, revive it. Then let the figure pack itself back into the name. Let the name fade into silence. You are left with pure awareness — the ground of all images.

RETURN AND INTEGRATION

Bring awareness back to the physical — touch, taste, smell, hearing, sight. The imaginal and physical are not separate; they interpenetrate. Both levels are equally true.

"I dreamed I was a butterfly, and now I don't know if I'm a man who dreamed he was a butterfly, or a butterfly dreaming he's a man. Both levels are equally true." — Zhuangzi

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Journey Through the Mind: Three Faculties

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A guided exploration of the three faculties of mind: Sensation → Memory → Imagination

THE THREE FACULTIES

1. **Sensation** — the first faculty: presence functioning through the five senses, bringing us face to face with what is physically here now
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The Exercise

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RETURN AND INTEGRATION

Bring awareness back to the physical — touch, taste, smell, hearing, sight. The imaginal and physical are not separate; they interpenetrate. Both levels are equally true.

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Sensory Exercise: Smell (Fire Element)

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The third sensory exercise in the Sensus Communis sequence. Having worked with Touch (Earth — sandpaper) and Taste (Water — cardamom), we now turn to Smell, associated with Fire — for it arises through burning incense, rising vapors, and subtle essences.

THE ELEMENTAL SEQUENCE

- **Touch — Earth**: The most immediate, palpable sense; the whole skin feels it
- **Taste — Water**: Whatever enters the mouth presents taste
- **Smell — Fire**: Subtler than taste; usually only noticed when fragrance is strong, yet always present

THE PRACTICE — ROSE ESSENCE

1. **Close the eyes** — bring attention inward. Ask: *"What is the fragrance of this moment?"*
2. **Lift the paper with rose essence** to the nostrils. Breathe in slowly and deeply
3. **Fill your nostrils with the scent** — fill your whole being with it
4. **Lose yourself in it** — no visualization needed. Don't imagine the rose garden; become the fragrance
5. **Reach the point** where there is no one smelling and nothing being smelled — only fragrance itself, making itself known
6. **Set down the paper** — remain still. The scent lingers as a state of being, not merely an odor
7. **The impression remains** — even hours later you can return to this location in consciousness simply by remembering

KEY TEACHING

"Lose yourself in it, until there is no one smelling and nothing being smelled — only fragrance itself, making itself known."

"You'll always be able to find that location, because it's become your own now."

"The sense of smell is always present, though seldom noticed. By awakening it, we awaken the quality of presence in our lives."

DAILY PRACTICE EXTENSION

Throughout the day notice every subtle variation of fragrance — morning air after rain, dry warmth of sunlit stone, the invisible perfume of leaves, flowers, or wood. Each fragrance is a reminder to awaken.

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Color RED Concentration Exercise

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"See red. Not a red thing, but redness itself — scarlet, crimson, deep and glowing. Let it fill your mind and flood your senses. Let the color red arise within you, not as an object, but as a living atmosphere. Feel how it radiates, how it warms, how it moves through your being."

TWO-PHASE INSTRUCTION

Phase 1: Hold Redness as Living Atmosphere

- Hold redness as living atmosphere

- Sense your state, what is coming through?

Phase 2: Let Red Fade and Notice Resonance

- Let the red fade from the mind's eye
- Note: 'The resonance of red is there'
- How has it left you feeling? Alert, alive, passionate, or tender?

The resonance persists after the color fades.

MURSHID'S WORDS ON RED

In the red color, I see thy glowing countenance.

In red, I see the bleeding of thy heart in sympathy for thy creatures.

Red shows me thy life in its perfect glow.

Red brings life to my hungry heart.

Dye my heart red that it may take the color of thine own life.

DAY-LONG PRACTICE EXTENSION

"So now throughout the day, I would encourage you to notice red wherever it appears. Just let it pop up and strike you wherever it occurs. Take in the mood of it all through the day."

The exercise does not end in the session. Red as a living transmission is to be received continuously through ordinary life.

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Jamali Practice - The Crescent Moon

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

CONTEXT IN THE SEQUENCE

This is the third practice in a sensory/elemental sequence:

1. **Jalali** (radiant, strong) terrestrial object — the precious stone
2. **Jamali** (gentle, beautiful) terrestrial object — the flower
3. **Jamali** (gentle, receptive) celestial object — the crescent moon

THE NATURE OF MOONLIGHT

"The moon that receives the light of the sun and is kindled by it, reflects it. The sunlight in itself is so fiery, so intense. But when sunlight reflects from the moon, it is cooled, becomes gentle and diaphanous."

"You can't stare into the sun, but you can gaze directly at the moon. And to gaze upon the moon is to be calmed, to be cooled, to be immersed in this gossamer light — that reminds you of something very fine, very gentle within your own being."

THE DAY-CYCLE TURN

"When one has spent the whole day talking and writing and giving opinions and projecting thoughts into the world — there's a turn. And now one can just receptively rest."

"Does the moon have any opinions? The moon simply receives the light it's given and sends it onward."

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. **See** a glowing crescent moon hovering in the sky of your mind
2. **Trace** its gentle arc — observe its soft silver hue
3. **Sense** the tenor of its light: calming, receptive, cooling
4. **Embody** its quality: be serene, reflective, receiving light and radiating it softly
5. **Let** opinions, words, and outward projection fall silent — become receptivity itself
6. **Gradually** let the image fade until only the vastness of inner sky remains

REFLECTION AFTER THE PRACTICE

"Where has the crescent gone? It's no less in you now than it was when you saw it. But when you saw it, you manifested it."

"What else lies in wait within you, capable of being manifested at any time?"

"Perhaps the better question would be — what doesn't lie in wait within you, capable of being manifested at any time?"

KEY QUALITIES

- **You become moon-like, become lunar**
- Receptivity without opinion
- Cooling the fiery intensity of day
- Gentle reflection rather than direct projection

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Seeing and the Divine Will - Green Dot Practice

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

CONTEXT: WORKING WITH THE SENSES

This sight practice is part of a series working with the senses one by one — following sandpaper (touch) and cardamom (taste/smell) in prior sessions.

THE PROBLEM OF HABITUAL SIGHT

"Sight is the sense that we use so much that we hardly know we're using it. We take it for granted. It's just as if the world appears. We're not even conscious of looking. The world just shows itself."

"The way we look determines what we see. Our glance has developed in concert with the brain along a track that prioritizes discerning things — picking out this thing and that thing, differentiating one thing from another."

SHIFTING FROM THINGS TO QUALITIES

Instead of identifying objects (window, door), notice qualities: redness, roundness, luminosity, texture. What is a thing but a particular combination of qualities?

"Instead of immediately outlining the boundary of a thing, we discern the ways in which qualities advance and recede and mingle on all of the horizons in a constant flux."

THE LIGHT OF THE GLANCE - MEETING OF LIGHTS

"The impression that reaches your eyes is significant — but just as significant in the act of seeing is the light that goes out through your glance to what you see. Send that light out. Send out two beams. Illuminate what you see. There's a meeting of lights."

"As Jesus said, don't hide your light under a bushel — acknowledge it, utilize it."

VISUAL RAY AWARENESS

"As you open your eyes — beware of the rays, like the headlights of a car, wherever you turn. The sensation is not so different from having a hand by which you can reach out and touch something. You're reaching out through your glance. The ray is going out, touching, and shaking hands with what you see."

GREEN DOT PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Sit upright**, relax the face — no tension in forehead, temples, or jaw
2. **Find the green dot** (or point) on the wall
3. **Without tensing** — reach out through the glance, reach through the air, and touch the point
4. **Let the point glimmer** with the touch of your attention
5. **Hold the steady gaze** for about one minute
6. **Close eyes** — sense your state
7. **Open eyes again** — feel the rays extending outward

RAPTUROUS EYES - THE INVITATION

"Let your eyes become rapturous explorers of the divine manifestation in the visible and invisible worlds, rather than merely habituated reinforcers of preconceived expectations."

"Let your eyes surprise you, delight you. Let your eyes be practitioners of concentration, able to rest for moments at a time on something that in the eyes of the world is of no practical value."

INNER VISION TEST

"What if you were to suddenly, right now, close your eyes? The room around you — can you still see it? If you don't see it anymore, did you really see it before?"

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

This is the third and final stage of the Green Dot concentration practice. Each day the dot has become smaller, refining the focus and training the mind to settle on a single point. After this session, the dot is no longer needed at all.

"The focus is refining itself — it's concentrating on a smaller point. And soon, you won't need the green dot at all."

Pir Zia shared a teaching of Imam Ali that illuminates why the dot has such depth:

- The whole Quran is contained in Surah Fatiha.
- The whole Fatiha is contained in Bismillahir Rahmanir Raheem.
- The whole Bismillah is contained in the Ba.
- The Ba is contained in the point beneath it.

"The very first thing one sees when opening the Quran already contains the whole revelation. It's all in that point. There's a lot in a dot."

The spirit of agitation may arise — the impulse to rip the glance away, to feel restless, bored, tired. The instruction: notice it, do not judge it, but hold the decision to stay.

"It won't always be easy, but we give our whole heart to it. And if we find ourselves distracted, we just keep coming back again and again to the dot."

After this session, no green dot is needed. Simply relax the glance, close the eyes, set your state (tailbone rooted, crown open), then open the eyes — and the point of attention itself remains as the field of awareness.

1. Relax the glance
2. Close the eyes
3. Set your state (tailbone rooted, crown open)
4. Open the eyes — the point of attention itself remains as the field of awareness

The Green Dot practice reinforces the faculty of directed outward attention through the glance.

1. **Stand like a tree** — rooted. Let the weight come down off your shoulders. Breathe well.

2. **The Sensus Communis concentrates itself in the glance** — projected out through both eyes as two beams.
3. **Both beams converge** at the single point where the green dot stands on the wall.
4. **Gaze without rigidity** — jaw relaxed, temples relaxed, shoulders relaxed.
5. **Calm does not numb the mind** — precisely because of the state of calm, the whole care can be given to one point.
6. **Close the eyes** — draw the beams back in. Let the Sensus Communis fill all five senses. Sit down.

"It's a gaze at the point without becoming rigid — and it's not a relaxation that numbs your mind. On the contrary, precisely because of your state of calm, you're able to give your whole care to that one point for a minute."

1. Stand upright but relaxed facing the green dot on the wall
2. Focus the glance on the dot — don't look at anything else
3. Hold steadily for about one minute
4. If the mind wanders, gradually let yourself come back to this moment, this gaze, this point
5. Allow yourself this ease, this simplicity
6. Close eyes, bring the energy back to all five senses
7. Open eyes again and sit down

"Your whole attention goes to that point and that point lights up. Your sensation concentrates itself. All of the senses are concentrated in the Sensus Communis, which functions now first and foremost through the glance. And the glance lands on that point and gives its whole attention there."

A physical concentration practice using an external point of focus:

1. **Setup** — place a green dot on the wall in advance. Stand upright, relaxed, facing it
2. **Fix your gaze on the dot** — direct all attention to that single point
3. **Let the dot become the focal point** — all senses converge in the Sensus Communis, functioning through the glance
4. **If the mind wanders** — gently return without frustration. Stay with simplicity
5. **Completion** — close the eyes briefly; gather the focused energy back into all five senses; open the eyes and sit down

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Sovereignty of Attention - Three Parts

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE SHADOW SIDE OF CONCENTRATION

"What if you're holding in your focus something that depresses you? This is the flip side of concentration — not the concentration that is intentional, but the concentration that takes you over."

THE THREE-PART SOVEREIGNTY

True concentration requires mastery over three aspects:

1. **The ability to choose the giving of your consciousness to something**
2. **The ability to choose the length of that giving**
3. **The ability to choose what you give it to**

THE ART OF RELEASE

"True concentration requires the ability to utterly forget and disown any impression. We don't have to own everything because it met our glance once."

"Every time that you think it again, you're partaking of it, you're claiming it — and you don't need to."

THE TEACHING OF JESUS: EACH SPEAKS WHAT HE OWNS

Once Jesus was walking with disciples when someone began reviling him with crude and insulting words. Jesus said nothing. When the disciples asked why he didn't correct the man, Jesus answered:

> *"Each speaks what he owns."*

Pir Zia explains: *"So Jesus didn't choose to own it himself. That man said it — it belonged to him. He left it at that. Didn't accept it into his own concentration."*

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

There is so much that meets our eyes and ears that we have no need to hold in any way. The principle is simple: don't hold on to anything you don't need to.

"As soon as you let it go, it's just inconsequential — as if it never existed. And what a relief to exhale it and let it go."

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Color Blue Exercise

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

"Let it appear, let it come, show itself — filling you, saturating you, tincturing you. Be dyed blue, like a garment plunged in blue dye, soaking it up in every fiber — till all you see, all you know, is blue."

"You can let the blue expanse that surrounds and fills you gradually dissipate to make room for other colors. It doesn't disappear altogether, but other colors join it."

CONTEMPLATION QUESTIONS

"Sense your stain. What secret does blue hold for you?"

"If you had to explain blue to someone who had never seen the color — but you had to explain blue without recourse to words, just by communicating a state and conveying that frequency to the other person — how would you silently express it?"

MURSHID'S NATURE MEDITATIONS ON BLUE

"In the color blue, I get the glimpse of Thy heavens."

"I see heaven shining out in Thy blue eyes. I behold the blue of Thine eyes in the sky."

"Out of blue comes Thy uplifting influence which raiseth me from earth."

"In blue I see the purity of Thy nature."

"Raise me high in the blue spheres of Thy heaven."

"I feel Thy presence most when all is blue to me."

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Cognitive Styles and Sensory Concentration

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia acknowledged that not all students are suited to visual concentration — that cognitive styles differ, and that any sensory channel is a valid path.

ANY SENSE OBJECT AS PERFECT CONCENTRATION OBJECT

"A sense object in any of the categories is a perfect object of concentration, whatever it is. It could be a note, a musical note, could be a fragrance, could be a taste."

"The practice then would be to stay with something and recreate it in your experience, even after the outer stimulus has disappeared."

EXAMPLE: SOUND PRACTICE

Sound a note on an instrument. When the note fades out — keep hearing the note. Stay with it for five or ten minutes. That itself is concentration.

THE ESSENTIAL PRINCIPLE

"What's less important is the object. Let it be an object that draws you, an object that you love. But the essence of the practice is staying with, lingering over an experience. And not just rushing on — it could be any of the senses."

WHAT WAS WORKED WITH OVER FIVE DAYS

- Concentration — learning what it is and beginning to practice it
- The Glance — focusing through the eyes with awareness, both open and closed
- Visualization — perceiving things and beings, both eyes open (gaze) and eyes closed (inner image)
- The Senses — worked through day by day: smell, taste, sight, hearing
- Five colors worked with across the five sessions (Black, White, Yellow, Red, Blue)
- Five Aspects of Breath worked with throughout the program
- Five Aspects of Mind — Sensation, Memory, Imagination, Will, and Self

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Gazing & Visualization — Crescent Moon + Star

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A two-phase gaze and visualization practice, integrating all the concentration work of the retreat.

PHASE 1 — OPEN-EYED GAZE

1. Stay in the expanded awareness just cultivated.
2. Open the eyes.
3. Direct the gaze to a fixed point on the wall.
4. Hold the gaze steady for a minute.

PHASE 2 — INNER VISUALIZATION

1. Close the eyelids and relax.
2. Visualize the crescent moon — gentle, cool, diaphanous light.
3. Just above the crescent moon: a splendid star, glittering with rays streaking outward.
4. See both the crescent moon and the star together in your mind's eye — held in juxtaposition.
5. Then let the image disappear. Sense your inner state.
6. When ready, open the eyes again.

This practice serves as a crystallization of the entire retreat's concentration arc: from sensory outer attention → to inner visualization → to the awareness of pure Self that holds both.

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Light & Breath Practice — The Orb / Auric Body

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A core visualization practice integrating the fifth aspect of breath with awareness of subtle anatomy.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Let the breath be rhythmic, rooted in the belly, far-reaching and deep.
2. Visualize the breath as a sphere — an orb of light.
3. As you breathe out, watch it expand. As it expands, it fades and thins out.
4. *"At the culmination of your exhalation, that orb simply seems to lose itself in the darkness of space."*
5. As you inhale, it congeals anew. Its circumference shrinks down around you. Its light intensifies.
6. Begin by focusing it in the belly. As you contract it, you can locate its concentrated center anywhere in your body.

SUBTLE ANATOMY — THE AURIC BODY

"As it expands and contracts, it brings to light various contours which aren't merely the visible contours of one's physical body. These lineaments describe subtle structures — subtle anatomy."

"So that increasingly you become aware of a body of light — an Auric body."

"Let it be rhythmic. Let it be rooted in the belly. Let it go far and enter deeply."

SENSORY INTEGRATION — THE ETHERIC BODY

With the Auric body established, Pir Zia connected this subtle awareness back to everyday experience:

"When you're using your senses — whether touching or tasting or smelling, seeing, hearing — you're aware of doing so through the action not only of your obvious physical body, but also through this etheric body immersed in subtle light, breathing light in the way that the physical body breathes oxygen."

This teaching is the integration point of the five days: all sensory practices have been progressively building the student's awareness of this second, etheric layer of perception.

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Part I · Chapter 5

MOVEMENTS, RITUALS & TECHNIQUES

The Body as Sacred Instrument

The Sufi path is embodied. Pir Zia taught the prayer movements, ablutions, daily awareness exercises (like avoiding the word 'I'), and other physical practices that ground the teachings in the body.

12 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Daily Task - Stepping Through Doors with Right Foot First

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

When you step through any door — front door, room to room — be aware of the threshold and step right foot first.

PURPOSE

- Cultivates attention, awareness, and concentration in everyday movement
- Not a lifelong rule — just for today; though you may choose to continue in special moments

IF YOU FORGET

"You might walk from one room to another and then a minute later realize: oh, I just passed through a door and forgot. Don't be hard on yourself — but it's good that you remembered. Keep reminding yourself, even if you make a mistake, keep going."

The act of remembering is itself part of the practice.

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Daily Task: Stepping Through Doors

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The task for Day 1: each time you step through a doorway — any door, any threshold — do so mindfully, with the right foot first.

GUIDELINES

- **Purpose** — cultivates attention, awareness, and concentration in everyday movement
- **Not permanent** — just for today, though the practice may be carried into special moments or pilgrimages
- **If you forget** — do not be hard on yourself; the act of remembering is itself part of the practice
- **Threshold awareness** — stepping through a door is a movement from one space into another; meet it consciously

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Ablutions — Ritual Purification Practice

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

PURPOSE

Ablution is the act of washing parts of the body as a form of ritual purification. It is practiced upon waking and at intervals through the day — especially before prayers or spiritual practices.

THE COMPLETE SEQUENCE

1. **Wash right and left hands** — 3 times each
2. **Rinse the mouth** — 3 times
3. **Sniff water into the nostrils and blow out** — 3 times
4. **Wash the face** — 3 times
5. **Wash arms up to the elbows** — 3 times each
6. **Wash hair, behind the ears, and the neck** — 3 times
7. **Wash feet up to the ankles** — 3 times each

THE SPIRITUAL SIGNIFICANCE

The body is in the shape of a five-pointed star — two hands, two feet, and the head as the five points. Vitalizing these extremities with fresh water stimulates, wakes, cleanses, and purifies.

"You're vitalizing these extremities with fresh water, which stimulates you, wakes you up, but it cleanses and purifies."

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Blessing Devices - Prayer of the Artificer

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Our devices (computers, phones) are vibrationally near to our aura and consciousness. They are made of metallic ores from the earth, shaped by generations of human ingenuity — and can be regarded as having spiritual quality.

THE PRACTICE

Place fingertips on your device and recite:

"Oh, Artificer of the heavens and the earth, bless this artifact. Shower it with Thy love and light, and let it glorify Thy holy name. Amen."

THE UNDERSTANDING

- Our homes and devices become extensions of ourselves, imbued with our thoughts and intentions — and can be treated as mirrors of our consciousness.
- The internet is a mirror of the human condition — full of troubled impressions and unawakened impulses. Rather than fleeing it, the path calls us to meet it wisely and transformatively, navigating it with awareness.

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Saum Prayer Movement Instructions

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Standing upright is itself a practice of concentration — an art the trees have perfected. *"Send a root right down into the depths of the earth."* The movements of the prayer begin from a place of strength, not from being crushed by the world's weight.

"Find the place of your strength — and then offer your obeisance."

THE SEQUENCE OF MOVEMENTS

1. **Palms forward** — releasing weight from the shoulders, opening the chest, letting air in. *"Praise be to the most supreme God."*
2. **Hands draw closer together** — *"Omnipotent, omnipresent, all-pervading."*
3. **Hands come down to sides** — *"The Only Being. Take us in Thy parental arms."*
4. **Bend forward, hands on knees** — *"Raise us from the denseness of the earth."*
5. **Rise, then lean forward with palms extended toward the ground** — *"The only do we worship. Toward the alone do we aspire."*
6. **Hands together at waist** — *"Most merciful and compassionate God, the idealized sovereign of the whole humanity."*
7. **Open the heart center (Qalb)** — *"Open our hearts toward Thy beauty. Illuminate our souls with divine light."*
8. **The Qalb-Ruh connection, then Khafi-Nafs connection** — invoking the subtle anatomy.
9. **Final surrender** — *"Pour upon us Thy love and Thy light… Draw us closer to Thee every moment of our life until in us be reflected Thy grace, Thy glory, Thy wisdom, Thy joy and Thy peace. Amen."*

PRACTICE NOTES

At first the movements feel clunky and require thought. With practice they become fluid and natural — like water, no longer requiring conscious attention as the gestures and words merge into one living prayer.

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Sleep and Waking Practices — Nostril and Threshold Work

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

UNDERSTANDING SLEEP AND MEDITATION

Sleep and meditation are intimately related — sleep is the same process as meditation, with the one difference that in meditation we are awake. Sleep rejuvenates by turning energy inward, guiding us into transcendental spheres, and then gradually outward again.

Waking suddenly from deep sleep disrupts the natural transition through the planes — it is not conducive to wholeness.

The task: bring the outer world and inner world into communication by honoring thresholds.

THE NOSTRIL PRACTICE ON WAKING

The Technique

- **Right side sleep** promotes the left (lunar) nostril — conducive to deep sleep
- **Before waking, shift to the left side** — this activates the right (solar) nostril, preparing for outward daytime consciousness
- This mirrors the threshold practice of stepping through doors right foot first

"As you are nearing the time of waking up, switch sides — and then you emerge out of dreams."

DREAM RECOLLECTION PRACTICE

1. **On waking, pause** — do not leap immediately into the day
2. **Gently bring with you** the most salient images and words of the dream
3. **Adventitious impressions** from the dream — release them; let them dissolve
4. **Meaningful dream content** — carry it into the day and contemplate its significance

THRESHOLD PRACTICES

The Invocation on Waking

"I recommend saying the invocation when you wake up — so the very first idea, the very first words that come from your mouth consist of this orientation to the absolute and to the soul of creation."

Right Foot First

Step out of bed right foot first. The threshold of waking is honored exactly as the threshold of a doorway.

WATER DRINKING PRACTICE

Drinking a glass of water first thing in the morning is recommended. The instruction: **drink it with full awareness of its living-ness.**

- Water flows down from the icy peaks — the purest drink
- Our bodies are most essentially made of this substance
- Drink in thankfulness

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Sleep, Waking and Dream Recollection Practices

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Sleep and meditation are intimately related — sleep is the same process as meditation, with the one difference that in meditation we are awake. Sleep rejuvenates by turning energy inward, guiding us into transcendental spheres, and then gradually outward again.

THE PROBLEM WITH SUDDEN WAKING

Waking suddenly from deep sleep disrupts the natural transition through the planes — it is not conducive to wholeness.

The task: bring the outer world and inner world into communication by honoring thresholds.

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DREAM RECOLLECTION

1. **On waking, pause** — do not leap immediately into the day.
2. **Gently bring with you** the most salient images and words of the dream.
3. **Adventitious impressions** from the dream — release them; let them dissolve.
4. **Meaningful dream content** — carry it into the day and contemplate its significance.

MORNING THRESHOLD PRACTICES

- Say the Invocation upon waking — so the very first words that come from your mouth consist of this orientation to the absolute and to the soul of creation.
- Step out of bed right foot first. The threshold of waking is honored exactly as the threshold of a doorway.

WATER DRINKING PRACTICE

Drinking a glass of water first thing in the morning is recommended. The instruction: drink it with full awareness of its living-ness.

- Water flows down from the icy peaks — the purest drink.
- Our bodies are most essentially made of this substance.
- Drink in thankfulness.

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Daily Task - Avoid the Word "I"

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Do not say the word *"I"* for the next 24 hours.

INSTRUCTIONS

- The previous task (stepping through doorways right foot first) has run its course
- The new task: abstain from using the word *"I"* (the self-reference pronoun) for 24 hours
- **Permitted alternatives** — *"we," "one," "this person,"* or simply avoid self-reference altogether
- Any substitution is acceptable — no choice is better than another
- **The only commitment** — abstain from the specific word

PURPOSE

A direct practice in ego-observation and dis-identification with the personal self.

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The Body as Temple — Opening Movement

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

C6 opened with gentle movement practices to awaken the body and prepare it as a sacred vessel for spiritual presence.

"We spoke of the body as a temple — and with the kinds of movements that re-up the circulation and the breath, that temple comes into still fuller cohesion and becomes a more spacious vessel for the spirit to function in."

"So it's really a blessing whenever we can experience this kind of fluidity and opening up of the channels."

TEACHING

The body is understood as a temple — a sacred space that houses the spirit. Through gentle movements that awaken circulation and breath, this temple comes into fuller coherence and becomes a more spacious vessel for the spirit to function within.

The practice involves movements that create fluidity and open the channels, preparing the physical form to be a worthy container for spiritual presence and practice.

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Daily Practice - Think of God After Every Statement

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

"Throughout the day, whenever you speak — whether a short phrase or a long sentence — when you're finished speaking, when you take a pause — think of God. Remember God. Just for a moment, just for a second."

THE MYSTERY BEYOND SPECULATION

"Whatever God means to you — we may not even know what we mean when we use a word that evokes the mystery that confounds all speculation. But it's enough just to invoke the being of beings, just to gesture within yourself toward the absolute."

SIMPLE IMPLEMENTATION

After everything you say, for a moment — think of God. That is the task for today.

This practice works with:

- Short phrases
- Long sentences
- Natural pauses in conversation
- Any moment of speaking

THE GESTURE TOWARD THE ABSOLUTE

The practice doesn't require theological certainty or conceptual clarity about God. It's enough to:

- Invoke the being of beings
- Gesture within yourself toward the absolute
- Remember the Source for just a moment
- Touch the mystery that underlies all speech

INTEGRATION WITH DAILY LIFE

This transforms ordinary conversation into a continuous practice of remembrance, weaving the sacred into the mundane rhythm of daily communication.

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The Swing of Breath - Ha Practice

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE CHILDHOOD SWING MEMORY

"Do you remember, as a child, swinging on a swing? The sheer delight of it — but why was that experience so peaceful and exhilarating at the same time?"

The movements of the swing imitate the movements of the breath:

- **Inhale** = swing swings back and up — reaching the farthest place behind and above, a perch where for a fraction of a second the swing pauses
- **Exhale** = swing swings forward and out and up — then a momentary perch at the end of exhalation

Each half mirrors the other — inward and outward, descending and ascending

BODY MECHANICS OF THE SWING

"Do you remember what you did as a child to make the swing go further and further? When you swung forward, you leaned back and pushed your feet out — and so the outward swing was lengthened. And then when the momentum turned and you fell back, you leaned forward — and so the inward swing was boosted."

"The farther in you went, the further out you went. And the further out you went, the further in and up you went. Each half of the movement mirrored the other half."

The swing swings between the outer and the inner, between the visible and the invisible, between the world and the soul.

GROUNDING — THE EARTH BENEATH

The frame on which the swing hangs is standing on the ground. Feel two feet planted on the floor, tailbone rooted in the chair. Beneath the floor: ground, crust, mantle, core.

"The core is said to be hotter than the sun — so that in its way, the Earth is a star."

"To give one's attention to it is to begin to notice the upwelling of chthonic energy, telluric life — which moves in the tailbone, in the channel that arises from the tailbone up through the spinal shaft, through the belly, up into the chest."

HA — THE SACRED SOUND IN THE CHEST

In the chest, the current of life becomes a resonance — the sound of the breath vibrating in the thoracic cavity: Ah, Ah.

"It's said that the words La ilaha illa Allah boil down to three sounds: Ha, Hu, and He. And the Ha is in the chest, and it has its roots deep in the earth."

Each of these three Beej mantras — Ha, Hu, He — corresponds to one of the dimensions of the primal created being, which is to say: the universe itself.

Ha = the body of the primal/universal creature

THE LITTLE BODY AND THE GREAT BODY

Our body is a fraction of the body of the whole universe — and in each fraction, the whole is represented:

"The design of this body epitomizes, summarizes everything that is in the universe. We're a miniature of the cosmos."

"We are establishing a rapport between the little body — our own personal body — and the great body, the body of the universe. The two are linked."

"We're offering our own little body to our own great body, which is the universe itself. And we're offering the great body to this little body in the chest, resounding."

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS — HA × 11

1. Sit straight but relaxed — shoulders open, chest open, belly rising and falling
2. Ground: feel feet on floor, tailbone rooted, Earth's telluric energy rising through the spine
3. On the breath, intone Ha eleven times
4. As you intone, offer the little body to the great body, and receive the great body into the little

Ha… Ha… Ha… (×11)

This practice is to be done every day.

ITTISAL CONJUNCTION

"This is the first in a sequence of intonations, connecting us with the cosmic person by way of Ittisal conjunction."

Ittisal (Arabic: اتصال) = junction, connection, conjunction — the mystical union between the individual soul and the cosmic being. Ha is the first link in this sequence.

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Walking Practice — Two-Year Encouragement

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia closed the teaching content with an ongoing practice prescription for the full two-year Suluk arc.

THE PRESCRIPTION

"Over the next two years, I would like to encourage you to walk from time to time. Go for a walk every day if possible — but as often as you can. And this walk will be a space of practice."

BEGINNING INSTRUCTIONS

"In your first walks, it's enough just to do this: feel your footsteps. Feel gravity holding you to the earth. And feel every footstep — feel the touch of the earth. Feel the contact between your body and the ground and value it, honor it."

"These feet won't always step this way. Each step is an intimate act. So walk when you can, and feel every footstep."

CLOSING SUFI SAYING

"Let your soul be where your soles are. Let your soles be where your soul is."

PURPOSE

This walking practice grounds all the interior work of the five days — concentration, breath, self-awareness, sensory refinement — into bodily presence, into earth contact, into every day of the two-year journey.

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Part I · Chapter 6

TEACHINGS & WISDOM

The Living Transmission

The living transmission of the Inayati lineage. Pir Zia brought the teachings of his grandfather Hazrat Inayat Khan alive through personal commentary, deep scholarly knowledge, and luminous presence across all 10 sessions.

46 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Amān — The Opening Prayer of Each Suluk Day

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

MEANING OF AMĀN

Amān = Sanctuary · Safety · Security · Protection · Refuge

PURPOSE

Each day of Suluk begins with the prayer Amān. It is not a prayer of denial or avoidance — it is a prayer of compassionate witness. Before turning toward the divine, before entering practice, the Salik pauses to acknowledge:

- That all is not well in this world
- That there is great suffering, tremendous violence, and injustice
- That human beings both endure and inflict tremendous pain upon each other

THE COSMOLOGICAL CONTEXT

In the story of Mount Qaf, it was precisely this vision — the Earth foreseeing the tragedies, violence, and heartbreak of humanity's history — that caused her to wobble in her orbit. God's response was to raise Mount Qaf as an anchor.

The prayer Amān holds this same awareness:

> *"We begin each of our days with the prayer Amān to acknowledge that all is not well in this world, that there is great suffering, that there is tremendous violence and injustice in our very time. And can you imagine the mind and the heart of the earth foreseeing all of this?"*

PRACTICE NOTE

Amān is said at the beginning of each day during Suluk — before other practices. It grounds the spiritual work in compassionate awareness of the world's condition, making the entire practice a form of service and refuge for the world.

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Arabic & Sufi Terms — Concentration P1 · C1

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Term · Meaning · Context / Significance
Suluk · Travel; fine manner · The path of intentional inner travel + the art of traveling well
Salik (pl. Saliks) · Traveler on the path · One who undertakes the Suluk journey intentionally
Sohbet · Heart-centered conversation · A form of spiritual companionship and sharing

Murshid / Pir · Spiritual guide / Elder · Hazrat Pir-o-Murshid Inayat Khan — transmitter of the Inayatiyya
Murid · Student / seeker · One formally initiated into the Inayatiyya or other Tariqa
Tariqa · Path / Order · A Sufi lineage or order (e.g., the Inayatiyya)
Saum · Repose · Daily prayer addressed to the One divine being
Salat / Salawat · Benediction · Daily prayer addressed to the Spirit of Guidance
Alif · First Arabic letter; upright line · Symbol of unity, oneness, divine perfection — root of all letters
Khalwat dar Anjuman · Solitude in the crowd · Meditating together in inner worlds even while physically apart
Qaf / Mount Qaf · The spiritual mountain · Cosmic anchor connecting all planes; this class is named after it
Nasut · Physical plane · First of the five planes of existence
Malakut · Angelic / subtle plane · Second plane — realm of subtle forms
Jabrut · Plane of power / force · Third plane — realm of divine attributes
Lahut · Divine plane · Fourth plane — realm of pure divinity
HaHut · Plane of the Absolute · Fifth and highest plane — the Absolute beyond all names
Divan · The League of Bodhisattvas · Spiritual guardians of the world; their seat is the emerald peak of Mount Qaf
Amān · Sanctuary, safety, protection, refuge · Opening prayer of each Suluk day — holding the world's suffering
Ashik · Lover / devoted one · One who has deep love for the path without formal initiation
Gayathri · Sacred hymns · Hymns transmitted through Pir-o-Murshid; used throughout Suluk
Al-Mu'min Mir'atu'l-Mu'min · The believer is a mirror to the believer · Hadith expressing the spirit of companionship on the path
Inayatiyya · The Sufi order of Inayat Khan · The lineage through which Suluk is transmitted

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Concentration — The First Stage of Suluk

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

DEFINITION

"Concentration means the whole of you is in one place. You are not scattered. You are not dispersed. You are not diffused. You are gathered."

"Concentration means to be whole, not fragmented. To be fully there, not absent."

WHY CONCENTRATION IS THE FOUNDATION

"If one can learn to concentrate, then one can pray. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can meditate. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can create. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can love. The whole of life depends on concentration."

THE CHALLENGE

Our habitual state is one of distraction — constantly scattered across tasks and thoughts. Concentration requires pulling attention back, centering it, and staying with one thing. This can feel uncomfortable at first — boring, wasteful, unproductive — because we are conditioned to distraction.

Common reactions when beginning concentration practice:

- Feels wasteful or boring
- The action seems to be *“somewhere else”*
- Impatience — *"I just don't have the patience for it"*

THE CULTIVATION

Concentration is not about suppressing energy but **molding it**. The energy of interest, desire, love, or will — when flung in all directions, it is scattered; when gathered with intention, it deepens.

> **"If one has the intention to take ownership of your attention — to take it into your own care, to allow it to slow down, to give it breathing room — you may find that actually there is a satisfaction. It isn't the obvious gratification. It's a different kind of satisfaction. But it grows and it deepens."**

INTEGRATION WITH DAILY LIFE

Concentration is not separate from life's responsibilities. It **infuses** family, work, and ordinary moments with presence. The practices of Suluk are rehearsals for living this quality of attentive presence in every moment.

> **"The cultivation of concentration is not about separating or segregating the practice from our daily life and responsibilities but integrating it in every action and every moment."**

THE FOUR STAGES (OVERVIEW)

1. **Concentration** — gathering scattered attention into presence
2. **Contemplation** — dwelling with a quality of being
3. **Meditation** — experiencing pure essence beyond quality
4. **Realization** — returning to the visible world with the invisible essence illumining all

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Key Teaching Quotes — Concentration P1 · C1

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

ON THE JOURNEY

"We're like a flock of birds that have landed in a field and are having a look at each other and just wondering what it's going to be like to form a murmuration in the sky to fly together."

"The journey is a journey of recollection — recollecting yourselves, bringing the parts back together. Remembrance — bringing the different members back into unity."

"Our intention is to reunite body with mind, mind with heart, heart with soul, soul with the soul of souls. And in the process we'll see that what might have seemed at the beginning like an individual journey is in fact the journey of the whole universe."

"Everyone comes from the same source, is returning to the source, is sustained all the while by the source."

"We are there for each other on the hilltops, but also in the shadowed valleys."

"In this world, there is no friendship like the friendship on the path." — Sayed Abu Hashim Madani

ON INTENTION

"If the intention is clear, if it's sincere, if it's focused, we'll get through everything easily."

"There's a spark in us. There's a gem seeking its mine. A spark seeking the sun."

"All of the prayers, all of the practices, all of the readings, all of the conversations, everything we'll do is simply fuel for that ember. The flame is already there."

"The eyes must be sun-like to see the sun."

"The truth that is awakening in your spirit is looking for a mirror. And our intention here, all of us, is to be a mirror to each other."

"Al-Mu'min Mir'atu'l-Mu'min — The believer is a mirror to the believer."

ON CONCENTRATION

"Concentration means the whole of you is in one place. You are not scattered. You are not dispersed. You are not diffused. You are gathered."

"If one can learn to concentrate, then one can pray. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can meditate. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can create. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can love. The whole of life depends on concentration."

ON QUALITY AND PRACTICE

"A Salik could do one practice for their whole life and reach the divine presence."

"What is powerful is to bring one's whole being to whatever it is — whatever the practice is. The essence of it all is the spirit in which we give ourselves to this work."

ON PRAYERS

> *"These prayers are not intended to displace the prayers of the religion to which you belong, but rather to shine a light that reveals the depths of your faith even more clearly than ever before."*

ON MOUNT QAF

> *"At the crown of the mountain is an emerald peak. Emerald — in the alchemy of Sufism — is the color that outlasts all others, sums them all up, and bespeaks the perfect integration of all opposites. There the Divan, the League of Bodhisattvas who guard and guide the world, have their seat."*

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Mount Qaf — The Spiritual Mountain and the Name of This Class

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE STORY OF THE EARTH AND MOUNT QAF

When God created the Earth, she was revolving in space in a rapture of ecstasy, dreaming of the life that would unfold — oceans, continents, greenery, animals, birds, and finally the human being. Her vision filled her with joy. But as she foresaw the course of humanity's history — the tragedies, the violence, the suffering that human beings would not only endure but inflict on each other — she came face to face with heartbreak.

She began to shake. She began to wobble in her orbit.

All the heavens were focused on her. Something was needed. And so God decreed the raising up of a monumental mountain. And that mountain was established. Though not visible to eyes of flesh, it encompasses the Earth. Its roots work through the roots of all the mountain ranges of the earth and feed those mountain ranges. Its roots are sunk deep into the mantle of the earth and into the earth's core.

THE FUNCTION OF MOUNT QAF

Mount Qaf is a great **spiritual circulatory system** — a cosmic anchor between the Earth and the divine realms.

It mounts through the planes of existence:

- **Nasut** — Physical plane
- **Malakut** — Angelic / subtle plane
- **Jabrut** — Plane of power / force
- **Lahut** — Divine plane
- **HaHut** — Plane of the Absolute

This creates a direct connection between the physical earth and the spiritual depths from which it emerges — anchoring the earth in the invisible.

THE EMERALD PEAK AND THE DIVAN

> *"At the crown of the mountain is an emerald peak. Emerald — in the alchemy of Sufism — is the color that outlasts all others, sums them all up, and bespeaks the perfect integration of all opposites. There the Divan, the League of Bodhisattvas who guard and guide the world, have their seat."*

The emerald symbolizes the perfect integration of all opposites — the marriage of visible and invisible, earth and heaven, fragmentation and wholeness.

THIS CLASS IS NAMED MOUNT QAF

The Suluk class of 2025–2027 is named **Mount Qaf (Qaf)** — the cosmic mountain that stabilizes, anchors, and connects. A fitting name for a fellowship of travelers seeking to anchor themselves in the spiritual while living fully in the physical.

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Saum and Salat — The Two Daily Prayers of Suluk

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

OVERVIEW

Two prayers transmitted through Pir-o-Murshid Inayat Khan form the daily foundation of Suluk practice. Both involve specific postures, gestures, and words, and are said together every day — in group or individually.

THE TWO PRAYERS

Prayer · Meaning · Addressed To
Saum · Repose · The One Divine Being
Salat / Salawat · Benediction · The Light of the Rasool — Spirit of Guidance, first of creation

SALAT — DEEPER DESCRIPTION

> *"Salat is addressed to the spirit of guidance, the first of creation, that first manifested light from which the world derives, and which constitutes the luminous core through which the divine guidance pours into the world, and which is embodied in the consciousness of all who are awakened to the divine truth."*

KEY TEACHINGS

- These prayers are **not intended to displace** the prayers of one's own religion
- They *"shine a light that reveals the depths of your faith even more clearly than ever before"*

- They deepen the relationship with the divine being and with the light of guidance
- They subtly bring travelers closer to each other in the inner worlds
- Say them every day — in group or individually
- Both prayers involve **gestures as well as words**

NOTE ON THE INAYATIYYA

The Inayatiyya is not a religion. These are hymns and orisons that connect the Salik to the inspiration that came through the Murshid and to fellow travelers in the inner worlds.

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Suluk Class Names — A Legacy of Beautiful Names

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE TRADITION

Each Suluk caravan receives its own unique name reflecting the spiritual character and collective spirit of that particular gathering. Each configuration of Saliks has its own soul.

> **"Each, each configuration of Saliks has its own character. And that becomes even more palpable as we go along, as we're weaving our prayers, our practices, meeting together, speaking together, getting to know each other, helping each other. A vessel is emerging."**

PREVIOUS CLASS NAMES

Class Name · Meaning / Description
Khosar · River of Paradise (first four classes named after rivers of paradise)
Kafur · River of Paradise
Salsabil · River of Paradise
Tasneem · River of Paradise
Nasim · The breeze that blows through the garden
Gulzar · The rose garden
Zindarud · The living river
Luluvamarjan · Pearls and coral — the spiritual treasures deep in the ocean of soul

THIS CLASS — MOUNT QAF (2025–2027)

The current class is named **Mount Qaf** — the invisible spiritual mountain that anchors the Earth between the physical and divine planes, whose emerald peak is the seat of the Divan — the League of Bodhisattvas who guard and guide the world.

KHALWAT DAR ANJUMAN

The vessel that forms through the class is described by the Sufi concept of *Khalwat dar Anjuman — "solitude in the crowd"* — meaning that even when the Saliks are scattered

across the world meditating in silence, they are meeting each other in the inner worlds through the intention that has joined them.

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The Five Planes of Existence — Nasut, Malakut, Jabrut, Lahut, HaHut

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE FIVE PLANES

In the Sufi cosmological framework of the Inayatiyya, existence is understood through five ascending planes. Mount Qaf serves as the spiritual circulatory system connecting all of them:

Plane · Arabic Name · Description
1st · **Nasut** · The physical plane — the world of matter and ordinary sensory experience
2nd · **Malakut** · The angelic / subtle plane — realm of subtle forms, images, inner perception
3rd · **Jabrut** · The plane of power / force — realm of divine attributes and qualities
4th · **Lahut** · The divine plane — realm of pure divinity, beyond name and form
5th · **HaHut** · The plane of the Absolute — the Absolute, beyond all planes, beyond all comprehension

MOUNT QAF AS CONNECTOR

Mount Qaf is described as a great spiritual circulatory system that creates a direct vertical connection between all five planes — from the physical earth all the way to the Absolute.

> **"There's a great spiritual circulatory system that functions through the mountain — visible mountain ranges which culminate in the invisible mountain that in turn mounts up through the plains from Nasut to Malakut, from Malakut to Jabrut, from Jabrut to Lahut, and onto HaHut, through all of the planes, creating connection between them on Earth in the most direct possible way, anchoring the Earth in the spiritual depths from which the Earth emerges."*

THE DIVAN AT THE SUMMIT

At the emerald peak of Mount Qaf (highest visible point of the invisible mountain) sits the **Divan** — the League of Bodhisattvas who guard and guide the world. Their emerald seat symbolizes the perfect integration of all opposites — the marriage of every plane.

RELEVANCE TO PRACTICE

Understanding the five planes provides the cosmological map for the four stages of Suluk:

- **Concentration** operates primarily in Nasut (physical, sensory)

- **Contemplation** begins to access Malakut (subtle, quality)
- **Meditation** approaches Jabrut (essence, beyond quality)
- **Realization** recognizes that all planes are present simultaneously — the Absolute as the context of everything

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The Standing Posture Before Prayer — Embodying the Alif

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE POSTURE

Before prayer, one stands and settles into the posture of the upright line — the Alif:

- **Feet** firmly on the ground — like roots of a tree
- **Spine** erect — like the trunk of the tree
- **Tailbone** sends a root deep into the earth
- **Crown** of the head open to the vastness of sky and space beyond
- Grounded in the density of the earth below; overlit by the heavens above

Only when this orientation is experienced does one begin with the words *"Praise be to thee…"*

THE SYMBOLISM OF THE UPRIGHT LINE (ALIF)

> **"The upright line suggests the one, and the number one is represented by an upright line. The upright line suggests heaven, perfection, straightforwardness, firmness, life, rising, and unity — as it shows oneness with the whole. The upright line is the first line, and all forms and figures are nothing but the change of direction of that line."**

The Alif is the Arabic letter from which Allah begins. It is the root from which all other letters emerge. To embody the Alif is to embody unity itself.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTION

Stand. Feel your two feet on the ground. Feel yourself like a tree rooted in the ground. Spine like the trunk of the tree. Tailbone sends a root deep into the earth. Crown at the top of the head open to the vastness of sky. Experience this grounding and openness. Then begin the prayer.

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The Story of the Boy and the Alif — Quality Over Quantity

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE STORY

In a village in the Punjab, a teacher was teaching children the Arabic alphabet — beginning with Alif, the straight upright line. One child showed exceptional enthusiasm for the Alif. When the teacher moved on to the next letters, every other child followed — but this boy kept writing Alif.

The teacher grew frustrated. The parents tried to encourage the boy to move on. But he simply could not or would not leave the Alif. Feeling that he had disappointed everyone, he left home and went out into the jungle. He was not seen for many years.

One day, the same teacher was teaching a new group of children in the same classroom. Suddenly, a man entered — approached the blackboard — and wrote *Alif*. A great light filled the room, and the room shook. Everyone could see that he had truly understood the meaning of one thing.

He went on to master Bay, Tay, Se — and became one of the greatest Sufi poets of the land.

THE TEACHING

> **"This is a story about the power of the straight line. It's the story of the power of standing straight — rooted in the earth, tailbone grounded, crown open to the heavens. That posture — it's a story of the power of it. It's also a story about quality rather than quantity."**

The boy's story carries multiple layers of meaning:

- **Power of the Alif** — unity, oneness, divine perfection as root of all things
- **Quality over quantity** — one thing practiced with wholeness transforms more than a thousand things collected
- **Wholehearted giving** — the essence is not the technique but the spirit with which one gives oneself to the work

> **"A Salik could do one practice for their whole life and reach the divine presence. It's good to learn the techniques that have been passed down, but the essence of it all is the spirit in which we give ourselves to this work — the faith, the wholeheartedness. This is what transforms."**

APPLICATION TO SULUK

In Suluk, there are many subjects and many practices. One could spend a lifetime accumulating forms — hundreds of practices, thousands of books. But what transforms is not accumulation. It is **bringing one's whole being** to whatever the practice is.

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The Suluk Journey — Path of Recollection and Unity

Source: Concentration P1 · C1 · 2025-09-12 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE NATURE OF THE JOURNEY

> **"The journey is a journey of recollection — recollecting yourselves, bringing the parts back together. Remembrance — bringing the different members back into unity. And not only within ourselves, because what is a self? A self itself is a fragment of a greater whole. The journey is one of rediscovery, of long-forgotten unities, the revelation of patterns, connections, affinities that bring wholeness to a world that is otherwise broken apart in our psyche."**

The Suluk Path is a **Path of Recollection and Unity**. Its purpose: to reunite body with mind, mind with heart, heart with soul, soul with the soul of souls.

> **"Our intention is to reunite body with mind, mind with heart, heart with soul, soul with the soul of souls. And in the process, we'll see that what might have seemed at the beginning like an individual journey is in fact the journey of the whole universe."**

THE CARAVAN WITHIN THE CARAVAN

Participants form a close-knit fellowship — a *caravan within the caravan*. Like a flock of birds learning to fly in murmuration, they travel together in familiar and unfamiliar territory, supporting each other across hilltops and shadowed valleys.

THE MEANING OF SULUK

The word carries two inseparable meanings:

1. **Travel** — the universal inner journey
2. **Fine Manner** — the art of traveling well: gently, thoughtfully, considerately, wisely, discerningly, balanced

These two are not separate. To travel on this path *is* to cultivate the manner of travel itself.

INTENTIONAL JOURNEY

> **"If there is a difference, it's only this — that we're making a decision here to journey intentionally. We're aware that this is a journey and we want to, as far as possible, travel well."**

Everyone is a seeker. Everyone comes from the same source, is returning to the source, is sustained all the while by the source. The difference for the Salik is the *intention* to journey consciously — following those who blazed the trail before.

THE FRIENDSHIP ON THE PATH

Murshid Sayed Abu Hashim Madani said: *"In this world, there is no friendship like the friendship on the path."*

This friendship widens — step by step one realizes that everyone encountered is *in media res*, in the midst of a journey embedded within the journey of the whole of being.

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Previous Suluk Class Names and Their Meanings

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Each Suluk caravan receives its own name that reflects its particular spiritual character. The tradition began with the first four classes named after the rivers of paradise:

THE NAMED CLASSES

1. **Khosar** — River of Paradise
2. **Kafur** — River of Paradise
3. **Salsabil** — River of Paradise
4. **Tasneem** — River of Paradise
5. **Nasim** — The breeze that blows through the garden
6. **Gulzar** — The rose garden
7. **Zindarud** — The living river
8. **Luluvamarjan** — Pearls and coral (spiritual treasures deep in the ocean of soul)
9. **Mount Qaf** — The cosmic anchor (this current class)

THE PATTERN OF NAMING

The names progress through beautiful spiritual imagery:

- **Rivers of Paradise** (the first four classes)
- **Garden imagery** (breeze and rose garden)
- **Living waters** (the living river)
- **Ocean treasures** (pearls and coral from the depths)
- **Cosmic mountain** (the spiritual anchor between realms)

Each name captures both the unique character of that particular group and their place in the ongoing tradition of Suluk classes.

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The Power of Intention in Suluk

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE SUPREME IMPORTANCE OF INTENTION

The sincerity and clarity of intention is the single most important factor in the Suluk journey.

> *"If the intention is clear, if it's sincere, if it's focused, we'll get through everything easily."*

A clear, focused, sincere intention overcomes all obstacles. A murky or half-hearted intention limits progress regardless of favorable outer circumstances.

THE INNER SPARK ALREADY KNOWS

There is already a spark within each seeker — a gem seeking its mine, a spark seeking the sun. All prayers, practices, readings, and conversations are fuel for this existing ember. The work of Suluk is to shelter, kindle, and center this flame.

> *"The eyes must be sun-like to see the sun. Whatever elevates you, inspires you, motivates you, reassures you, consoles you — it does so because it meets in you the truth that is already there."*

MIRRORING THE DIVINE

Al-Mu'min Mir'atu'l-Mu'min — The believer is a mirror to the believer.

The spirit of companionship on this path is to mirror the divinity shining out from each one.

KEY POINTS ON INTENTION

- **Sincerity of purpose matters most** — clear intention overcomes all obstacles
- **Murky or half-hearted intention** limits progress even in ideal circumstances
- **The inner spark already knows where to go** — it hears the call
- **Prayers, practices, readings, conversations**: all are fuel for the ember
- **Shelter, kindle, and center the flame** — let it glow and blaze
- **Eyes must be sun-like to see the sun** — inner truth recognizes outer truth
- **The believer is a mirror to the believer** — we mirror each other's divinity

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The Suluk Journey - Path of Recollection and Unity

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE ESSENCE OF SULUK

The Suluk Path is fundamentally a **Path of Recollection and Unity**. Participants form a 'caravan within the caravan' — a close-knit fellowship traveling together like birds learning to fly in murmuration.

> *"The journey is a journey of recollection — recollecting yourselves, bringing the parts back together. Remembrance — bringing the different members back into unity. And not only within ourselves, because what is a self? A self itself is a fragment of a greater whole."*

THE PROCESS OF REUNIFICATION

The journey involves reuniting:

- Body with mind
- Mind with heart
- Heart with soul
- Soul with the soul of souls

> *"Everyone comes from the same source, is returning to the source, is sustained all the while by the source."*

THE DUAL MEANING OF SULUK

The word **SULUK** carries two meanings:

1. **Travel** - the journey itself
2. **Fine manner** - a way of being that is gentle, thoughtful, considerate, wise, discerning, and balanced

Suluk is both the journey and the art of traveling well.

KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF THE SULUK JOURNEY

- **Caravan within the caravan** — a fellowship of intentional travelers
- **Sohbet**: heart-centered conversation as a vehicle of companionship
- **Present for each other** — on hilltops and in shadowed valleys
- **Unique friendship**: 'In this world there is no friendship like the friendship on the path' — Sayed Abu Hashim Madani
- **Everyone is a seeker** — the circle of companionship widens beyond the class
- **Decision to journey intentionally** — aware of the path, traveling well
- **Following those who blazed the trail** — inheriting maps and directions

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Breath as Medium of Teaching - Saheb al-Anfas

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

“When I'm speaking and you're listening, the medium between us is the air. It's air that is carrying the current of the words, air that's vibrating. The medium between us is breath.”

KEY PRINCIPLES

- There is no voice without breath
- There is no speech without respiration
- When we go into silence, when the words fall away, what remains is inhalation and exhalation
- Breath moves between what is outside of us and what is within us — between mind and body, and even between mind and soul

We pay attention to people's words and judgments — but how much attention do we pay to the breath? For Suluk, this is at the center of everything.

SAHEB AL-ANFAS

“One of the definitions of a Sufi is 'Saheb al-Anfas' — one who breathes well. The possessor of breaths.”

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Heart-to-Heart Teaching Story - Hazrat Inayat Khan and His Murshid

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Hazrat Inayat Khan, though born into a family with a Sufi tradition, sought a living teacher. When he found his Murshid — a retired scholar — he visited him regularly. For months, months, the Murshid spoke only of ordinary things: milk, butter, different kinds of trees.

“Finally, one day, the Murshid began to speak about the planes of being. And Hazrat's ears perked up and he discreetly took out a notebook. And just as soon as Hazrat took out his notebook, the Murshid went back to speaking about the ordinary things.”

Hazrat always looked back on this as a real teaching: his Murshid intended him to receive whatever was coming through directly in his heart — without differentiating between the obviously mystical and the apparently ordinary.

CORE TEACHINGS

- **Transmission happens heart-to-heart** — true wisdom isn't only in mystical words but in presence
- **Don't separate the ordinary from the sacred** — all speech carries spiritual meaning when received openly

- **The real notebook is the heart** — teachings are first inscribed inwardly through deep attention
- **Presence over documentation** — the living moment takes priority

NOTE ON NOTE-TAKING

"This isn't because there is a proscription against taking notes in our order. In later times, among Hazrat's own circle, he sometimes asked for those present to note down his words. It isn't that notes are a bad thing, but we're lucky in Suluk that there is no need for any of you to take down notes. The notes are taken anyway and shared with you. So you can just give your whole attention to this moment, put aside pen and paper, and just be with what's coming through."

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Heart-to-Heart Teaching and Sacred Transmission

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia opened with a profound story from Hazrat Inayat Khan's relationship with his Murshid, illustrating the true nature of spiritual transmission.

Though born into a Sufi family, Hazrat sought a living teacher and found one. He would visit his Murshid regularly at home, and the Murshid received him warmly. Yet for months, the Murshid spoke only of ordinary things: milk, butter, trees.

One day the Murshid began speaking of the higher planes of being. Hazrat eagerly reached for a notebook — and immediately the Murshid returned to ordinary conversation. Hazrat later saw this as the real teaching.

"Not to differentiate between what seemed obviously mystical and what didn't seem particularly mystical — but instead just to listen to everything, take in everything, and engrave it on the notebook of your heart."

CORE PRINCIPLES

- **Transmission happens heart-to-heart** — wisdom lives in presence, not just in *"mystical"* words
- **Do not separate the ordinary from the sacred** — all speech, all encounter, is transmission when received with openness
- **The real notebook is the heart** — teachings must first be inscribed inwardly through deep attention
- **Presence over documentation** — in Suluk, notes are taken and shared; students can give full attention to the living moment

- **Timeless connection** — reading Murshid's words a century later still brings his presence alive

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Murshid's Complete Teaching on Breath - The Secret of Both Worlds

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"To a mystic, the subject of breath is the deepest of all the subjects with which mysticism or philosophy is concerned. Because breath is the most important thing in life. The very life of the human being is breath. One lives in the presence of breath, and in the absence of breath, one is called a corpse."

"Breath is that which keeps all of the parts in connection with each other, working together, depending upon one another. It is that which enables one to move, to put one's muscles into action, to keep the whole mechanism of the body at work. There is no other force or power concerned with all this than the power of breath."

"Wherever we look — be it the changes of the seasons, the changes of the weather, or even the constant circles which the Earth describes on its journey — all these show the same underlying current, the current of the whole of nature, which is the real breath."

"The whole universe is going on with a certain rhythm. There is a current which keeps the whole universe going. It is one breath, and yet it is many breaths."

"Breath is a channel through which all the expression of the innermost life can be given. Breath is an electric current that runs between the everlasting life and the mortal frame. Those who have attained any intuition or miraculous power have achieved it by the help of the breath."

THE SPINE AS SERPENT

"The breath makes a circuit through the body, and the channel through which it makes the circuit is the spine. The mystics give this channel great importance. They call it the serpent. They picture it as a serpent holding its tail in its mouth. In almost all symbols, the serpent represents the channel of the breath."

"When this channel is made clear by the method of breathing, this is not only a help to physical health, but it also opens up the faculties of intuition and the doors that are within, where lies the real happiness of the human being."

"In order to clear this channel of all that blocks the way, one must follow the rules of mystical ablutions and of rhythmic breathing."

THE MASTER KEY

*“People look for phenomena, but there is no better phenomena than breath itself. Because breath is life and light, and in the breath is the source of life and light. **The mastery of breath is the secret of both worlds.**”*

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Murshid's Teaching on Breath as Life and Light

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia read directly from Hazrat Inayat Khan's writings on breath:

"Breath is the most important thing in life. The very life of the human being is breath. One lives in the presence of breath, and in the absence of breath, one is called a corpse."

"The whole universe is going on with a certain rhythm. There is a current which keeps the whole universe going. It is one breath, and yet it is many breaths."

"Breath is an electric current that runs between the everlasting life and the mortal frame. Those who have attained any intuition or miraculous power have achieved it by the help of the breath."

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"Breath is life and light, and in the breath is the source of life and light. The mastery of breath is the secret of both worlds."

KEY PRINCIPLES

- Breath is life — without it, the body is a corpse; with it, we live in constant connection
- Breath is the bridge — linking body, mind, and soul; connecting the mortal with the eternal
- The whole cosmos moves in one great rhythm — it is one breath expressed through many breaths
- The spine is the channel (the serpent) — when purified through rhythmic breathing, intuition and spiritual faculties awaken
- Saheb al-Anfas — the Sufi definition: one who breathes well, the possessor of breaths
- Air and breath is the vibratory medium that carries words between speaker and listener

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Sensus Communis - The Sense Within All Senses

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE SOCRATIC DEVELOPMENT

"What is it that sees through eyes and hears through ears and tastes through the tongue and smells through the nose and touches with fingertips? What do these five senses all have in common? They're all sensory apparatuses — they all participate in sensation itself. Sensation moves through five different channels, but those channels converge in essential sensing: the common sense."

KEY CONCEPTS

- **Sensus Communis** = Latin for 'common sense' — the sense within all senses
- **Synesthesia** — Sometimes senses criss-cross: hearing a colour, seeing a taste
- All senses are expressions of one aspect of mind: sensation itself — an expression of presence and attention

HUDUR AND ILM-E-HUZURI

Hudur (Arabic) = Presence — the foundation of all knowing

Ilm-e-Huzuri — Knowledge by Presence

"Sufis speak of that way of knowing which is called Ilm-e-Huzuri — knowledge by presence. All knowledge has this as its foundation: pure attention. The physical senses are just extensions of it. And even when the senses close — in sleep or in death — that light of attention continues, but turned inward."

CULTIVATING ATTENTION

"It's like a plasma that can be shaped however the will wishes. And it can be grown, it can be intensified. If it's not cultivated — like anything that's not cultivated — it just languishes and becomes dull. But if you give attention to attention, then it flourishes, it blossoms, it becomes very luminous."

ETYMOLOGY OF HAZRAT

"Why do we refer to great beings, awakened mystics, as Hazrat? We refer to Murshid as Hazrat Inayat Khan. Hazrat comes from that root Huzur — we're saying 'your presence.' We see in Murshid a profound sonification of the presence that exists in ourselves and is seeking cultivation."

JESUS IN GETHSEMANE

"In the Garden of Gethsemane, Jesus said to the apostles: 'Stay awake with me.' But one by one they fell asleep. It's that wakefulness, it's that attentiveness, it's that ability to really

hear, really see — it doesn't matter which organ of sensation is used — but whatever it is, to wake up to it."

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Hejirat Day - Sacred Remembrance September 13

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

September 13 is a doubly sacred day in the Inayatiyya lineage, observed on the day of this very session.

THE MIGRATION OF HAZRAT INAYAT KHAN

Hejirat Day commemorates the migration of Hazrat Inayat Khan from Baroda, India, accompanied by Sheikh Maheboob Khan and Murshid Ali Khan. This journey set in motion the transmission of all his prayers, teachings, practices, and the living light he manifested in the world. September 13, 2025 marks **115 years** since this pivotal departure.

THE MARTYRDOM OF NOOR-UN-NISA INAYAT KHAN

The same date, **84 years prior**, marks the execution of Pirzadi Noor-un-Nisa Inayat Khan — Hazrat's firstborn child and direct spiritual heir — in Dachau concentration camp. Her final word was **"Liberté"** (freedom).

Her Legacy

- She dedicated her life to the freedom of the soul and the right of all beings to realize it.
- Facing the Nazi conquest of Europe, she chose to take a stand rather than flee.
- She is remembered as an inspiration against oppression, cruelty, and supremacism of every kind.

"She lived life dedicated to the freedom of the soul and the imperative that all human beings be unimpeded in their own realization of freedom."

"So it's with great humility and at the same time high aspiration that we invoke the spirit of Pirzadi Noor-un-Nisa on this day — and her soul's fragrance, tinctured the entire atmosphere of the planet. God bless her being."

THE CALL TO STUDENTS

Her life calls each student of the path to take seriously the opportunity of these few years given to us — to live in the fullest possible alignment with our highest vision of truth.

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Hejirat Day — September 13 Sacred Significance

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

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KEY TEACHING QUOTES

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The Rabita - Heart to Heart Connection

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The Rabita is the heart-to-heart link established and sanctified through initiation (Ashik or Murid). It connects fellow travelers on the path regardless of physical or screen presence — an invisible cord between hearts that persists always.

KEY UNDERSTANDING

- The Rabita is **not dependent** on being on screen together — it is always present.
- Regular meetings (every couple of months, two to three days at a time) carry great power depending on the attention, sincerity, and care brought to them.
- What is possible depends entirely on what attention and care we give to it.

"What is possible depends on what we give to it, what attention we give to it, what care we give to it. Everything is possible with that attention."

THE INTERNET AS SPIRITUAL TERRITORY

The internet is a mirror of the human condition — full of troubled impressions and unawakened impulses. Rather than fleeing it, the path calls us to meet it wisely and transformatively, navigating it with awareness.

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The Spirit of Guidance and Cosmic Being

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE TEACHING

The Invocation first invokes the One Being — the absolute — and then evokes the light of guidance that is the essence of creation. There is a soul of souls, a mind of minds, a body of bodies: not the infinite absolute itself, but the wholeness composed of all souls, all minds, all bodies — the cosmic being that is the first of creation and the mirror of the absolute.

WHAT IS THE SPIRIT OF GUIDANCE?

The criterion for right from wrong is the wholeness of the cosmic being — in whom all poles are balanced and every individual has a place within the totality. The Spirit of Guidance is personified in those human beings who awaken to life's purpose, work together, serve, and advance the ongoing revelation of the divine in creation.

KEY QUOTES

“There's a soul of souls, a mind of minds, a body of bodies — still created, still ephemeral, not the infinite one that is all and everything, but rather the essence of creation.”

“The Spirit of Guidance is the first of creation, the cosmic being — the mirror of the Absolute.”

THE RABITA — HEART-TO-HEART LINK

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Jalali and Jamali - Two Aspects of Concentration

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Concentration has two essential and complementary qualities that must be held in balance.

DEFINITIONS

Jalali — active, assertive, forceful. The quality of rock. Projecting, depicting, manifesting an image in the mind.

Jamali — receptive, gentle, embracing. The quality of a flower. Resting with, holding, listening to an image.

ANALOGY: CONVERSATION

A conversation requires both speaking and listening. A friend who only talks (all Jalali) makes conversation impossible. A friend who only listens and never responds (all Jamali) is equally frustrating. True exchange requires both.

IN CONCENTRATION PRACTICE

Jalali — you actively portray, project, and hold the image in the mind. Without this, the image never forms.

Jamali — you rest with the image, embrace it, sustain it. Without this, the image fades quickly and the mind tires.

The rhythm — etch it, then hold it. Trace it, then sustain it. Right hand and left hand together.

WORKING WITH THE BALANCE

- When dullness arises — bring in more Jalali to retrace and re-enliven the image
- When the image is present — yield to Jamali and simply be with it

"You can't just keep pushing it. You have to etch it and then hold it, trace it and then sustain it. It's these two things, right hand and left hand together — active and passive."

"Rock. That's Jalali. Flower. The words themselves tell you about the Jalali or Jamali character of what's being described."

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The Faculty of Memory in Spiritual Practice

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Yesterday's practice was presence as sensation — the first faculty of the mind: being awake in the here-and-now. C4 introduces the complementary faculty: memory.

WHAT MEMORY DOES

- **Locates us in time and space** — the experience of waking in a dark room and slowly remembering where you are; memory returns and situates the temporal self within chronology
- **Allows revisiting the past** — nothing is truly lost; the past lives in the mind
- **Enables wisdom** — impressions can be engaged with, their wisdom extracted, and then released
- **Selective preservation** — we can choose to let go of impressions that only bring regret, while preserving and returning to moments that nourish the heart

THE PRACTICE — REVISITING A BEAUTIFUL MOMENT

1. Close the eyes
2. Recall a beautiful moment in your life — go right there, be there now
3. Remember exactly where you were. What time of day? What fragrance was in the air? Who else was there?
4. What was the quality of the light? What colors were predominant?
5. Relive that moment fully — it is not lost; it lives in you

"It isn't lost. It isn't going to slip away. It's just a place that will always be there. It lives in you. The past is available."

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Living a Balanced and Pure Life - Murshid's Prescription

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia shared Murshid's prescription for a wholesome way of life — the foundation for walking this path over time. The body is the Temple of Light (Hayakal al-Nur), a profound trust entrusted to our care.

MURSHID'S PRESCRIPTION FOR HEALTH

"The best medicine is a pure diet, nourishing food, fresh air, regularity in action and repose, clearness of thought, pureness of feeling, and confidence in the perfect being with whom we are all linked and whose expression we are."

PURE DIET

The body is a miniaturization of the whole cosmos — showing it respect is showing respect to creation itself. The questions to ask:

- What truly nourishes you?
- What leaves you energized, grounded, sustained?
- Where did your food come from?

We take in not only physical molecules but the condition and etheric trace of what we consume. There is no single rule for all — it is a question of knowing your own body and constitution.

FRESH AIR

Step outside, breathe a fresh breeze, go for a walk — especially first thing in the morning. Just this one act changes everything. The word inspiration derives from respiration.

REGULARITY IN ACTION AND REPOSE

Balance is essential for the long path. Deep repose is not mere inactivity — it is the relinquishing of all cares and fears, entering deep silence. One who learns deep repose finds even greater energy and effectiveness in activity.

CLEARNESS OF THOUGHT AND PURENESS OF FEELING

The essence of both is sincerity — sincere intention. It requires only a decision: to think clearly, to feel purely. Moving from the noise to the message. Not staying on the surface.

CONFIDENCE IN THE PERFECT BEING

We have been plucked out of the void, endowed with soul, mind, body. The world has been brought forth out of great mystery. Trust in the process; trust in the great benevolence behind all of this.

"With trust in God, with goodwill, self-confidence, and a hopeful attitude towards life, one will always win one's battle, however difficult."

"The only way to live in the midst of inharmonious influences is to strengthen the willpower and endure all things — yet keeping fineness of character and nobility of manner together with an ever-living heart full of love."

"No one can take from you the character of your heart."

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Understanding Prayer - Al-Ghayb and the Invisible

Source: C5 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia addressed potential resistance to prayer, particularly the word *"God,"* and gave a profound teaching on what prayer actually is.

AL-GHAYB — THE INVISIBLE

Modern materialist rationalism challenges what is called Al-Ghayb — the invisible. The assumption is that if something is not quantifiable, it should be disregarded. But divinity is encountered in the wholeness of our being, of which the critical rational function is just one fraction. The sincerity of questioning and seeking is itself spiritual.

"One's belief in God is challenged by people enacting atrocities in the name of God. That sincerity is itself a spiritual intuition."

"Divinity is encountered in the wholeness of our being, of which the critical rational function is just one fraction."

"The word God may give some speakers pause — but what if you allow it to be a placeholder for mystery? You don't rush to define it, but let it be an ever-dawning discovery, never fully known."

HAZRAT INAYAT KHAN'S STORY — THE KEY TURNING IN THE LOCK

As a boy, Hazrat Inayat Khan performed the daily prayers of Islam punctiliously, until he began to question: Is this just a performance? What is the real intention? He brought his deep question to his grandfather Maulabaksh, who pointed to a verse of the Quran:

"We will show them Our signs on the horizons and in themselves, and they will know that We are God."

At that moment, the key turned in the lock. He saw that prayer was not merely ritual — it was a path, a search, a quest for the signs found on the horizon in everything encountered, and in oneself in the depths of one's own being.

- What is without shows itself within
- What is within shows itself without

- In the confrontation of the internal and external, divine attributes reveal themselves through their reflection
- Prayer is a vessel for that journey of discovery

"He saw that it wasn't merely a ritual — it was a path. It was a search. It was a quest for the signs which are to be found on the horizon in everything that we encounter and in ourselves, in the depths of our own being."

"What is without shows itself within. What is within shows itself without. Prayer is a vessel for that journey of discovery."

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Deep Teaching on Salat: Darood, Majma-ul-Bahrain, Syzygies

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

WHAT SALAT IS

Salat (benediction) is not the five-times daily Islamic prayer — it has a wider meaning. In the Quran: *"Indeed God and the Angels extend their benediction to the Nabi — O you who believe, likewise present your benediction."* This prayer is a Darood: paying respect to the light that is the inner being of all prophets, which flows into saints and sages.

"The Spirit of Guidance is that prism through which the divine light is refracting and reflecting into creation."

FORMS OF THE SPIRIT OF GUIDANCE

The Spirit of Guidance can take any manner of forms: loving mother, kind father, innocent child, helpful friend, inspiring teacher. The great prophets and teachers of history are focal points of vast movements of people — messengers, bringers of healing and remembrance. There are at least 180,000 such beings; many names have been forgotten.

MAJMA-UL-BAHRAIN — THE MINGLING OF TWO OCEANS

A phenomenon in both inner and outer worlds that the Quran calls Majma-ul-Bahrain — the mingling of two oceans. In India, reflected in the confluence of the Ganga and Yamuna rivers — where one dispensation meets another. The names in Salat include Biblical, Quranic, and Eastern figures — suggesting an intersection of lineages pointing to a vaster pattern.

"There is a very meaningful phenomenon in both inner and outer worlds which the Quran refers to as the Majma-ul-Bahrain, the mingling of two oceans."

NUZUL AND MANZIL — REVELATION AND ITS ACCOMMODATION

Revelation (Nuzul) pours into the world. There is a Manzil — an accommodation, a readiness — where it can alight. It lands everywhere, but certain constellations of individuals are prepared to be central channels. Revelation never happens in isolation; even those at the center collaborate with others holding the light.

"Revelation is coming upon the whole of humanity — even the ones who find themselves at the center of the whole pattern are in close rapport with others who are also holding that light."

AHL AL-BAYT — THE HOUSES AND SYZYGIES

Each name in Salat emblemizes a whole house (Bayt) — an Ahl al-Bayt constellation. When we say Rama, Sita, Lakshman, and Hanuman are all present — a syzygy, a shared house, an ecology of revelation. These houses include men, women, elders, children — all manner of relationships. Houses exist within houses within houses.

Each name points to an oikos — an ecology, the peoples of the houses, the symmetries and geometries between houses.

The Inayatiyya has elaborated Salat with additional names of Ahl al-Bayt constellations.

All of these beings belong to history but also have presence within us — discovering them awakens parts of our own spiritual heritage.

"Each name is just pointing out to an oikos, an ecology, the peoples of the houses, the houses within houses, the symmetries and geometries between the houses — opens out into all of this."

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Deep Teaching: Salat, Darood, and the Spirit of Guidance

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From Concentration to Contemplation - Armored to Porous

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

This session continues Concentration 1, the first stage of a four-stage path unfolding over the program:

Concentration → Contemplation → Meditation → Realization

Timeline: 'over the course of the next two years' — Suluk Academy 2025–2027.

"We're just at the beginning." — This is the very earliest stage.

THE TASK OF CONCENTRATION

The foundational task of concentration is deceptively simple: slow down, be fully present, and take conscious responsibility for attention.

"The task is simply to slow down, be present, be awake, mind one's senses, take responsibility for one's attention, sculpt it, direct it, and in this way, choose what you will create with your mind."

"Mental creation comes into full flower in contemplation. In concentration, we're just beginning — learning to dwell on an experience, to linger over a sight or a sound."

RELEARNING CONCENTRATION

"We live in a world that has sped up so fast that, strangely, concentration hardly comes naturally to us anymore. We have to relearn it — with patience, with dedication, and most of all with the willingness to bring your heart to the moment — a readiness to be in a state of intimacy with what is right here, right now."

Everything we do in our practices together, conversations, prayers — everything is an opportunity to bring the heart to the center of our life.

FROM ARMORED TO POROUS

"After we've been so armored, so bounded, so closed, we're learning to reopen, to be porous. It doesn't mean we're going to soak up every impression and let every idea reverberate in our minds."

Porousness does not mean passive absorption of everything. The same ease that draws the in-breath meets the world; the out-breath releases:

"The same ease with which we learn to draw in a breath and meet the world as it is, characterizes the out-breath, where we let it all go — or at the very least, let go of all that we don't need or wish to carry."

QUALITY OVER QUANTITY

"We don't actually need lots of practices. Sometimes we do many, but it isn't the number that matters. It's a way of being — a certain gentleness, fineness, loving-kindness, and porousness."

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Sobriety and the Body as Spiritual Instrument

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

MURSHID'S TEACHING FROM THE GATHAS

"Sobriety is most necessary in the path of spiritual evolution. Especially in the first stage, when the body must be made pure for spiritual revelation. Everything intoxicating deadens the nerves more or less, and the centers — which are the factors for spiritual realization — become dead."

"The centers which show sensitiveness during intoxication become weary and lifeless afterward. Fakirs or yogis who take intoxicants to excite the centers become dependent on material objects for spiritual experience — and in the end, their seeming advancement becomes fatal."

ON SMOKING AND THE SPIRITUAL CENTERS

"Even hard smoking may block not only the channels of breath, but even the spiritual centers — and thereby intuition is confused. Smoking gives momentary comfort — it brings a kind of repose to the smoker. But it is only a passing comfort. Smoking not only has an effect upon the throat or lungs — the two most important centers, the heart and the brain, upon which all spiritual progress depends, will become blocked."

THE PATH TO SELF-SUFFICIENCY

"The principal thing in spiritual attainment is to be self-sufficient. The first step to self-sufficiency is to make one's body independent of all such things upon which its comfort and enjoyment depend."

PIR ZIA'S COMMENTARY ON THE LATAIF

Pir Zia extends Murshid's teaching with a subtle-body (etheric) explanation:

- Intoxicants act on the Lataif (subtle centers), exciting and stirring them
- The sensation obtained is the result of this artificial excitement
- The centers are left depleted afterward — an artificial high, a corresponding low
- This is well known to anyone who drinks a lot and then feels exhausted and depressed in the morning
- Each Latifa has the capacity to awaken itself naturally — that capacity diminishes with external dependency

THE NATURAL PATH TO ALTERED STATES

"Drugs can open the doors of perception and reveal dimensions unacknowledged in the collective paradigm of our time — hence their attraction. But many of those who discovered

the invisible this way realized before long that there is a path into the invisible that doesn't require the use or abuse of substances — and which instead involves the cultivation of our own natural capacities."

"We can appreciate the possibility of taking our consciousness as our own responsibility — and learning to craft it, to sculpt it, to elevate it, and to lift it down into states of repose — all by means of the clarity of our own intention through the medium of the awakened breath."

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Vanity - The Magic Plant That Cannot Be Rooted Out

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

MURSHID'S TEACHING ON VANITY AND THE EGO

"The whole manifestation is the expression of that spirit of Logos, which in Sufi terms is called Kibria. Through every being, this spirit is manifested in the form of vanity, pride, or conceit. Vanity, expressed crudely, is called pride. Had it not been for this spirit working in every being as the central theme of life, no good or bad would have existed in the world, nor would there have been great or small. All virtues and every evil are offspring of this spirit."

"The art of personality is to cut off the rough edges of the spirit of vanity, which hurts and disturbs those one meets in life. The person who says 'I' — the more he does so, the more he disturbs the mind of his listeners. Yet if this spirit of vanity is pronounced, it will creep up in spite of all good manners and beautiful language — calling aloud: 'I am, I am.' If a person be speechless, his or her vanity will leap out in the expression of his or her glance."

VANITY VS. PASSIONS - THE HARDER BATTLE

"For adepts, the struggle in life is not so great with the passions and emotions, which sooner or later, by more or less effort, can be controlled. But vanity — it is always growing. If one cuts down its stem, then one cannot live, for it is the very self. It is the I. The ego, the soul, or God within — it cannot be denied its existence. But struggling with it beautifies it more and more, and makes more and more tolerable that which in its crude form is intolerable."

THE MAGIC PLANT - VANITY TRANSFORMED

"Vanity may be likened to a magic plant. If one sees it growing as a thorny plant and cuts it down, it will grow in another place as a fruit tree. And when one cuts it down again, it will spring up as a bush of fragrant roses. It exists just the same, but in a more beautiful form — which gives happiness to those who touch it."

"The art of personality does not teach the rooting out of the seed of vanity, which cannot be rooted out as long as one lives — but its crude outer garb may be destroyed, in order that, after dying several deaths, it may manifest as the plant of desires."

WORKING WITH THE EGO

The ego is inherent in human constitution and in the cosmos itself — it is an expression of the Divine, not an accident. It cannot and ought not be rooted out. Yet it tends to develop in unconsciousness, seeing itself as the sole center of the universe.

“The universe is a circle whose center is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere.”

How do we work with the ego? By watching its workings, seeing it in action, then slowing it down:

- If it wasn't charming when someone else was boasting — is our own boasting any different?
- What is the real need? If I've imagined a need for a certain kind of attention — that's a distraction.
- What truly fulfills, nourishes, and advances me in the journey of being?

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Living Concentration as a Way of Life

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

SINGLE-MINDEDNESS IS THE SECRET

Murshid teaches us that true concentration becomes a way of being:

> *"When a person develops concentration, she does not need a regular concentration, although a Sufi likes to do it, for her life becomes a concentration."*
>
> *"If she is speaking on a certain subject, she does not suddenly change the subject of the conversation. If she is thinking about something, she does not change her mind and leave it half done in order to accomplish something else. She continues at every moment the work she is doing at that time until it is finished. That is the secret of concentration."*

PIR ZIA'S COMMENTARY ON EVERYDAY PRACTICE

“Eventually concentration doesn't need to be a practice that one does in the way of visualizing red or visualizing an emerald. Every moment becomes an opportunity to practice attention.”

Signs of a Scattered Mind

- Thinking two thoughts at once and not doing justice to either
- Walking into a room and forgetting why you went there
- Starting sentences that end with *“dot, dot, dot”* instead of completion

The Practice of Completion

"Completing what one starts is itself a great practice. If one has taken something up — just to finish it — is important. It brings completeness and gives you more energy for what is to come next."

Being Serious - Not Solemn

"Not serious in the way of being solemn and grim, but serious in the sense of giving it one's heart, meeting it with care, and being ready to put into it all that it's going to require."

Self-inquiry questions before undertaking anything:

- *"Am I ready to give my heart to it?"*
- *"What is that going to mean?"*
- *"Am I going to really follow through?"*

Escorting Thoughts Deeper

"Maybe think fewer thoughts, but honor your thoughts. Escort your thoughts to the deeper spaces within your own psyche. That's concentration — and it leads to contemplation and on to meditation."

"We're not going to be led to the center of everything if we just skim the surface. What leads us down, down to the center is this care, this steadiness, this giving of the heart to what we're confronting."

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Sacrament of Attention and Theophanies

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

LETTING GO - THE QUALITY OF RELEASE

"Don't hold on to anything you don't need to. As soon as you let it go, it's just inconsequential — as if it never existed. And what a relief to exhale it and let it go."

"You breathe out and that cloudy, viscous, murky dust starts dissipating. You know it's going. And you know that you've been accumulating this residue for a long time. Finally, now, you're letting it go."

THE SACRAMENT OF HOLDING

"This precious energy that is in your awareness — this focus, this heartfulness — to give it purposefully, meaningfully, bestow it as you will. And in that bestowal, feel the sacrament of holding a process, an experience, an object of attention for the full term of wished-for witnessing, discovery, revelation — and then let it go and meet what is next."

THEOPHANIES - DIVINE DISCLOSURES

"And the theophanies, the disclosures from the source of being are never repeated, never identical. Stay with the color till you reach the end of it. And go on and meet the color that is coming."

The Uniqueness of Each Moment

Each color, each practice, each moment of genuine attention is a **unique disclosure from the Source** — never to be repeated. This is why presence matters: each theophany is once only.

THE SACRED ARC OF ATTENTION

1. **Purposeful Bestowal** - Give attention meaningfully
2. **Full Term Witnessing** - Stay present for the complete revelation
3. **Sacred Release** - Let go when the disclosure is complete
4. **Meeting What Comes Next** - Open to the new theophany

THE SACRAMENT DEFINED

Attention itself becomes sacramental when we:

- Recognize its preciousness
- Give it purposefully
- Hold the full arc of witnessing
- Release completely to meet what follows

This transforms every moment of concentrated awareness into a sacred encounter with divine disclosure.

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Vision as a Cross-Section of a Multi-Dimensional Landscape

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

BEYOND HABITUAL SEEING

Pir Zia teaches that our ordinary way of seeing — picking out objects, differentiating things — is only one mode of vision. The eyes have developed to prioritize discerning *"this thing and that thing,"* but there are other ways of looking.

"Instead of immediately outlining the boundary of a thing, we discern the ways in which qualities advance and recede and mingle on all of the horizons in a constant flux."

THE INVISIBLE DIMENSIONS

“There's much that is not visible because it belongs to another wavelength. The eyes only see certain wavelengths. Or because it's occluded — for instance, the entire interior of our own bodies. When we partake of a meal, we don't witness the process of digestion.”

“If we could see it, it might alter the impression we have of being a thing, bounded, separate. We could see the breath moving through the bloodstream, through the cells, the water that we drink churning in our bloodstream. We would see more.”

THE FULL REALITY

“Our vision is just a little cross-section of a multi-dimensional landscape that consists not so much as an array of objects as it does a constant process of transformations involving all manner of organic and inorganic configurations of energy.”

THE INVITATION

“Let your eyes become rapturous explorers of the divine manifestation in the visible and invisible worlds, rather than merely habituated reinforcers of preconceived expectations.”

“Let your eyes surprise you, delight you. Let your eyes be practitioners of concentration, able to rest for moments at a time on something that in the eyes of the world is of no practical value.”

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Will as Divine Power and Sacred Trust

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

WILL = ALL THE POWER THAT IS

"Will is not a power. It is all the power that is." — Murshid

"The creation of the world is an act of will by God. Therefore, that in us which we call willpower is in reality God-power. When this power is recognized and affirmed, it increases in potential and strength." — Murshid

PHYSICAL MANIFESTATION OF WILL

"Our hands, with their perfect mechanism, would not be able to hold even a glass of water if there was no willpower to support them. A person may seem to be healthy, but if willpower fails him, he will not be able to stand. It is not the body which makes a person stand upright. It is our willpower." — Murshid

"Success and failure are the phenomena of willpower." — Murshid

WILL = LOVE = GOD

"What is willpower made of? In metaphysical terms, willpower is love. If one says God is love, it really means God is will. God loves creation — only after God came to will its creation." — Murshid

"Will and consciousness are fundamentally the same. It is the dual expression of the same thing. In action, it is will. In stillness, it is consciousness. It is just

as sound and light are fundamentally one thing — in one condition producing light through the friction of vibrations, in another producing sounds that are audible." — Murshid

WILL AS SACRED TRUST

"This will that is in us, this will that is ours, is far more precious than anything we may believe we own."

"When we are unaware of it, it fragments, weakens, and we become easily caught up in the will of others — because we don't know our own will."

"When we know that will is our sacred trust, then we perceive the responsibility that comes with it. It's the ultimate power of creation."

ALIGNING WITH THE DIVINE WILL

"As this will in us is divine in origin, divine in essence — the highest purpose, the fullest, deepest purpose to which we can devote it — is in responding to the divine will, aligning with the divine will, seeking to embody the divine will. Not by way of presumption, not by way of making any kind of claim — but by the giving over of that which is most free in us, the offering of it up to the all-pervading."

CONCENTRATION AS GATHERING THE WILL

"When we practice concentration, we're accepting responsibility for our own consciousness — endeavoring to make this energy that is within us, this power, this luminous substance — to make it whole, to collect it, to concentrate it."

"How can we offer our will to the divine when it's scattered? We don't even know the location of its parts. Concentration is drawing it together, affirming it, exercising it."

"The exercises that we're doing are not ends in themselves. They're simply opportunities to put into practice the concentrating and enlivening and reawakening of this freedom that's in us."

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Commentary on Burden - Lightness and Letting Go

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"So don't be discouraged if you've stumbled, even if you've failed at your endeavors a thousand times. Never mind — keep going. Hope guides."

THE WEIGHT OF CARRIED IMPRESSIONS

"Don't carry with you the impressions of the past which weigh you down. The jarring pictures, the voices of despair — none of us can afford to carry such a load."

"Lightness, lightness of mind, quickens our steps on the journey. Clears our sight."

DIRECT PERSONAL ADDRESS

“Is there something that's weighing on you? Something that has burdened you now for too long? You needn't carry it. No one is requiring this of you. It's your choice to carry it or not carry it.”

UNCONSCIOUS CARRYING

“Too often these choices are made unconsciously. One doesn't mean to carry it, but one carries it nonetheless. The time has come to be intentional and choose to lay it down.”

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Progress vs Standstill - The Clock Analogy

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE CLOCK ANALOGY

“As dust gets into the works of a clock and stops the clock, so the effect produced by all impressions that are void of beauty and harmony, and which disturb your peace, keeps you from progress.”

“The mind cannot act properly when it is hindered by impressions which have a paralyzing effect upon it.”

LIFE IS PROGRESS

“Life is progress. And stopping from progress is death.”

“Failure does not matter in life. To a progressive person, even a thousand failures do not matter. He has before his view success — and success is his, even after a thousand failures.”

“The greatest pity in life is that standstill when life does not move farther. A sensible person prefers death to such a life as that. It is a paralysis of the soul, of the spirit, which is always caused by holding bad impressions in the mind.”

THE SOUL'S NATURAL HAPPINESS

“No soul is deprived of happiness in reality. The soul's very being is happiness. Man brings unhappiness upon himself by holding in one's hands the clouds of bad impressions, which fall as a shadow upon one's soul.”

“Once a person is able to clear from their mind, by whatever process, the undesirable impressions — a new power begins to spring from his heart, opening a way before him, attracting to him all that he requires, clearing from his path all obstacles, and making his atmosphere clear for him to live and move, and to accomplish all one wishes to accomplish.”

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Purity of Mind - Five Methods of Destroying Impressions

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

MURSHID'S CORE TEACHING

"Purity of mind requires the destroying of all bad impressions collected there or received at present. One can destroy these impressions by five methods — and the method is chosen according to the impression one has to destroy."

THE FIVE METHODS

1. **Wash off** from the mind
2. **Erase** from the surface of the mind
3. **Shake off** like dust from the clothes
4. **Burn** like wood in fire — after its test by fire, it turns into ashes
5. **Drown** so that they will never come up again

Additional Method:

"Bury certain impressions like a corpse. Find every way of annihilation that is suited to each impression, so that your mind may be clear."

THE MIND AS KING

"The mind is not only a means of thinking or reasoning, but the king of one's being. Upon the condition of the mind, one's health, happiness, and peace in life depend."

WHAT TO COLLECT / WHAT TO DESTROY

"Collect and keep all that is beautiful — destroy all that is void of beauty."

"Collect and keep all that is agreeable — destroy all that has a disagreeable effect upon you."

"Collect and keep all that is harmonious — destroy all that creates disharmony in yourself."

"Collect and keep all that is restful — destroy all that disturbs the peace of your life."

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The Meaning of Suluk - Traveling the Path

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"Suluk means travel. Saliks are travelers. We're on a journey."

"We've come to realize there's a destination. And there's a way."

"Since, in any case, all is change. Nothing stays the same."

REACTIVE VS. WAKEFUL RESPONSE

"Anything is possible. At the same time, we know that whatever arises may be met reactively, unconsciously, distractedly — or it may be met wakefully, conscientiously, compassionately, wisely."

"Our intention is to meet the changing terrain of life with wisdom."

"Our intention is to navigate this world and the worlds beyond in the most beautiful way possible."

THE MOUNTAINEER'S PATH

"How does a mountaineer passing through the rugged peaks and deep chasms travel well?"

"It's wise to follow a route that has been already explored."

"The ones who have gone ahead have blazed the trail and even removed obstacles from the path in advance. And as we travel behind them, we benefit from their foresight."

"Debris may have meanwhile interposed itself" — our responsibility to clear fresh debris.

"Our task is to follow the path that has been revealed and do our part in keeping the path clear for those who come after."

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What to Carry - Lightness as Imperative

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"If one is traveling a very short distance, then one might succeed in dragging along many heavy things. But if one is going a great distance, then a light load is imperative."

THE WEIGHT TEST

"Does its usefulness justify its weight?"

THREE WAYS TO RELEASE WHAT WE CARRY

1. **Pass Along**: Things others could beneficially use → pass them along
2. **Return to Nature**: Things to give back to nature itself
3. **Conscious Dissolution**: Things to consciously pulverize and return to dust

"We stop at way stations along the way. And at each way station, there's an opportunity to re-examine what we're carrying."

"Certain things are best returned to the cosmos by very consciously pulverizing them, reducing them to dust."

THE GUIDING QUESTION

"Is there something that I'm carrying that the time has come to relinquish?"

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Five Aspects of Mind — Complete Teaching

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia enumerated all five aspects of mind in sequence, forming the interior architecture the program has been developing. Each aspect is both a faculty of mind and a station on the path of inward concentration.

THE FIVE ASPECTS

1. **Sensation** — the most immediate faculty of mind
2. **Memory** — the faculty that holds and retrieves
3. **Imagination** — the creative/generative faculty
4. **Will** — the faculty of intention and direction
5. **Self** — the deepest aspect, introduced as the culminating fifth

THE HIERARCHICAL CHAIN

The five aspects of mind form a hierarchical chain: each faculty arising from and resting in the deeper faculty below it, until the deepest — Self — dissolves into soul.

"Will emerges from it, and imagination, and memory, and sensation. But these other faculties again and again find their repose in the I."

"Which is the essence of mind. It's where the mind merges into the soul."

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Listening to Murshid's Melody — Orchestrated by Count Sergei Tolstoy

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE FIFTH SENSE: HEARING

As part of the concentration practices engaging all five senses, Pir Zia introduces a listening practice using a melody communicated by Hazrat Inayat Khan and orchestrated by Count Sergei Tolstoy.

THE PRACTICE

"And listen well, give a whole heart to it. For listening — if you wish to have your eyes open, you are welcome to do so, but also very welcome to keep your eyes closed."

"Just be relaxed, settle into a position in which you can stay for the next 5 or 10 minutes. And realize there's nowhere else you have to be. Nothing else you have to do and so you can entirely give yourself to this piece of music."

"We're going to listen to a melody communicated by Murshid and orchestrated by Count Sergei Tolstoy. Let's begin."

REFLECTION AFTER LISTENING: WHO IS THE SELF LISTENING?

After the music, Pir Zia poses the question of identity:

"Who has listened? Who is the self listening? Is it the persona — this character on the stage of life consisting of self-image, a self-image that is composed of a variety of attitudes, judgements, assumptions, and which is a constant negotiation between how we would like to be seen and how others see us?"

"Or is it something that looms behind this character? Something that was awake before we were born. Before we were conceived. And which will be awake after we die."

HISTORICAL NOTE

Count Sergei Tolstoy was a Russian musician and the son of the famous writer Leo Tolstoy. He orchestrated melodies that Hazrat Inayat Khan had communicated, preserving the musical dimension of the Sufi teachings.

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Opening Reflection — Pir Zia's Farewell Remarks

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

This is the closing session of the first five-day gathering of the Qaf class within Suluk Global 2025–2027.

PERSONAL FAREWELL

"Dear friends, we are coming to the end of this gathering and the end of the first five days of Suluk for the Qaf class."

"It's been a pleasure to be with you. And to be getting to know you together and one by one."

PROGRAM STRUCTURE AND NEXT TEACHER

"When you meet next time, it will be with another teacher — with Urs Qutbuddin."

"Who I recommend with all of my heart."

"You'll be in the very best of good hands with Urs Qutbuddin."

"I'll be with you in spirit and then, God willing, joining you in the succeeding sessions back and forth — five days at a time."

PROGRAM ARCHITECTURE

Program structure clarified: Pir Zia steps away between five-day intensives, with Urs Qutbuddin continuing the work in those intervals.

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The Fifth Aspect of Mind — Self (Persona vs. Witness)

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

This is the culminating teaching of the entire five-day retreat. After the listening practice, Pir Zia opened direct inquiry into identity and selfhood.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

"Who has listened? Who is the self-listening?"

THE PERSONA — THE SUBJECTIVE SELF

Pir Zia described the persona as the constructed, social, ever-negotiating self:

"This character on the stage of life, consisting of self-image — a self-image that is composed of a variety of attitudes, judgements, assumptions — and which is a constant negotiation between how we would like to be seen and how others see us."

"This persona that's patched together, forged of various influences, and which is always a work in progress."

THE WITNESS — THE OBJECTIVE SELF

"Something that looms behind this character. Something that was awake before we were born, before we were conceived, and which will be awake after we die. That doesn't change when the opinions of the character change or when the social profile of the character alters."

"The I that is the EYE. The I that is the space of experience. Not so much the character on the stage as the theater itself — the witness."

"It's this sheer, luminous presence that hosts all manner of perceptions and emotions — but isn't them."

BOTH ARE OURSELVES

"Which one is oneself? The persona or the pre-existing I-ness? Both are ourselves. One the subjective self, the other the objective self. And each has its part to play in the story of the soul."

"But which goes deeper? Which lasts longer? Which is steady when the other is careening? We know the answer."

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Part I · Chapter 7

STORIES & PARABLES

Teaching Through the Heart's Ear

Stories are the Sufi's oldest teaching tool. The stories shared by Pir Zia — from the boy who only wrote Alif to Rumi's shepherd and Moses — plant seeds directly in the heart.

5 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

The Story of Mount Qaf - Earth's Spiritual Anchor

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE STORY

When God created the Earth, she orbited the sun in ecstasy and began to envision the unfolding of life — oceans, continents, animals, humanity. But as she foresaw the course of human history — the tragedies, the violence, the suffering — she began to shake and wobble in her orbit.

To anchor and stabilize her, God raised up **Mount Qaf** — a monumental spiritual mountain. Though not visible to physical eyes, its roots work through all the mountain ranges of the earth, sinking deep into the earth's mantle and core.

THE FUNCTION OF MOUNT QAF

Mount Qaf functions as a great spiritual circulatory system, creating connection between the planes of existence:

- Mounting from **Nasut** to **Malakut**
- From **Malakut** to **Jabrut**
- From **Jabrut** to **Lahut**
- And onward to **HaHut**

Anchoring the physical earth in the spiritual depths from which it emerges.

THE EMERALD PEAK AND THE DIVAN

At the crown of the mountain is an **emerald peak**. Emerald — in the alchemy of Sufism — is the color that outlasts all others, sums them all up, and bespeaks the perfect integration of all opposites.

There the **Divan**, the League of Bodhisattvas who guard and guide the world, have their seat.

THIS CLASS NAME

This class is named **Mount Qaf** — **Qaf** — the cosmic anchor between Earth and the divine realms.

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The Story of the Boy and the Alif

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE STORY

In a village classroom, a teacher began teaching the Arabic alphabet. One child showed exceptional devotion to the very first letter — **Alif**, the upright line — and refused to move on to the others.

Dismissed and misunderstood by his teacher and peers, he left home and disappeared into the jungle for years.

When he finally returned and wrote Alif on the blackboard, the entire room shook with light. He had truly mastered the one. He then went on to master all the other letters and became one of the greatest Sufi poets of the land.

THE TEACHING

> *"A Salik could do one practice for their whole life and reach the divine presence. What is powerful is to bring one's whole being to whatever it is."*

This story teaches **quality over quantity** — depth over accumulation. The essence of Suluk is not in multitudinous practices but in the wholehearted spirit with which one gives oneself to the work.

THE LESSON FOR SEEKERS

True mastery comes not from rushing through many practices, but from bringing complete dedication and presence to whatever practice is given. The depth of engagement matters far more than the breadth of techniques.

The boy's devotion to the single letter Alif — the symbol of Unity — ultimately opened all doors to him, demonstrating that the One contains the All.

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The Young Lady and the Man in Prayer

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

A teaching story about concentration and the power of love.

THE STORY

A young lady was on her way to meet her beloved. Fully absorbed in anticipation, she walked directly in front of a man who was praying — a breach of normal decorum. The man quickly finished his prayer and stopped her: *“Didn't you see I was praying to God at that moment?”*

She replied with sincere apology: *“I am so sorry — I didn't see you. All my thought was with the one I love and whom I am going to see.”*

In that instant the man was struck: she did not see him because she was absorbed in her beloved — but how was it that he saw her, when his prayer was directed to the Beloved of all?

THE TEACHING

- Sincere love makes concentration natural and effortless — the young lady's love was single-pointed and undistracted
- Distraction in devotion reveals the heart is not yet fully absorbed in the Beloved
- The path moves from single-object love (one beloved) toward perceiving the Beloved in every being, every direction, every trace of existence
- Every stage has value — the distracted man and the absorbed young lady are both on the journey toward ever-vaster love

"It's a story about concentration and how love, sincere love, makes concentration possible."

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The Story of Hazrat Ali - Breath and Right Action

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia uses this account to illustrate breath as the arbiter of right action under provocation.

"Hazrat Ali was fighting a fierce enemy and was about to deal the decisive blow when just at that moment, his enemy spat in his face. And then, instead of striking down his foe — as it was fully in his power to do — he sheathed his sword and walked away."

When asked why he withdrew from victory, Hazrat Ali answered that when he fought in the first place, it was for the noble cause — for the cause of defending the beleaguered. But when this opponent spat in his face, he aroused his anger. And as Hazrat Ali was determined never to act in anger, he sheathed his sword.

"One might say that Hazrat Ali observed a change in his own breath, and that change required him to withdraw — to bring his breath back into its fundamental rhythm before taking action of any kind."

THE TEACHING APPLIED UNIVERSALLY

- Certain provocations will temporarily throw us out of rhythm — this cannot always be prevented
- The question: are we aware of that departure from the natural rhythm of the breath?
- If aware: do we have the clarity to pause, recalibrate, and only then proceed?

"Whatever is done with breath askew will be badly done. Whatever is done with breath aligned will be well done."

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Birbal and Emperor Akbar - The Crescent and Full Moon

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE STORY

Birbal was the witty minister at the court of the Mughal King Akbar. One day Akbar sent Birbal as ambassador to the court of the Emperor of Iran.

At the Iranian court, Birbal addressed the monarch:

"Oh your majesty — you are such a tremendous force in this world. You are, if I may say so, the full moon — as compared to our own Akbar Shah, who is more like a mere crescent."

The Shah was delighted and honored Birbal with great largesse, sending him back with many gifts.

Birbal returned to Fatehpur Sikri — Akbar's court — where his fellow ministers reported what he had said.

Akbar confronted Birbal: *"Now, Birbal — I can hardly believe it. Did you really say such a thing?"*

And Birbal said: *"Of course I said that! I meant every word."*

BIRBAL'S EXPLANATION

"I said he's like a full moon. What's going to happen to the full moon? It's going to wane — it's going to start fading. The crescent moon is that power that's rising and rising, becoming fuller and fuller. It's on the ascendancy."

Akbar was happy with that explanation — and Birbal was doubly rewarded.

THE SUFI TEACHING

The crescent is the symbol of spiritual ascent — rising, filling, on the ascendancy.

Birbal's wit demonstrates:

- **Presence** in the moment
- **Intelligence** that sees deeper meanings
- The ability to **transform a potential offense into deeper understanding**
- How the same words can carry multiple layers of truth

SPIRITUAL SYMBOLISM

- **Full Moon**: Apparent completion that contains the seed of decline
- **Crescent Moon**: The power of ascendancy, continuous growth toward fullness
- **Double Reward**: The fruits of wisdom that serves multiple purposes simultaneously

The story illustrates how spiritual insight can navigate worldly diplomacy while revealing deeper truths about the nature of spiritual development.

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Part I · Chapter 8

QUOTES, SAYINGS & POETRY

Luminous Fragments

The compressed wisdom of the aphorism, the saying, and the poem. Key quotes and poetry from Pir Zia's sessions, including readings from Hazrat Inayat Khan and the great Sufi poets.

11 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Key Quotes from Pir Zia - Concentration Class 1

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

ON THE NATURE OF SELF AND JOURNEY

"The journey is a journey of recollection — recollecting yourselves, bringing the parts back together. Remembrance — bringing the different members back into unity. And not only within ourselves, because what is a self? A self itself is a fragment of a greater whole."

ON INTENTION

"If the intention is clear, if it's sincere, if it's focused, we'll get through everything easily."

ON RECOGNITION OF TRUTH

"The eyes must be sun-like to see the sun. Whatever elevates you, inspires you, motivates you, reassures you, consoles you — it does so because it meets in you the truth that is already there."

ON CONCENTRATION

"Concentration means the whole of you is in one place. You are not scattered. You are not dispersed. You are not diffused. You are gathered. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can pray. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can meditate. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can create. If one can learn to concentrate, then one can love. The whole of life depends on concentration."

ON QUALITY VS QUANTITY

"A Salik could do one practice for their whole life and reach the divine presence. What is powerful is to bring one's whole being to whatever it is."

ON THE ALIF

"The upright line suggests heaven, perfection, straightforwardness, firmness, life, rising, and unity — as it shows oneness with the whole. The upright line is the first line, and all forms and figures are nothing but the change of direction of that line."

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Sayings and Aphorisms from Concentration Class 1

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

TRADITIONAL SUFI SAYINGS

Al-Mu'min Mir'atu'l-Mu'min

"The believer is a mirror to the believer."

The spirit of companionship on this path is to mirror the divinity shining out from each one.

FROM SAYED ABU HASHIM MADANI

> *"In this world there is no friendship like the friendship on the path."*

SUFI CONCEPTS

Khalwat dar Anjuman

> *"Solitude in the crowd"*

Even when meditating in silence, one is never alone. The class meets in the inner worlds through the intention that joins them.

TEACHING PRINCIPLES

> *"Everyone comes from the same source, is returning to the source, is sustained all the while by the source."*
>
> *"These prayers are not intended to displace the prayers of the religion to which you belong, but rather to shine a light that reveals the depths of your faith even more clearly than ever before."*

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Key Teaching Quotes from Session 2

Source: C2 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

ON HEART-TO-HEART TEACHING

"Not to differentiate between what seemed obviously mystical and what didn't seem particularly mystical — but instead just to listen to everything, take in everything, and engrave it on the notebook of your heart." — Pir Zia on Murshid's teaching

ON BREATH AND SPEECH

"There is no voice without breath. There is no speech without respiration. And when we go into silence, when the words fall away, what remains is inhalation and exhalation." — Pir Zia

ON ATTENTION

"Attention is a substance that can be molded into any form, can be given any color." — Pir Zia

"If you give attention to attention, then it flourishes, it blossoms, it becomes very luminous." — Pir Zia

ON ETERNITY AND ATTENTION

"That which your heart meets, in some mysterious way, is introduced into eternity."
— Pir Zia

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Key Teachings from September 13 Session

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

ON AMAN PRAYER

"We wish to be part of a transformation that heals these insufferable wounds, that mends the breaches, that doesn't allow any life to be disregarded as less than precious."

"Whatever we do, bring our heart to it."

"We want to witness what others are going through, we don't want to turn away from it, we want to be in solidarity, and we take it very seriously."

ON PRAYER PRACTICE

"Find the place of your strength — and then offer your obeisance."

ON THE SPIRIT OF GUIDANCE

"There's a soul of souls, a mind of minds, a body of bodies — still created, still ephemeral, not the infinite one that is all and everything, but rather the essence of creation."

"The Spirit of Guidance is the first of creation, the cosmic being — the mirror of the Absolute."

ON SPEAKING OF OTHERS

"If we're going to speak about someone, is it possible to imagine them in the room and think of them as a soul as well as a body — and then speak?"

"How would you speak about someone in the presence, not only of that person, but of the human being who is the exemplar of your highest ideals — and in the presence of all the bodhisattvas, and in the awareness of the divine immanence?"

ON BREATH PRACTICE

"Each inhalation cascading through the body right down to the tips of the toes, satisfying a deep thirst."

"In this communion, in this participation, breath by breath, there is joy for the cells, and peace, and an inkling of the oneness of all being."

ON ATTENTION AND POSSIBILITY

"What is possible depends on what we give to it, what attention we give to it, what care we give to it. Everything is possible with that attention."

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Noor-un-Nisa on Speaking of Others

Source: C3 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Noor-un-Nisa Inayat Khan's saying, recalled by her friend Jeanne Overton Fuller:

"I never speak ill of a flower for fear of offending the fairy that is doing its best to make the flower beautiful."

This saying was shared in the context of Iron Rule 2: *"My conscientious self, speak not against others in their absence."*

It beautifully illustrates the recognition of the divine presence working through all beings, and the reverence with which we should speak of others, seeing them as souls as well as bodies.

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Breath as Cosmic Process

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"Breath is the churning of the life field itself. Oxygen and carbon dioxide are just one component of the larger process of expansion and contraction, assimilation and disgorgement — essential to all of the patterns of this world and of the inner worlds."

"Spring and fall, sleeping and waking, birth and death — all of the cycles of our lives are expressions of this contraction and expansion, which is constantly occurring through the breath."

— Pir Zia Inayat Khan

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Body as Temple - Opening Teaching

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"We spoke of the body as a temple — and with the kinds of movements that re-up the circulation and the breath, that temple comes into still fuller cohesion and becomes a more spacious vessel for the spirit to function in."

"So it's really a blessing whenever we can experience this kind of fluidity and opening up of the channels."

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Mount Qaf — Closing Vision

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia closed with a vision of Mount Qaf as the symbol of the retreat's ground and aspiration:

"May this mountain be the grounding, the stability in which we find renewal in the midst of the shaking of the earth — culminating in its emerald peak where physical and spiritual worlds coincide, and where the divan gathers in service to the furtherance of creation."

FINAL BLESSING

May your heart be filled with heavenly joy.

May your soul be illuminated with divine light.

May your spirit unfold the divine message.

May you go on in the spiritual path.

May God's peace abide with you forever and evermore. Amen.

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Sayed Abu Hasim Madani on Breath as Virtue

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE QUOTE

"In this path there is one sin and one virtue — and virtue is the breath: breathe in with Divine awareness. The sin is the breath that escapes in negligence."

— Sayed Abu Hasim Madani

THE TRIPLE ALIGNMENT

From the wakeful, rhythmic, attuned breath comes a triple alignment:

- Soul ↔ Mind ↔ Body
- Soul ↔ Soul of Souls
- Mind ↔ Mind of Minds
- Body ↔ Body of all Bodies

"All felicity comes from this, from this alignment."

RECALIBRATING THE BREATH

"When we find ourselves in a scattered state, the most important thing is to recalibrate the breath."

The natural rhythm: balance between inhalation and exhalation — evenness, consistency — 'like a pendulum, like the tides on the shore of the sea.' If this rhythm was absent during a difficult episode, the outcome would have been very different.

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Key Quotes from Concentration Session

Source: C8 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

ON LIVING CONCENTRATION

"When a person develops concentration, she does not need a regular concentration, although a Sufi likes to do it, for her life becomes a concentration." — Murshid

"Single-mindedness is the secret of concentration." — Murshid

"Eventually concentration doesn't need to be a practice that one does in the way of visualizing red or visualizing an emerald. Every moment becomes an opportunity to practice attention." — Pir Zia

ON WILL AND DIVINE POWER

"Will is not a power. It is all the power that is." — Murshid

"Will is essential. Will is divine." — Murshid

ON THE NATURE OF ATTENTION

"Each speaks what he owns." — Jesus (as taught by Pir Zia)

"The theophanies, the disclosures from the source of being are never repeated, never identical." — Pir Zia

ON MOONLIGHT AND RECEPTIVITY

"You can't stare into the sun, but you can gaze directly at the moon." — Pir Zia

"The moon simply receives the light it's given and sends it onward." — Pir Zia

"Does the moon have any opinions?" — Pir Zia

ON SEEING AND VISION

"Let your eyes become rapturous explorers of the divine manifestation in the visible and invisible worlds, rather than merely habituated reinforcers of preconceived expectations." — Pir Zia

"Where has the crescent gone? It's no less in you now than it was when you saw it. But when you saw it, you manifested it." — Pir Zia

ON COMPLETION AND DEPTH

"We're not going to be led to the center of everything if we just skim the surface. What leads us down, down to the center is this care, this steadiness, this giving of the heart to what we're confronting." — Pir Zia

"Maybe think fewer thoughts, but honor your thoughts. Escort your thoughts to the deeper spaces within your own psyche." — Pir Zia

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Walking Practice Sufi Saying

Source: C10 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

From Pir Zia's closing teaching on the walking practice for the two-year Suluk journey:

“Let your soul be where your soles are. Let your soles be where your soul is.”

This saying encapsulates the grounding principle that connects all interior spiritual work to bodily presence and earth contact.

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Part I · Chapter 9

DEEP STUDY & ARABIC TERMS

The Language of the Path

The Sufi path uses a rich vocabulary drawn from Arabic, Persian, and other sacred languages. Arabic terms, glossary entries, and deeper learnings from Pir Zia's sessions.

8 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Arabic and Sufi Terms - Concentration Class 1

Source: C1 · September 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Arabic/Sufi Term · Meaning · Context/Significance

Suluk · Travel; fine manner · The path of intentional inner travel + the art of traveling well (gently, wisely, balanced)

Salik (pl. Saliks) · Traveler on the path · One who undertakes the Suluk journey intentionally

Sohbet · Heart-centered conversation · A form of spiritual companionship and sharing among fellow travelers

Murshid / Pir · Spiritual guide / Elder · Hazrat Pir-o-Murshid Inayat Khan — transmitter of the Inayatiyya teachings

Murid · Student / seeker · One formally initiated into the Inayatiyya or other Tariqa

Tariqa · Path / Order · A Sufi lineage or order (e.g., the Inayatiyya)

Saum · Repose · Daily prayer addressed to the One divine being

Salat / Salawat · Benediction · Daily prayer addressed to the Spirit of Guidance (light of the Rasool)

Alif · First letter of Arabic alphabet; upright line · Symbol of unity, oneness, divine perfection — the root of all letters

Khalwat dar Anjuman · Solitude in the crowd · Meditating together in inner worlds even while physically apart

Qaf / Mount Qaf · The spiritual mountain · Cosmic anchor connecting all planes; this class is named after it

Amān · Sanctuary, safety, protection, refuge · Opening prayer of each Suluk day — holding the world's suffering with compassion

Ashik · Lover / devoted one · One who has deep love for the path or the Murshid without formal initiation

Gayathri · Sacred hymns · Hymns transmitted through Pir-o-Murshid Inayat Khan, used continuously throughout Suluk

Divan · The League of Bodhisattvas · Spiritual guardians and guides of the world; their seat is the emerald peak of Mount Qaf

THE FIVE PLANES OF EXISTENCE

Plane · Arabic Term · Description

1st · **Nasut** · Physical plane

2nd · **Malakut** · Angelic / subtle plane — realm of subtle forms

3rd · **Jabrut** · Plane of power / force — realm of divine attributes

4th · **Lahut** · Divine plane — realm of pure divinity

5th · **HaHut** · Plane of the Absolute — the Absolute beyond all names

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Salat - Benediction, prayer. Not the five-times daily Islamic prayer but has a wider meaning. From the Quran: *"Indeed God and the Angels extend their benediction to the Nabi."*

Darood - Paying respect to the light that is the inner being of all prophets, which flows into saints and sages.

Majma-ul-Bahrain - The mingling of two oceans. A phenomenon in both inner and outer worlds where one dispensation meets another.

Manzil - An accommodation, a readiness where revelation can alight.

Ahl al-Bayt - The houses, constellations of spiritual beings. Each name in Salat emblemizes a whole house.

Bayt - House, referring to spiritual constellations or families.

Malakut - The realm where images exist without physical substance; the imaginal realm.

Jalali - The quality of divine majesty, power, fierce radiance.

Jamali - The quality of divine beauty, grace, delicacy.

Khatum - Closing prayer of gratitude in Suluk gatherings.

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Nazar Par Kadam — Watchfulness of the Step

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

TWO SUFI PRINCIPLES IN PRACTICE

Pir Zia invokes two classical Sufi principles during the soles-breathing practice:

Nazar Par Kadam — *"Be conscious of your breath with each step."* Watchfulness of the step — the practice of bringing full awareness to each footstep, each breath, each movement. Whether walking or lying down, the attention rests on the soles of the feet as a passageway between inner and outer worlds.

Khilwat dar Anjuman — *"Be in communion in meditation."* Solitude in society — maintaining an inner meditative state even while engaged in the outer world.

THE TEACHING

"Be conscious of your breath Nazar Par Kadam. Feel the soles of your feet with each footstep or lying down with each breath Khilwat dar anjuman. Be in communion in meditation."

These two principles form the spiritual foundation of the soles-breathing practice: Nazar Par Kadam brings awareness to the physical point of contact (the soles), while Khilwat dar Anjuman holds the practitioner in a state of inner communion throughout.

CONNECTION TO SOLES-BREATHING PRACTICE

The soles-breathing practice (lying down, breathing through the soles of the feet) is a direct embodiment of these principles — the practitioner watches the breath enter and leave

through the feet (Nazar Par Kadam) while remaining in a state of wakeful meditation (Khilwat dar Anjuman).

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Sensus Communis

Source: C4 · September 13, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Sensus Communis - The unified faculty of perception that can be concentrated and directed through different sensory channels. In practice, it can concentrate itself in the glance (projected out through both eyes as two beams), or be drawn inward to fill all five senses, or be focused in specific areas like the mouth and tongue.

The Sensus Communis represents the common root of all sensory experience, the unified awareness that underlies and coordinates the individual senses.

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Spiritual Terms from Salat Teaching

Source: C6 · September 14, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Salat - Benediction, not the five-times daily Islamic prayer but a wider meaning of presenting benediction to the Spirit of Guidance

Darood - Paying respect to the light that is the inner being of all prophets, which flows into saints and sages

Majma-ul-Bahrain - *"The mingling of two oceans"* - a phenomenon in both inner and outer worlds where one dispensation meets another

Nuzul - Revelation that pours into the world

Manzil - An accommodation, a readiness where revelation can alight

Ahl al-Bayt - *"People of the House"* - constellations or ecologies of beings around each prophet/guide

Bayt - House, referring to the spiritual households or constellations

Oikos - An ecology, the peoples of the houses, the symmetries and geometries between houses

Syzygy - A shared house, an ecology of revelation where multiple beings work together

Malakut - The realm where images exist without physical substance, the imaginal world

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Amen - Phonetics and Sacred Meaning

Source: C7 · October 11, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

ETYMOLOGY AND UNIVERSAL USAGE

The word Amen is shared across the three Abrahamic traditions:

- **Amin** (Judaism)
- **Amen** (Christianity)
- **Ameen** (Islam)

Same root, same word.

It comes from the same root as the word **Aman** that we intone. It's related to the word **Amana** — the Covenant. It bespeaks faithfully upholding a trust, respecting a covenant older than time, a fundamental agreement between ourselves and the Absolute.

PHONETICS OF AMEN — A COMPLETE ARC OF EXISTENCE

A — (Ah)

- Mouth open, vibrating in the chest
- The sound of **LIFE**
- *"Feel it right there in your chest"*

M — (Mim/meme)

- Lips closed
- The sound of **DEATH** — but death as transformation, not ending

EN

- Begins in the **jawz** (resonance point)
- The sound of **RESURRECTION**: 'life revealing itself in a further mode of life'

DEATH AND RESURRECTION TEACHING

"Death doesn't mean what we think it means. Death is not the end. Death is a transformation. After the Mim comes the higher sound — after death, the resurrection, life revealing itself in a further mode of life. Death and resurrection — and this is brought home to us at the end of every prayer."

"All of us will physically die. And we don't know when. But this form of life, this mode of existence, is only for a time. But what we imagine is the end is not the end."

"Throughout all of the permutations of existence, the presiding imperative is the enactment of the ancient covenant — the realization of our agreement with the Absolute."

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Beej Mantras - Seed Syllables

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Beej Mantras: Sanskrit term for seed syllables

CONTEXT FROM TEACHING

"It's said that the words La ilaha illa Allah boil down to three sounds: Ha, Hu, and He. And the Ha is in the chest, and it has its roots deep in the earth."

"Each of these three Beej mantras — Ha, Hu, He — corresponds to one of the dimensions of the primal created being, which is to say: the universe itself."

Ha = the body of the primal/universal creature

These are the fundamental sound vibrations that connect us to different aspects of cosmic being through intonation practice.

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Chthonic and Telluric Energy

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Chthonic: Relating to or inhabiting the underworld; of the earth or soil; subterranean

Telluric: Of or relating to the earth; terrestrial; earth energy

CONTEXT FROM TEACHING

"To give one's attention to it is to begin to notice the upwelling of chthonic energy, telluric life — which moves in the tailbone, in the channel that arises from the tailbone up through the spinal shaft, through the belly, up into the chest."

These terms describe the earth-based life force that rises through the spine during the Ha practice, connecting us to the planetary body and its core energy.

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Ittisal - Mystical Conjunction

Source: C9 · October 12, 2025 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Ittisal (Arabic: اتصال)

Meaning: junction, connection, conjunction

Sufi Definition: The mystical union between the individual soul and the cosmic being

CONTEXT FROM TEACHING

"This is the first in a sequence of intonations, connecting us with the cosmic person by way of Ittisal conjunction."

Ha is the first link in this sequence of mystical connection through sound.

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PART II

THE TEACHINGS OF URS QUTBUDDIN SCHELLENBERG

Concentration II · November 2025 · 3 Classes · 6 Sessions

Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg, based in Zurich with 22 years on the Sufi path, is a European Suluk teacher. He taught Section II of the Concentration program (C11–C20) across two retreat weekends: November 21–23 and December 2025.

Weekend 3: November 21–23, 2025 (C11–C16)
Weekend 4: December 2025 (C17–C20)

122 Teachings · 10 Chapters

Part II · Chapter 1

PRAYERS & INVOCATIONS

The Sacred Words That Open the Way

Urs Qutbuddin continued the prayer teachings in his sessions, deepening the students' relationship with the sacred words and their embodied practice.

6 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Elemental Purification Prayer

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Beloved sovereign, almighty God,
through the rays of the sun,
through the waves of the air,
through the all-pervading life in space,
purify and revivify me.
And we pray, heal our bodies, hearts, and souls.
Amen.

CONTEXT

This prayer was offered following the water elemental breath practice, connecting the elements to divine purification and healing.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

A prayer of elemental purification — addressing the divine through the four natural forces:

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The Invocation

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Towards the one,
the perfection of love, harmony and beauty,
the only being,
united with all the illuminated souls
who form the embodiment of the messenger,
the spirit of guidance.

CONTEXT

This was the full Sufi Invocation (Nayaz) used to open the session before greetings, as recovered from the transcript opening.

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Salawat — The Complete Form

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Three-prayer close marking the end of the November weekend. The Khatum is introduced here for the first time in Section II.

SALAWAT

O most gracious sovereign, messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,
we greet thee with all humility.
Thou art the first cause and the last effect,
the divine light and the spirit of guidance,
Alpha and Omega.
Thy light is in all forms,
Thy love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.
Allow us to recognize thee in all thy holy names and forms:
as Sita and Rama, as Radha and Krishna,
as Parvati, Shiva, Tara, and Buddha.
Let us know thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham,
as Deborah and Solomon,
as Anahita and Zarathustra,
as a seer, Aaron, Miriam, and Moses,
as Mary and Jesus, as Khadijah and Muhammad,
and in the many other names and forms known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy past.
Thy presence deeply enlightens our being,
and we look for Thy blessing in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God,
Thou whose heart constantly reaches upward,
Thou comest on earth with a message
as a dove from above, when Dharma decays,
and speakest the word that is put into Thy mouth
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Let the star of the divine light shining in Thy heart

be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees.
May the message of God reach far and wide,
illuminating and making the whole humanity
as one single family in the parenthood of God.
Amen.

KHATUM

O Thou, who art the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty,
the sovereign of heaven and earth,
open our hearts that we may hear Thy voice
which constantly cometh from within.
Disclose to us Thy divine light which is hidden in our souls,
that we may know and understand life better.
Most merciful and compassionate God,
give us Thy great goodness,
teach us Thy loving forgiveness,
raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us.
Send us the peace of that divine spirit
and unite us all in that perfect being.
Amen.

BLESSING — PIR ZIA / TRADITION

May your heart be filled with heavenly joy.
May your soul be illuminated with divine light.
May your spirit unfold the divine message.
May you go on the spiritual path.
May God's peace abide with you forever and evermore.
Amen.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Most gracious sovereign, messenger, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,
we greet thee with all humility.
Thou art the first cause and the last effect,
the divine light and the spirit of guidance, Alpha and Omega.

Thy light is in all forms. Thy love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.
Allow us to recognize thee in all thy holy names and forms:
as Sita, Rama, Radha, Krishna, as Parvati, Shiva, Tara, and Buddha.
Let us know thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham,
as Deborah and Solomon, as Anahita and Zarathustra,
as Isea, Aaron, Miriam, and Moses,
as Mary and Jesus, as Khadija and Mohammed,
and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy past. Thy presence deeply enlightens our being.
We look for Thy blessing in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God,
Thou whose heart constantly reaches upward,
Thou comest on earth with a message as a dove from above, when Dharma decays,
and speakest the word that is put into Thy mouth
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Let the star of the divine light shining in Thy heart
be reflected in the hearts of Thy devotees.
May the message of God reach far and wide,
illuminating and making the whole humanity
as one single family in the parenthood of God. Amin.
May your heart be filled with heavenly joy.
May your soul be illuminated with divine light.
May your spirit unfold the divine message.
May you go on the spiritual path.
May God's peace abide with you forever and evermore.
Amen.
Full gender-inclusive Salawat as given by Urs at session close. Variant form: 'Seer, Aaron, Miriam and Moses' (where C10 had 'Asiya, Aaron, Maryam and Moses').
Most gracious Lord, Master, Messiah, and Savior of humanity,
we greet thee with all humility.

Thou art the first cause and the last effect,
the divine light and the spirit of guidance,
Alpha and Omega.
Let us know thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham,
as Deborah, Solomon, Anahita, and Zarathustra,
as a seer, Aaron, Miriam, and Moses,
and as Mary and Jesus, Khadija, and Muhammad,
and in many other names and forms known and unknown to the world.
We adore thy past.
Thy presence deeply enlightens our being,
and we look for thy blessings in the future.
Oh Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God,
thou whose heart constantly reacheth upward.
Thou comest on earth with a message,
as a dove from above, when Dharma declines,
and speakest the word that is put into thy mouth,
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Thy light is in all forms,
Thy love in all beings:
as a loving mother, as a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, and in an inspiring teacher.
Oh messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God,
thou whose heart constantly reaches upward,
thou comest on earth with a message
as a dove from above, when thy law decays,
and speakest the word that is put into thy mouth
as the light filleth the crescent moon.
Thou art the first cause and the last effect,
the divine light and the spirit of guidance, Alpha and Omega.
Thy light is in all forms, Thy love in all beings:
in a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child,
in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher.

Let us know thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham,
as Deborah and Solomon, as Anahita and Zarathustra,
as Asiya, Aaron, Maryam, and Moses,
as Mary and Jesus, Khadijah and Muhammad,
and in many other names and forms, known and unknown to the world.
We adore Thy past. Thy presence deeply enlightens our being.
We look for Thy blessings in the future.
O Messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God,
Thou whose heart constantly reacheth upward,
Thou comest on earth with a message, as a dove from above when Dharma decays,
and speakest the word put into Thy mouth as the light filleth the crescent moon.

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Nayaz — Prayer of Gratitude

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

PRAYER CLOAK-RELEASING GESTURE

Urs taught this movement as a ritual threshold for entering sacred space:

"If you want, you can return to this one movement of the prayer where we lift our hands above the shoulders — which is like letting go of a cloak that is hanging over our shoulders. And letting go for a moment, for these two days, of everything that is hindering us to be in the space that we need. Just let go."

This gesture serves as a symbolic releasing of all that would impede spiritual presence and openness.

NAYAZ (CLOSING THE ELEMENTAL PRACTICE)

The prayer used to close the elemental breath practice:

Beloved Sovereign, Almighty God,
through the rays of the sun,
through the waves of the air,
through the all-pervading life in space,
purify and revivify me,
and we pray, heal our bodies, hearts, and souls.
Aum.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Beloved Sovereign, Almighty God,

through the rays of the sun, through the waves of the air,

through the all-pervading life in space,

purify and revivify me.

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Fifth Aspect of Prayer - Union and Communion

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The fifth and final aspect of Murshid's five aspects of prayer — the completion of the arc begun in C11 with gratitude:

"The fifth element of prayer is beyond thanksgiving, beyond repentance and healing, beyond supplication, and beyond invocation."

"There is the same aspect in prayer. We spent time with the aspect of invocation — the calling of the beloved. What is the next step? It's finding him, it's finding her. It's being in communion with the one."

COMPLETE REVIEW - FIVE ASPECTS OF PRAYER AS LIVED LIFE

The five aspects of prayer not as ritual moments but as qualities of lived experience encountered throughout each day:

1. GRATITUDE

A sudden outburst of thankfulness to the one; or a daily review in the evening. Not a fixed form, but a quality of cherishing what is given, usually hidden from attention.

2. REPENTANCE / HEALING

Moments of introspection: looking at deeds, how we managed situations, how it might have affected others. By putting it before the all-compassionate, being healed and strengthened to be more wakeful in the next situation.

3. SUPPLICATION / HAIYA

In moments of stillness, contact with the pure vision of one's path. The deep wish that one might get all the support needed. Desires closer and closer to one's true path within the one.

4. INVOCATION

In moments of intimacy, a heavy or uplifted heart: longing, love, sincere wishing for the presence of the one. Like the lover singing a song with no wish but to be with the ultimate.

5. UNION / COMMUNION

Moments of complete stillness. No name, no word. No me and thee. Just the one. No separation between the lover and the beloved. Love, lover, and beloved — just one.

"You're invited to be with these five aspects of prayer. Sometimes you might just be aware that you've suddenly, most naturally, been in the mode of one of these aspects — not even planned. It was a natural rising of this aspect. As this thankfulness or this longing — in the end it's nothing that's produced. It's something that's in you that comes forth."

"Live in the space of this thankfulness, the space of repentance and healing, the clarification of your desire, your path, the pursuit of the beloved, and the presence of the ineffable."

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Salat — Prayer of Benediction

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE TWO FORMS

Half Prostration (previously taught):

- Putting the hands before us and bowing down
- Without going down towards the ground
- Hands placed like on a stool in front of you

Full Prostration (new teaching):

- Go down to the full prostration on the ground
- Hands in front of you
- Head touching the ground

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF FULL PROSTRATION

"One of the wonderful things about this is that in this position, the heart is higher than the brain. And it is, as far as I know, the early way our body is formed in the early stages in the womb of the mother."

This physical positioning creates a specific energetic state where:

- The heart takes precedence over the mind
- We return to our most primal formation
- The body remembers its original sacred geometry

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Part II · Chapter 2

CHIVALRIC RULES & IRON RULES

The Ethical Foundation of the Path

Urs wove the Chivalric Rules into his elemental teachings, showing how ethical refinement connects to the practice of concentration and the purification of the elements.

5 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Do Not Reproach Others Rule

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE RULE

"My conscientious self, do not reproach others, making them firm in their faults."

TEACHING CONTEXT

Urs offered this guidance on receiving the rules:

"The rules are an invitation. They are not set because these rules change with the ears and the tongues that hear them and speak them. They change with your biography, with where you're at."

"So it's an invitation to work with them. It's not a call to uphold each and every of these rules. And not at all is there any inclination to judge any of us in the way that we connect with the rules. They are like lenses that help us to explore ourselves, our connection with the world, and be aware of our moral compass."

UNDERSTANDING "MAKING THEM FIRM IN THEIR FAULTS"

"The part 'making them firm in their faults' — by addressing it harshly, you ask them in a way to put their concentration on this very specific aspect of their being. And as we will address today: when we focus on a certain part in us, it is strengthened. It will grow bigger."

"Maybe you've been in situations where your friend entered the mode of defending this very aspect of their being. So it strengthened it."

POSITIVE ORIENTATION

"An aspect of this rule invites us to take very good care of the feeling of others, and if ever possible, meet them in a loving, supportive way — in which you can still address your discomfort. But your aim is not to lash out at your friend, but to make way for some healing that needs be."

"God is love, and this love is also expressed through our own hearts."

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Rule - Do Not Spare Yourself in the Work You Must Accomplish

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE RULE

"My conscientious self, do not spare yourself in the work that you must accomplish."

UNDERSTANDING BALANCE

“One of the core teachings of Murshid is balance. That is so important in his teaching that he could have never meant that we should grind ourselves in work and exhaust ourselves. He always points out that we should be as balanced as possible with action and repose, with work and rest.”

“Work could not happen for long if we didn't have enough rest. So let's keep this in mind: the rule is not asking us only to be on the active side of our life.”

WHAT IS THE WORK WE MUST ACCOMPLISH?

“The second part says: 'in the work that you must accomplish.' Now, what is this work? Is it the work others ask us to? There's always someone around us who needs something from us. There's an immeasurable load of work that we could be doing for people that ask us.”

“But what is the work we actually came here for? What is the work that can only be done by us — by you? No one else?”

“The universe would not be complete without you as an expression of the one — a unique expression of the one.”

“So it's not so much the question of doing much work, but what work? Where do we give our time to? What do we give our attention to? Do we make enough space that this true self can be expressed in this world? Not in the sense of a show, or that everything must be seen by other human beings — but that this longing of the soul may be expressed in the way that it is meant to be.”

PLEDGE PRACTICE

“I'm reading the words of the rule again. And if you feel in resonance with this rule, you can join in, or decide to deepen it further. You can close your eyes — as it is not important to see who is speaking the rule and who is not. Rules are always an invitation.”

"My conscientious self, do not spare yourself in the work that you must accomplish."

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Rule: Render Your Services Faithfully

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The Rule:

“My conscientious self, render your services faithfully to all who require them.”

READING THE RULE CAREFULLY

★ Urs drew attention to the precise wording — 'all who require them' is not 'everyone who asks':

"It's helpful to look at this rule closely and carefully. It doesn't say: render your services to each and every one that asks. But it is a rule that invites us to see where we lend our services when there is a true need — when there is a need only you can fulfill with your being."

PIR ZIA — THE BODHISATTVA OF SERVICE

★ Pir Zia's framing of this rule — Bodhisattva service as the model:

"Pir Zia describes it as like the service of the Bodhisattva that supports others to move obstacles out of their way so they have a smooth path on their way to enlightenment."

"Where can you be of service for people around you in supporting them to be uplifted, to be safe on their journey to the one? What are these needs for the greater good where you can render your help faithfully?"

ON FAITHFUL SERVICE

"What could it mean to render it faithfully? Full of trust and in contact with your true being."

"Maybe on a simple level, this rule asks us: if we are only preoccupied with our own sorrows and work that lies ahead, or if there is time and space we can make to be of service for others who truly need it."

PLEDGE

★ Opt-in pledge — same format as prior rules:

"If you are planning to take up this rule and take a pledge, we can say it together — or you can decide to contemplate it a bit further, which is wonderful. You can close your eyes."

"My conscientious self, render your services faithfully to all who require them."

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Rule: Seek Not Profit by Putting Someone in Straits

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE RULE

"My conscientious self, seek not profit by putting someone in straits."

TWO DIMENSIONS

"There is a basic need for all of us to provide ourselves with everything that supports our wellbeing, from food to our home, warmth, shelter. So there's an invitation to contemplate this aspect of the rule for seeking profit."

"But it doesn't end there. It highlights the seeking profit by putting someone in straits. It doesn't say anything about the profit itself — but the way by which we seek profit. So others are carrying the costs for our own profit."

PIR VILAYAT — THE FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN

"Pir Vilayat reminds us of a wonderful approach which we meet daily: when we're providing food for ourselves and others. While in some cases you can go to a market and meet the people who produced the food, put their work and time and care into growing vegetables — we nowadays mostly find food on shelves. And you need to really look closely to find out where this produce comes from. What were the circumstances in which it was grown?"

"Who was involved? How is their wellbeing? Can they make sure they have their basic needs covered as well? Or when animals are involved, how were they kept? Were they treated well?"

"So many things have happened before something is ready to be bought by us. And so many beings have given time and energy to make it possible. Was it in a way that is supportive for all — for each and every one's wellbeing? Or have other beings been put into straits?"

PLEDGE

"My conscientious self, seek not profit by putting someone in straits."

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Final Iron Rule - Harm No One for Your Own Benefit

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The Rule:

"My conscientious self, harm no one for your own benefit."

This is the 10th and final Iron Rule, completing the first section of chivalric codes.

TEACHING

Both this rule and Rule 9 (C18) ask us not to gain or benefit by harming others. For most this is common sense, but the highlight is more in the aspects where we are not aware of how our seeking for benefit or profit harms other beings.

TWO STAGES OF THE NAFS

Nafs al-Ammara (النفس الأمّارة) - The Commanding Nafs:

- The nafs that separates oneself from every other being
- Holds up a very strong self-identity where the strength lies in supporting oneself alone

- Seeks benefit at the expense of others
- This benefit cannot last long when it comes at others' expense

Nafs al-Lawwama (النفس اللوّامة) - The Self-Reproaching Nafs:

- Connected with each and everyone
- Seeks reasonable profit to support oneself AND all those one is responsible for
- Seeks benefit that is beneficial for all that we can reach
- Profit that benefits our generation and all generations to come
- Benefits people, plants, animals, the whole ecosystem, the planet

THE RULE'S WISDOM

The rule doesn't forbid seeking benefit or profit - but it asks: **what sort of benefit, and whom does it benefit?**

With this 10th rule, all the Iron Rules are now complete. Students are invited to revisit them, perhaps choosing one to be with for a few days to deepen understanding and experience.

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Part II · Chapter 3

BREATH PRACTICES

The Bridge Between Worlds

Urs taught the Five Elemental Purification Breaths — Earth, Water, Fire, Air, and Ether — each with specific directions, colors, and qualities. His approach to breath is deeply embodied and experiential.

6 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Five Element Breathing Practice - Foundation

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

This is the core elemental breathing practice that serves as the foundation for all element work. This basic form will be returned to repeatedly with deepening layers added.

PREPARATION

- Close the eyes
- Find a comfortable position that allows the breath to flow freely
- Be aware of the connection of your feet — or the tailbone — to the ground

THE FIVE ELEMENTS AND THEIR BREATH

Each element has a specific breath mode. The practice moves through all five in sequence:

Earth

Breath: Inhale through nose, exhale through nose

Quality: Steadiness, Patience

Instructions: *"Breathe in through the nose and breathe out through the nose. Just be aware of your breath for a few moments. Now be in the presence of the element Earth — whatever the initial thought or feeling, whatever Earth symbolizes for you, just be in this presence for a few more breaths."*

Water

Breath: Inhale through nose, exhale through mouth

Quality: Flow, Adaptability

Instructions: *"Breathe in through the nose and breathe out through the mouth. And be in the presence of the element water, in whatever form it might be present."*

Fire

Breath: Inhale through mouth, exhale through nose

Quality: Transformation, Energy

Instructions: *"Breathe in through the mouth and out through the nose. Be in the presence of the fire element."*

Air

Breath: Inhale through mouth, exhale through mouth

Quality: Freedom, Movement

Instructions: *"Breathe in through the mouth and out through the mouth."*

Ether

Breath: Subtle (both mouth and nose)

Quality: Vastness, Spaciousness

Instructions: *"The breath is very subtle — through mouth and nose, very subtle, in and out. Just be aware of all the elements in the space beyond."*

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Earth Element Extended Practice - Three Layers

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Urs returned to the Earth element from C11 and introduced three additional layers of practice beyond the basic elemental breath. These layers are cumulative — each builds on the last.

LAYER 1 — PURIFICATION / GROUNDING BREATH

New layer: Earth as a purification element — letting go through the out-breath, drawing in magnetism on the in-breath:

1. Close the eyes. Bring awareness to the feet, tailbone, and knees — everything touching the earth.
2. Breathe in through the nose, out through the nose (Earth mode).
3. **On the out-breath:** let go of bodily tensions. Then let go of impressions, feelings, memories not needed right now.

"You can feel how they're falling off you through your feet, through this touch of the earth. And with a feeling of kindness towards the things you let go, you hand them over trustfully to earth with a feeling of thankfulness."

Let earth take good care and transform what you let go.

4. **On the in-breath:** imagine drawing in through deep roots — earth magnetism, all the gifts of the element earth — strengthening and holding you.

"Let go on your out-breath and be filled with earth qualities on your in-breath."

LAYER 2 — DIRECTION: THE HORIZONTAL

Each element is connected to a specific direction of movement. Earth's direction is horizontal:

"Earth is connected to the horizontal line. When breathing out, you can imagine how your breath is moving in every direction on the horizon — along the plains, over the mountains."

This directional awareness opens the practice beyond the individual body into the vast flat expanse of the Earth plane — the planetary horizon in all directions simultaneously.

LAYER 3 — COLOR: YELLOW / OCHER

Each element is attributed a color. Earth's color is yellow or ocher:

"Earth is the color yellow or ocher. It's the color of the earth you might see when it's freshly dug up. It's this rich color of the soil."

Just be a moment with this yellow, this ocher. Be with its quality, its atmosphere.

CLOSING COUNSEL ON THE LAYERS

"The work with the elements has so many layers. Stay with the elements that you're drawn to. Keep it a bit playful, explore, and be with this element like you would be with a friend you haven't met for a long time."

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Water Elemental Breath Practice - Complete Instructions

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

BASIC FORM

- **Breathe in through the nose, out through the mouth**
- *"Already in the setting of the breath, you see there is a downward stream. So the direction of water is downward."*

THE WATERFALL OF WATER AND LIGHT

On the in-breath: Let yourself be lifted way above your head, up into the clouds and even beyond.

On the out-breath: Imagine a stream of water with its true origin in the one — becoming water, a waterfall — a waterfall of water and light washing down on you, cleaning you, refreshing you.

"Not only wash the outside of your body, but this waterfall goes through you — through your veins, through every part of your body. Feel how your heart is washed and refreshed, your abdomen, your arms and legs. And everything is washed away that is not needed anymore."

Go way up on the in-breath. Let yourself be emerged in this waterfall of water and light that runs through you and all around you.

WORKING WITH BLOCKAGES

"Sometimes you can feel how the water is stuck in a certain place in your body. With a subtle breath, just steer this water towards this part. And maybe you experience a subtle opening. Maybe this part allows itself to be washed by this water."

COLOR LAYER: GREEN

"The color of water is green — green as you see it in the different shades in the ocean and the lakes. You can add this layer to your concentration: to be merged not only in this waterfall, but also in this color that runs through you."

AS COMMUNION

"The elemental breath is like a communion — the outer and the inner, of the world around us and within us, the aspects of our personality, our individuality, and the universal — all that belongs to the one."

DAY PRACTICE

"When you take your next shower or ablution, be aware of the transformative power of water — how it is used in so many traditions to help us to transform from one state into another."

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Three Element Breath Sequence - Complete Practice

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

★ First time all three elements practiced in sequence in a single opening. Represents the cumulative practice arc of C11–C15. Each element's full layer set now included.

EARTH BREATH

In through nose · Out through nose · Direction: Horizontal · Color: Yellow/Ocher

"You might have already been greeted by the earth today. Be aware again of this communion — that which seems to be separate, your body from your surrounding, is one. It shares the same origin. And you share in qualities."

"When you breathe out, be aware of the earth breath rolling in every direction through all the horizons, mapping the land. Be present with the color yellow, the ocher."

"Each element has a healing aspect, a cleansing that is offered. Let go of everything that is not needed anymore — everything for which it is time to be let go. Hand it over to earth, where it will be transformed into new soil, nutritious ground for new life to emerge."

"Let go with your out-breath. And take in new magnetism of the earth. Let the earth qualities in you be refreshed. And we can remember the eshk, the longing, the love expressed through this gentle pull by the earth that holds us."

WATER BREATH

In through nose · Out through mouth · Direction: Downward · Color: Green

"Let yourself be lifted up with your in-breath, and then connect to this downstream of the water element from far above. This waterfall full of light coming from the source, washing all over you, through you, through your veins, your limbs, your heart, the abdomen."

"Be aware of the water in you — how it is greeting the water that is flowing through you. How it is cleansed by it, renewed. And when you sense a blockage, let this water gently wash through it, and maybe you can feel how a gentle flow is emerging again."

At-onement: *"Feel this atonement, this at-onement — being one with the element water that surrounds you. The streams beneath you, the clouds in the sky, the vapor we breathe. Be aware of this constant flow and exchange."*

"Be aware of the color green — this shimmering green that is ever changing when you look out into the water. It's reflecting light. Sometimes you can see through."

FIRE BREATH

In through mouth · Out through nose · Direction: Ascending · Color: Red (belly) → Pure Light (above)

★ Fire element introduced for the first time in the breath sequence:

"While water is descending, the fire element is ascending. It's going up. Imagine fire burning in your belly with that red color. And with your in-breath, you supply it with the oxygen necessary."

"Everything that needs transformation through fire can be put in there. Fire consumes and transforms small things very quickly — lights them up, transforms them into heat and light. And there are things that take longer to be consumed by the fire, but this fire is ever burning."

"It rises up. When you follow this fire in your body rising up, you see it's getting more and more light. Warm light the further it gets upwards — transformed into pure light. And on your out-breath, you can be with this pure light shining from your inside out in every direction into your subtle body, your subtle body of light."

"Maybe you can feel how your body is heating up — feel the warmth produced in every cell. You can feel that fire is a part of your innate nature."

Slowly return to natural breath. Let go of this concentration.

ELEMENTAL PRACTICE SUMMARY — C11 THROUGH C15

EARTH · In/Out: Nose→Nose · Direction: Horizontal · Color: Yellow/Ocher · Quality: Patience, steadfastness, eshk as gentle holding · Healing: Release into soil; draw in magnetism

WATER · In/Out: Nose→Mouth · Direction: Downward · Color: Green · Quality: Flow, adaptability, cleansing, at-onement · Healing: Waterfall of light washing through; clearing blockages in Lataif

FIRE · In/Out: Mouth→Nose · Direction: Ascending · Color: Red (belly) → Pure Light (rising) · Quality: Transformation, will, eshk as consuming love · Healing: Burns what needs transforming; purifies to pure light

Two more elements — Air and Ether — to be introduced in the December weekend (C17–C20).

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Complete Four-Element Breath Practice with Living Beings

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The full elemental sequence as practiced in Concentration 1 Part 2, with each element now enriched with awareness of living beings:

EARTH

Method: In/Out: Nose→Nose | Direction: Horizontal | Color: Yellow/Ocher

"While you're breathing out, be aware of your earthly element in your body. Be with this feeling of letting go of everything you don't need anymore — handing it over to earth. You can breathe it out through the soles of your feet. And be revivified on your in-breath, taking in this earthly magnetism that is given as a gift."

Living Beings of Earth: *"Be aware of all the living beings that live in or very close to the earth: worms and insects, mammals that build their living spaces in the earth, seek that closeness to this element, or all the plants united through their web of roots, the fungi with their unseen web of communication — all hidden in the earth. Being aware of all these beings is being aware of the friendship we can hold in this reality that we share."*

WATER

Method: In/Out: Nose→Mouth | Direction: Downward | Color: Green

"On your in-breath you can feel how you're lifted up, straightened, where your spine is lengthened — you follow it way up to the heavens. And on your out-breath through the mouth, imagine this stream of water, this waterfall immersed in light, running through every part of your body, renewing and washing every corner."

Living Beings of Water: *"Reconnect with the waters around you. Be aware of all the beings living in the waters: fish and mammals, from the very large to the smallest insects that make the waters their home, or on the waters like the ducks. They hold a deep wisdom of this element by living in and on it so closely. There is much to share."*

FIRE

Method: In/Out: Mouth→Nose | Direction: Ascending | Color: Red→Pure Light

"Breathing in, we can imagine drawing this air onto a fire in our belly — heating it up, flames rising. And from fire we see the light. On your out-breath you can imagine how you breathe out from your heart center pure light in every direction."

Living Being of Fire: *"Fire spirits living in the heat. A salamander was believed to be able to live in the highest heat and quench a fire. Seen and unseen beings living in the elements."*

AIR (NEW)

Method: In/Out: Mouth→Mouth | Direction: All Directions / Zigzag | Color: Blue

"It is the finest of the elements before ether. And it's very much connected to our breath. We breathe in through the mouth and we breathe out through the mouth. Maybe you can hear the sound of the air moving between your lips — it sounds like the wind."

"Air is moving in every possible direction. It's more of a zigzag — the wind that changes. And it's the element that we on the one hand hardly see or touch, and on the other hand, it is so close to us like the water is close to a fish. We are living in the air. We are in a constant exchange through our in-breath and out-breath."

Living Beings of Air: *"There are those beings even more immersed in this element: birds, insects with wings, bats — moving through this element in their very own dance. From nervous, joyful zigzag to the majestic circles high above. There is so much wisdom in their lives of this element air."*

DAILY PRACTICE GUIDANCE

"It is most advisable to choose the elemental breath as the one daily practice — if you are overwhelmed by all the possible practices you could be doing, or life just doesn't give you enough space."

"It is advised to do this practice in the morning, and if you can, to do it outside in the fresh air. The contact with the elements is more immediate outside. Maybe you can step outside on a veranda, garden, or even an open window."

"In the daily practice, it is just five breaths — five breaths for each element. Of course you can always prolong it, but as a daily practice, it's a revisiting of your state how it woke up, and the reality with all its dimensions."

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Complete Five-Element Breath Practice with Ether

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The first time the full five-element sequence is practiced in one sitting — the complete elemental breath as it will be done as a daily practice. Earth through Ether:

EARTH · NOSE→NOSE · HORIZONTAL · YELLOW/OCHER

"We let go of everything heavy that burdens us. We hand it over to earth. Let it be transformed, and we breathe in new magnetism. Earth lends you patience, endurance. There's a strength not easily shaken."

WATER · NOSE→MOUTH · DOWNWARD · GREEN

"Breathing out, be washed by this water, cleansed. This waterfall of pure refreshing water full of light, moving through every part in your body and your whole being, washing everything away that needs purification. Whatever the obstacle may be — like water, you will find a way through it."

FIRE · MOUTH→NOSE · ASCENDING · RED

"You can feel the warmth or even the heat rising. The flame going higher — become pure light. The fire that has the Ishq that burns everything except the beloved. The fire that lights us up to intensify our quest for the ideal."

AIR · MOUTH→MOUTH · ALL DIRECTIONS · BLUE

"The air moving in every direction — the most subtle of the elements. Sometimes strong and powerful, but often very subtle. This constant stream of the breath is a communion with the element air. The air blowing through you, cleansing you."

ETHER · SUBTLE (MOUTH AND NOSE BOTH) · NO DIRECTION · NO COLOR

"The quintessence of all the elements. Akash. Asman. A very fine breath through the mouth and the nose, on both the in and the out breath."

"It has no color. It has no direction, and it has no form. And as the quintessence of all the elements, it has all the colors, all the forms, and all the directions when expressed in the elements. The elements express what is hidden in ether. All emerges from it and all dissolves back into it. Ether is intimately present and yet ineffable."

Three Planes of Ether

"There is an ether of the body, ether of the mind, and ether of the spirit. In ether of the body, physical forms transpire. In ether of the mind, thoughts transpire. In ether of the spirit, souls transpire. It's like skies within skies within skies."

"After five breaths with every element, you enter the presence of ether. Just present with the dissolving of each and every element, present in silence. Aware of the union of all the elements in total balance. And when you do this practice in the morning, you can stay in ether as long as you wish and taste this essence of the elements."

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Part II · Chapter 4

CONCENTRATION, VISUALIZATION & MEDITATION

Training the Sovereign Attention

Urs's approach to concentration emphasizes gentle attention over forceful will — the parent at a sick child's bedside rather than the warrior's focused determination. His practices include dot-on-wall gazing, color immersion, and elemental concentration.

20 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Bridge from Concentration to Contemplation

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Urs introduced a key arc for these two weekends — the transition from outer concentration to inner contemplation. This marks a significant shift from Section I.

THE PROGRESSION

"In these two weekends, we already approach a bridge from concentration to contemplation."

"You might have already realized that there is no pure form of concentration that doesn't already lap into a meditative state — or that has very much in common with contemplation."

The progression described:

- **Section I:** Concentration on outer objects (dot, colors, senses)
- **Now:** Concentration on beings in imagination — beings one knows
- **Next:** Moving toward abstract qualities of those beings
- **There:** Already in the midst of contemplation

TWO MODES OF CONCENTRATION

"Concentration can come, for example, in a very strong focus — in a willful focus. But it can also come as a very gentle attention."

"A gentle attention which we might see in a parent sitting by the bed of a sick child, just being there, totally being there. Not being with his or her own sorrows, but being there fully attentive to this being."

"Sometimes it's in this mode that we concentrate on a certain aspect in our life, on a certain being, on the resonance, a quality — attentive to the one being."

DEPTH OVER MULTIPLICITY

"I would like to remind you of the story of the pupil who made a whole wall crumble just by mastering the Alif. And in this story, we already see that in a single practice, there can be the whole universe."

This teaching anchors the counsel: rather than being distracted by the multiplicity of practices, go deeply into one — as the pupil went deeply into the Alif.

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Visualizing an Inspiring Being Practice

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

This practice marks the transition from concentrating on objects toward concentrating on beings — thereby crossing the threshold from concentration into contemplation.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Close the eyes.
2. Imagine a person who is inspiring to you — someone you know personally, someone you have met, or someone whose qualities you know clearly from afar.

"It could also be a person you just know of, and you have a clear picture of that person and this person's uplifting atmosphere. It might be a person that you adore for what they stand for, what they did in their life. But eventually it's a person that has truly become herself — and reminds you of becoming yourself."

3. Imagine this person sitting with you, in front of you.
4. Be aware of the atmosphere, the resonance evoked through this being.
5. If your mind wanders, just go back to this being. Keep it present.

"Use your imagination to have this being in your presence as palpable as possible, with these qualities that you admire."

6. Feel the resonance in you. This focus can have an imprint on your thoughts, your feelings, the atmosphere you're in.

THE TEACHING BEHIND THE PRACTICE

"What we experience in the outer resonates in our minds. And that which our minds hold is reflected by our souls."

"The mind is the filter for the light of our soul — for what we show in the world of our true being, or what's not shown yet, maybe because the filter of the mind has another focus."

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Feeling the Pulse - Water Element Inner Awareness

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Close the eyes**
2. **Be aware of the water element within you** — the element most of your body consists of
3. **Focus on the heart** — It is most palpable in the heart, where the bloodstream is constantly pumped through every vessel in each part of the body

4. **Try to feel the pulse, the throbbing**
5. **If it's not easy to feel, touch certain parts of the body:** below the chest, the wrist, gently on the neck

"Just be aware for a moment of this constant movement within. Be aware of this watery existence you are."

TEACHING CONTEXT

"On the inside of our bodies, it [water] is the predominant element. It's always hard to imagine because with our eyes open, we see a fixed set of body. But when we look inside us, we realize there is so much fluidity, so much water — always in constant movement, a movement that is necessary for us to be alive."

MOVEMENT AS LIFE

"One aspect of water is its movement. If it doesn't move in our bodies, it has dire consequences. When water doesn't move on the street, it builds a puddle. When it stays there for a while, it gets murky and you can't see through it anymore."

"The moment it starts flowing again, it shows its revivifying and cleansing ability — the refreshing."

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River Visualization Practice

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Sit in the atmosphere of Astaghfirullah**
2. **Imagine a river** — a river you are sitting beside
3. **Imagine its color**
4. **See the ground beneath it** if visible
5. **See animals living in it**
6. **See the lush vegetation and plants growing by its side**
7. **Maybe you can hear it** — this constant murmur
8. **See the reflected light**
9. **Stay with this picture** — Always return to the flow of this river

RETURNING TO THE BODY

After the visualization:

- *"Now you can let go of this inner vision"*

- *“Be aware of your body. What was the imprint of it?”*
- *“How does your body feel? How is your breath? What is moving inside you?”*
- *“You can feel your feet, come back and open your eyes again”*

CONTEXT

This visualization followed the Astaghfirullah zikr practice, connecting the flow of water to the flow of divine forgiveness and the cleansing quality of repentance.

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Color Concentration Practice - Brown to Green

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

This practice develops concentration through a slow, intentional color shift — from brown (earth, density) to green (water, life, growth). It bridges the two elements worked with this weekend.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Close the eyes.
2. Imagine the color brown, just as it appears to you. Be surrounded by this color. Immersed. Just try to hold this presence of this color brown.
3. Now slowly shift from brown to green — imagine how from brown there emerges the color green, step by step: a slow transformation.
4. *“When you've arrived with the color green, sit with this color. Be totally immersed in it. Always return to green again.”*
5. Notice if there is a shift in experience between brown and green. Just stay in green for a moment.
6. Slowly let the color fade away. Return to the breath. Feel the feet on the ground. Feel the body again. Open the eyes.

Teaching Context:

This practice reinforces the deeper pattern of the weekend: from Earth's steadiness and density into Water's life, flow, and greenness. The color shift is also a concentration technique — sustaining and guiding a subtle, willed transformation of the inner visual field.

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Tailbone Concentration Practice

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A full body-awareness concentration practice, using the tailbone as the anchor point.

OPENING QUESTIONS — ENTERING THE PRACTICE

Close the eyes. Return to the tailbone.

What happens when you're asked to be with your tailbone? What does it mean to shift your awareness to a certain place in your body? How does it feel?

"Is it a sensation of a mind sitting in your head, watching down to the tailbone? Or is it slowly shifting the whole awareness to that tailbone? How does the breath flow in and out?"

DEEPENING INQUIRY

What comes to your awareness? How does it affect your posture?

Do you feel a warmth? Or is it cool? Is it still? Or can you feel a movement in the tailbone?

Concentrate on the tailbone and be aware of what is happening in it and around it.

"The legs, the abdomen, the upper body, the breath, the mind."

BREATH INTO THE TAILBONE

Always return to the tailbone.

"It is possible to concentrate on a part in your body and still be aware of the surroundings."

Breathe in to the tailbone and breathe out through it.

The legs, the abdomen, the upper body, the breath, the mind.

CLOSING — RESONANCE CHECK

Notice: Do you still feel a shift? Does it still change? Has it come to rest? Is it constant?

Now, slowly return to natural breath. Let go of the concentration.

For a moment, feel what resonance is left — if any.

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Three-Stage Being Visualization

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

This is the culminating concentration practice of the November weekend — a direct enactment of the bridge from concentration (outer objects) toward contemplation (inner and non-physical beings).

STAGE 1 — A PERSON YOU KNOW

Close the eyes. Take a few deep breaths. Feel the body.

Breathe in through the nose, out through the mouth.

Think of someone you know — a friend, a relative. Think of that person's name.

Let this person with that name appear before you. Use your creative imagination to really see this person in front of you, as clear as possible. Recollect your memory of their appearance.

Try to hold this image. Be aware of your resonance. How does it change your mood? What do you feel?

Let go of this image. Take a few breaths.

STAGE 2 — A PERSON YOU KNOW OF (BUT NOT PERSONALLY)

Think of a person you don't personally know, but have heard of — still living or from the past. An inspiring person, a teacher, a saint.

Be with their name. By their name, be with their appearance in front of you. You might not have a clear image — see what image is created before you.

Be in the presence of this being. Be aware of the atmosphere, of your breath, of your posture, your resonance.

STAGE 3 — A NON-PHYSICAL BEING

Imagine a being that has not existed on the physical plane — an angel, a jinn, a Bodhisattva in its pre-earthly stage.

Be with this image. Be in the presence of this being.

Be aware of the atmosphere of your breath, your posture, your resonance.

Finally, let this image also fade away. Return to your natural breath. Your feet. Slowly feel your body again. Open your eyes.

THE ARC OF THE PRACTICE

The three stages map onto an ascending interior arc:

- **Stage 1** — Personal memory; the being is known through direct experience; resonance is immediate and personal
- **Stage 2** — Transmitted image; the being is known through report; the imagination works with what has been received from others
- **Stage 3** — Pure imagination; no physical counterpart; the subtle senses reach beyond form entirely

"This is the threshold where concentration becomes contemplation."

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Burning Torch Concentration Practice

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

★ Fire as concentration object. The torch as purposeful fire: not burning for its own sake but to shed light.

After the fire teachings, Urs guided a concentration practice using the burning torch as object — the form of fire that is most deliberately directed toward a single purpose: illumination.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Close the eyes.
2. Imagine a burning torch in front of you. The torch uses fire for a specific purpose: to shed light.
3. Imagine this fire of the torch as vivid as possible. See its colors. Its movements. Its ever-changing character. How the flames seem to dance. The emerging light.
4. When you wander off, gently come back to this image of the burning torch.
5. Keep your gaze a little bit longer on this torch.
6. Slowly let this image go. Just be aware of your pure state, your breath, your body. Sit with it for a moment.

TEACHING

"The torch uses the fire for a specific purpose: that is to shed light."

The torch is fire that has been given intention — it does not burn freely and wildly but is held, directed, purposeful. This practice is both a concentration exercise and a teaching image: the fire of the soul, when it has been contained by will and given a direction, becomes a torch. It illuminates rather than consumes.

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Color Concentration - Green to Orange

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

As the final concentration of the November weekend, this practice extends the brown→green transformation of earlier sessions and introduces orange for the first time.

Practice Instructions:

1. Enter the color green. Let yourself be immersed in it.
2. Now slowly let this green turn into orange — a slow fade from one color to the other.

3. Until fully arrived with orange: be with this color for a moment.
4. Let it go. Return to the body and feet.

Teaching Note:

Orange has not yet been formally assigned to an element in the curriculum as taught. It may anticipate the Air or Ether element teachings in December, or serve as a bridging color between fire's red and ether's more luminous palette.

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Energy Ball Practice - Opening Session

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Practice Instructions

1. Slowly massage the left arm with the right hand — from the shoulder all the way down to the hands. Several times. Don't forget the hands. Not hard — just activating through touch.
2. Change arms: massage the right arm with the left, all the way down from the shoulder to the hands. Gently stroke it down.
3. Gently breathe on your palms.
4. Rest the hands on the knees. On the in-breath, slowly lift both arms up in front of you. On the out-breath, let them sink back to the knees.
5. Let them rest on the knees for a moment.
6. Raise the hands again — palms now facing each other. Play with the distance between them.

Energy Ball Awareness

"There is a moment where there is this feeling of holding a ball between them. You can gently squeeze it and give way again — allow it. Stay with the gentle breath. With your out-breath, you can even make this ball a bit larger. Just be aware of this sensation."

7. Place the left hand on the right chest and the right hand on the left chest. While breathing in, giving it a bit of space. When breathing out, return to the chest.
8. Lower the hands. Rest them on the knees. Sit with it for a short moment.

Teaching Point

This exercise demonstrates that a shifted focus of awareness reveals phenomena already present in the body — subtle fields, warmth, the sensation of the etheric body between the palms. The practice is both grounding and a direct entry into energy perception.

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Fana-fi-Sheikh - Three Stages Practice

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Fana-fi-Sheikh is the practice where we are invited to be in the presence of Murshid, and through his presence, in the presence of all the murshids that have become him or her — the light that shines through this lineage and through this being.

STAGE 1 — THE IMAGE

- Build the inner image of Murshid, your chosen guide — as if you would sit before him or her.
- Create a clear picture. Imagine being seen. You are not looking at an object — you are looking at a living subject looking back at you.
- *"It's a most intimate meeting. Your glance meets Murshid's glance. There's nothing to hide. You're just who you are, the way you're meant to be, and you're seen as this."*
- Be aware: you are in the presence not just of one murshid, but of the whole Silsila reaching back in time — the light of all those murshids before.
- *"You're in the presence of this very specific fragrance. Sometimes you can almost smell it. It's an atmosphere you're encompassed in."*
- There is an intimate connection through the breath: through your breathing out, Murshid breathes it in. Through your breathing in, he or she breathes it out.
- *"Try to keep the soft concentration, the awareness, the sympathy, as Murshid says. Be aware of this atmosphere."*

STAGE 2 — THE ATMOSPHERE

- Let go of the image.
- Let this atmosphere, this taste, this palpable presence of this being — let it reside in your heart. Be immersed in this light.
- *"You're not focusing on an image anymore. You are holding the atmosphere — pure presence. And it's no longer opposite you. Now it's in your heart, and it's around you."*
- Hold it alive. Hold it present. Settle in it. Be at rest.

STAGE 3 — MERGING

"Eventually the third stage of Fana-fi-Sheikh is when this being becomes a part of you. When Murshid's speech is expressed in yours. You hear with Murshid's ears. And when you walk, there is something of Murshid's walk in your way."

"And this is a much different way of transmission than just exchanging information."

Summary:

- Stage 1 — Image: outer concentration on a living subject; glance meets glance; the Silsila as presence and fragrance
- Stage 2 — Atmosphere: image released; pure presence held in the heart; the teacher is no longer opposite but within and around
- Stage 3 — Merging: the teacher's qualities express through one's own speech, hearing, gait; transmission without exchange of content

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Three Contemplation Practices

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

These practices are described as being 'at the crossroad of concentration and contemplation' — each one asking the student to hold an intangible quality as an object of awareness, rather than an image, a sensation, or a being.

PRACTICE 1 — A CHARACTER TRAIT

- Think of a character trait you see in people you know, or in yourself — a habit, a mode of acting in life, a tendency. Perhaps highly focused, slightly distracted. Perhaps the habit of giving everything into a certain hobby.
- Take one character trait and be with it. Explore it. Be in its resonance.
- *"How does it feel? What is its atmosphere, its taste? By focusing on it, by being with it, we explore something deeper that might otherwise be a neglected thing of daily life. But there is richness in it."*
- We approach an inner understanding of this mode of being.
- Let it go.

PRACTICE 2 — A DRIVING MOTIVATION

- Choose a driving motivation — a motivation for people to get out of bed in the morning, to thrive, to put in their effort. For some it's accumulating worldly richness or power. For some it's to be remembered, to leave an impression. For others it's care, or the longing for beauty.
- Choose one — perhaps you see it in others, perhaps you see parts of it in yourself. Stay with it for a while and explore it.
- *"How does it feel to be motivated by this? What is the quality of it? We're not understanding it by analyzing it — but in this practice, we understand something by*

being in its presence, feeling its quality, and seeing what emerges when we're in contact with it."

- Let it go.

PRACTICE 3 — A SPIRITUAL ASPIRATION

- Think of yourself or people you know. Try to pick a spiritual aspiration — something that's keeping them on their path, something that brought them to the path, something that was a longing, maybe an ideal, maybe a concrete wish.
- Explore it for a while. Be with it.
- Slowly let go of this aspiration. Take a few breaths. Let the images and impressions go.

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Breath Still-Point Concentration

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Find a comfortable position — rooted, breath flowing easily
2. Be aware of the breath for a few moments
3. Let go of the out-breath a little further. Don't press it — relax and let it flow out
4. At the end of the exhalation: hold briefly. Not uncomfortable — just hold and savor this moment
5. Feel how your breath is, by itself, moving from the out-breath to the in-breath. There is no conscious will needed. The air flows in all by itself

TEACHING ON MAGNETISM

Murshid tells a story told in India about the cobras — that the cobras' magnetism is so strong that they don't need to hunt their prey. By magnetism and patience, he writes, the mouse will climb into the cobra's mouth by itself. And there is a quality of this magnetism in this still point after the out-breath.

This still-point — the moment between the exhale completing and the inhale beginning — is where the body's natural magnetism is most palpable. No will is needed; life moves by itself. A teaching on effortless attraction and the power of patient stillness.

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Skull Light Concentration — The Luminous Glance

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A practice on the light the being radiates outward through the eyes — exploring Murshid's teaching that the glance sheds light as much as it receives it.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Sit straight, shoulders relaxed. Connect to the awareness of density in the body — feel the form given through density.
2. Become aware of the space in this part of the body. Imagine it very subtly expanding — letting go of denseness, becoming aware of the permeability of your being. You are not truly separate from everything around you.
3. Expand this feeling to the skull — the head. Be aware of this cask of bone. Let go and expand: be aware of the space where the brain is.
4. *"It can merge with a feeling of the heaven reaching into this part — as if there was no fixed boundary between the heaven and your upper part of your head. Merged with the luminosity of the heaven — this pure blue, luminous sphere."*
5. Through the front of your head above the eyes — as if your head were a crystal — feel the light entering on the in-breath. On the out-breath, from the center of your skull, this light is answered by your light shining back.
6. *"It is like a beam from the midst of your brain being cast through your forehead, above the eyes. You can imagine what is in front of you in your room — and without looking, cast with your out-breath out this light. On your in-breath, feel the resonance."*
7. Just be with it for a few breaths. Cast out the beam through your forehead. On the in-breath — feel the resonance. You might physically feel a shift around the eyes and forehead: expansion, a feeling of pouring something within you outward.

OPENING THE EYES

As the next step — on the out-breath only — open the eyes with this feeling of the beams. Look slightly above the screen or turn a little to the side so the glance reaches something in the room.

"It will not be a focused glance — maybe you don't even see it clearly, but it's a glance that comes from within you and is shining out into the world. On your in-breath, close your eyes again, gather, be aware of the light. On the out-breath, open the eyes again — aware of these beams shedding light on a part of the room."

THE TEACHING BEHIND THE PRACTICE

"This concentration is a way to experience the light that we pour out into the world. Usually we are mostly thinking of the light that is entering us through our eyes. But Murshid says: through a luminous glance, there's also light which is shed by us, through us."

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Star, Crescent Moon, and Heart Visualization

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A layered inner construction practice, building three sacred forms in sequence — the three forms of the Inayatiyya symbol.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Form the Star**: Form before you in your inner vision a star — a five-pointed star. Geometric at first: peak on top, two spikes to the sides, two below.
2. **Make it Vivid**: Now make it vivid. Be aware of its glance, its light, how it's shining. Keep this image. Return to it when drawn away.
3. **Add the Crescent Moon**: Underneath the star: sculpt the image of a crescent moon, starting to grow, reflecting the light of the star. Its cool, silver light. Take joy in sculpting it and watching it take its form, shining in its beauty.
4. **Surround with Heart**: Now draw around the star and the moon the shape of a heart — surrounding both. Keep this image for a moment.
5. **Dissolve in Reverse**: Slowly let go of the heart and the moon — just the star remains.
6. **Complete Release**: Now let go of the star and relax.

Star · Crescent Moon · Heart — the three forms of the Inayatiyya symbol, built and dissolved in sequence.

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Elements Mapped to Stages of Concentration

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The five elements as five stages of the concentration arc, from outer object to union. The deepest philosophical integration of the elemental and concentration work — showing they are the same journey:

EARTH — MEETING THE OBJECT

Awareness of the material reality of what is before you. The solid, the concrete, the given.

WATER — FLOW BETWEEN SELF AND OBJECT

Through presence, a flow begins. The element water is present — this combining flow. One is no longer merely looking; one is in resonance.

FIRE — THE OBJECT BECOMES A SUBJECT

One becomes aware that one is actually meeting a subject, a being. This being is lighted up, and we are aware of the spirit behind it, within it.

AIR — INCREASING SUBTLETY

The sitting with the subject becomes finer and finer. We become aware of the subtle qualities of this being in front of us.

ETHER — UNION

The communion comes to a stage where there is no 'it and I,' subject and object anymore. Just the one presence of the one being held in ether. Beyond subtlety — it cannot even be described as subtle.

"Going through the elements and these stages of concentration, we have arrived at a state where we can't even describe it as subtle because it's beyond subtlety."

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Geographical Orientation Practice

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Practice for spatial rooting before entering the elemental breath. Connects to C5's geographical orientation task:

Before the elemental breath, Urs guided a spatial orientation in the landscape:

Be aware of your location. Try to orient yourself in the landscape you're set in.

- Where is the east — where the sun rises?
- Where is the west?
- North?
- South?
- Where is the nearest mountain?
- Where is a strong expression of the element earth?
- Where does the nearest river flow, or where is the nearest seashore?

"We're starting where we are at, where we are seated. We're aware of our bodies, of our physical being. Our feet are on the ground, tailbone, feeling the earth."

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Fana Sequence - The Complete Arc

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

For the first time, the complete fana arc has been named explicitly as a sequential practice progression across the Suluk program:

THE THREE STAGES

1. Fana-fi-Sheikh (فناء في الشيخ)

- Annihilation in the teacher
- Fully introduced in C16
- Being in the presence of the murshid and the whole Silsila
- The murshid's qualities expressing through you

2. Fana-fi-Rasul (فناء في الرسول)

- Annihilation in the messenger / spirit of guidance
- Focus of this final session
- The great beings through whom the spirit of guidance shone
- The cosmic beings whose presence inspires us across centuries

3. Fana-fi-Allah (فناء في الله)

- Annihilation in God
- The ultimate station
- The arc's final destination
- Complete dissolution into the Divine

THE PROCESS OF INITIATION

"Murshid calls the moment when we are so close to this being that this being becomes an expression of ourselves — an initiation."

Each stage represents a deeper level of spiritual initiation, moving from the personal teacher, through the archetypal guides, to ultimate union with the Source.

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Final Color Concentration - Orange to Gold

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE PRACTICE

The final concentration of the entire 20-session Concentration 1 program — a ceremony of completion moving through four colors in sequence:

1. Orange

Close the eyes. Be with the color orange — in you, around you, immersed.

2. Red

Orange slowly turns to red, brighter and brighter. From orange, slowly move to red. More and more red until it is a bright red. Keep it present. Experience the redness.

3. Purple

Red to magenta, then to purple as blue enters the red. From red, slowly move to purple — from red to magenta, more and more a shade of blue within the red, until you arrive at purple.

4. Gold

Purple turns to bright gold, reflecting the light. Finally, from purple, move to the color gold. See how the purple turns into bright gold, reflecting the light. Be immersed in this color gold, below and above you, around you, within.

Completion

Now slowly let this color dissolve and let it go. Return to your breath, to your body.

THE FULL COLOR ARC

The complete spectrum across Concentration 1:

Black → White → Yellow → Red → Blue → Brown → Green → Orange → Red → Purple → Gold

This traces the full spectrum from the densest (black) to the most luminous (gold) — a chromatic journey of the soul, ending in the golden light that reflects the divine radiance.

"Be immersed in this color gold — below and above you, around you, within."

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Two Modes of Concentration - Hare vs Lion

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE TEACHING FROM THE JATAKA TALE

"When you imagine to be amongst these hundreds and thousands of animals and you're sure the earth is coming to an end — there's no doubt. Everyone is sure. How focused you must be to try to run for your life. This is a very energetic and strong and willful focus and concentration. But it did lack the element of relaxation in it."

"The lion in his mode was not so easily lured in this powerful mood of the multitude. We may remember this one breath that we might take before we act."

"The concentration of the lion is a very different one. It's a concentration of awareness, of relaxation. It is a very broad concentration. It is the coming together of the ability of being aware of that which is in front of you and still be aware of everything that is around you, in you, and above you."

THE TWO MODES CRYSTALLIZED

The Hare's Concentration

- Willful, intense, single-pointed, energetic
- Without relaxation
- Without context
- Without the breath
- Power without wisdom
- Driven by fear and urgency

The Lion's Concentration

- Broad, aware, relaxed
- Holds the immediate situation AND the larger field simultaneously
- Takes the one breath before acting
- Acts from knowing, not from fear
- Power WITH wisdom
- Rooted in awareness rather than reaction

This teaching synthesizes the entire Concentration 1 program: true concentration is not forcing the mind into a narrow tunnel, but expanding awareness to hold both the particular and the universal, the immediate and the eternal, with relaxed presence.

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Part II · Chapter 5

FIKR, ZIKR & WAZIFA

The Practices of Remembrance

Practices of remembrance as taught through Urs's sessions, connecting Fikr, Zikr, and Wazifa to the elemental teachings and the body's inner landscape.

4 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Ashukrillah - Zikr of Gratitude

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Meaning: *"Thanks be to the One"*

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Repeat *"Ashukrillah"* many times in slow, continuous rounds
2. Follow with a period of dwelling in the atmosphere of thankfulness
3. *"Be in this atmosphere of thankfulness for a moment. Be aware of the things around you that support you — that you can breathe in and be aware of something, and breathe out and disperse thankfulness."*
4. *"Let this thankful attitude flow out to this aspect in your life you're thankful for. It can be the simple things, simple but necessary to do the things we wish to do — even the stool we're sitting on, the lights surrounding us."*

TEACHING

"By lifting something up in thankfulness, it is immortalized." (Bawa)

This zikr connects to the first aspect of prayer - gratitude (shukr) - as taught by Murshid in his work on the universality of religious ideals.

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Astaghfirullah Zikr Practice (33x)

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE ZIKR

Astaghfirullah — *"I seek forgiveness from God."*

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

- Repeated **33 times in tone**
- Followed by a period of **silent sitting in the all-compassionate presence**

CONTEXT

This zikr was practiced as part of the teaching on the second aspect of prayer (repentance/Istighfar), connecting to the water element and the teaching on tears of joy, sorrow, and regret together.

"One expression of water is tears. And we have tears of joy. Sometimes we have tears of laughter. We have tears of sorrow, and we have tears of regret."

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Doing Zikr as Murshid

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Pir Vilayat's Instruction:

“When you do the Zikr, don't do it as you. Do it as if Murshid would do the Zikr — and you will feel another power, another energy in it.” (Pir Vilayat)

Teaching Commentary:

This is the third stage of Fana-fi-Sheikh made concrete in a daily practice. Rather than performing the Zikr from one's habitual self, the murid steps into the murshid's presence first — and the Zikr is done from within that merged state. The 'another power' is not added from outside but released from within as the small self steps back.

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Sallallahu 'Alaika Ya Rasul Allah Zikr

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE ZIKR

Sallallahu 'alaika ya Rasul Allah

"Divine benediction be upon you, O messenger of God"

Practice: Recited 11 times in tone

TEACHING

“With fana-fi-rasul, we enter the presence of the great beings. Those who have been remembered for hundreds or thousands of years. The Rasul being the spirit of guidance — those beings through whom this spirit of guidance shone forth in a way that inspires us till today. The cosmic beings through whose presence we are close to the spirit of guidance. And in their presence, all doubts and fear might vanish.”

“We humans have the tendency to understand it in an exclusive way. But even though our attention might not be with all the great beings in the same way, we still acknowledge the spirit of guidance manifesting in them. They are like the rays of a sun — light of the one true being.”

THE UNIVERSAL VISION

This zikr acknowledges the spirit of guidance as it manifests through all the great archetypal teachers:

- Buddha, Zoroaster, Christ, Krishna

- Moses, Mohammed, and others known and unknown
- They are rays of one sun
- Light of the one true being

The practice connects us to this cosmic lineage of guidance that transcends any single tradition while honoring the particular forms through which divine guidance has appeared.

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Part II · Chapter 6

MOVEMENTS, RITUALS & TECHNIQUES

The Body as Sacred Instrument

Urs brought the body fully into practice — arm massage, energy-ball exercises, feeling your own warmth. His rituals honor the body as the vessel of spirit.

3 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Earth Practice: Eshk — Communion with Earth

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE PRACTICE

"In the days coming, just be in communion with Earth in yourself, in your being, outside. If the weather allows, go outside barefoot — to really be in contact."

"This communion of the Earth and our bodies is also described as eshk — a form of love and longing."

"Be aware of this eshk when you take your next step. Your next step might be like a kiss — your body kissing the Earth."

"We might not understand everything they are communicating, but just be there, be aware in the next few days of this wonderful communion. So concentration as a form of awareness."

UNDERSTANDING ESHK

Eshk (عشق) — in Sufi usage, a consuming, longing love. Here Urs applies it not to divine-human love but to the primal bond between embodied being and the Earth that holds it.

CONTEXT: WE ARE EARTHLINGS

"Earth is not just outside of us. We are made of earth. We are the very same material as the whole universe. We have very dense material in our bodies — the bones. They allow us to stand upright. Incredibly strong. It takes usually hard blows to break them. It's like stone. Even stronger are our teeth — an element of Earth."

"So when we are in connection with Earth, it's not just on the outside. Be aware of your very own making. So we are siblings. It's not just 'us and the Earth' — it's we as earthlings. It's just such a wonderful word: earthlings. Made of earth."

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Four Seating Positions for Practice

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Murshid's four traditional postures for practice, with Pir Vilayat's teaching on their inner significance:

POSITION 1 — FOR KINGS AND QUEENS (CROSS-LEGGED / SUKHASANA)

"It is the cross-legged seating. You see it as a very natural way of sitting — around children who are very naturally moving on the grounds. It has different benefits: one is the broader contact with the earth element. It's not just the feet and tailbone, but the knees and thighs

can touch the earth as well. And it can also be a healthy way of sitting as we need to move further to sit and stand up again."

POSITION 2 — THE CUPID (ARCHER'S SEAT)

"The Cupid — like the god Cupid with his bow. This seat is very often taken when doing Zikr. Your right foot is at the back of the knee of your left leg. The big toe and the toe next to it could actually hold the tendon right behind the kneecap — which reminds us of the string of the bow of Cupid."

POSITION 3 — THE POSITION OF THE SAGES (FULL LOTUS / PADMASANA)

"Also known as the full lotus — where the palms of your feet look upwards. Your right foot is placed on the left thigh and the left foot is placed on the right thigh. This can be a very powerful way of sitting, but not for every body easily to sit in."

POSITION 4 — KNEELING

"Kneeling is very close to the full prostration. When you are kneeling, it's the last position before you bend down and put your forehead on the ground — so your heart is lifted. There is a specific way of kneeling where the heel of the right foot is standing up while the heel of the left is bent down."

PIR VILAYAT ON THE INNER MEANING

"Pir Vilayat said: in the posture of the king or queen — the cross-legged posture — we are at the center of the universe. And in the kneeling posture, we are before the beloved."

FOR CHAIR SITTING

Feet truly touching the floor, hips level, back straight for breath to flow, rootedness through tailbone and feet.

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Itisal - The Junction Practice

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

DEFINITION

Itisal (اتصال) - Junction, connection. The practice of the junction between the small and the immeasurable.

THE PRACTICE

"Let us continue in this place where the limited self meets the vast — with the practice of itisal. Itisal meaning the junction between the small and the immeasurable. And over the months to come, the next teaching sessions, you will build up this practice."

Method

1. **Intone Ha** (H-A)
2. **Trace the sound** from the ground to tailbone, right up to chest
3. **Be aware** of how the universe is connected with us from the ground, through the tailbone, right up to the chest
4. **Practice:** Intone Ha 11 times

When to Practice

"You can intone Ha as a practice in the morning right after the elemental breath — while you've already established the connection to the universe around and within you."

THE SOUND

Ha (ه) - The aspirated A. With this sound, we are aware of the universe, being of beings, in deep communion with our limited self.

This is an introductory teaching that will be developed further in coming sessions. The practice establishes the living connection between individual consciousness and universal consciousness through sound and awareness.

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Part II · Chapter 7

TEACHINGS & WISDOM

The Living Transmission

Urs's teachings blend the wisdom of the Inayati lineage with his own 22 years of experience on the path. His stories of personal experience (like the fire element visiting him at breakfast) make the teachings immediately alive and relatable.

41 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Earth Element Teaching - Outer and Inner Dimensions

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

EARTH AS OUTER WORLD

"Every step you take, this Earth is carrying you in the perfect way. There is a wonderful pull of the Earth. It is strong enough that we don't fly away and it is light enough that we are not crushed. It's the most gentle way to be held every day. And still we're most of the time not aware of it."

Two Forms of Outer Earth

Earth as Mountains — majestic, ancient, slow. Qualities: steadiness, strength, calm. *"Even the massive mountains are moving, but in a pace that takes millions of years."*

Earth as Soil — nourishing, patient, holding. *"In spring, it will be this very Earth that nourishes every plant to grow again."*

"It is all-patient. It doesn't ask. It gives when it can."

EARTH AS INNER REALITY — WE ARE EARTHLINGS

"Earth is not just outside of us. We are made of earth. We are the very same material as the whole universe. We have very dense material in our bodies — the bones. They allow us to stand upright. Incredibly strong. It takes usually hard blows to break them. It's like stone. Even stronger are our teeth — an element of Earth."

"So when we are in connection with Earth, it's not just on the outside. Be aware of your very own making. So we are siblings. It's not just 'us and the Earth' — it's we as earthlings. It's just such a wonderful word: earthlings. Made of earth."

THE WORK WITH ELEMENTS

"The work with the elements is a work that has a very, very long history. Very early recordings show us that throughout the world, people have been working with the elements in many different ways."

"It has actually been one of the first practices that I've been given. And throughout the years, it has always changed. It's never been the same. This is very exciting — how a single practice can evolve with you, with your life, your biography, your experiences."

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Five Aspects of Prayer - Introduction and Gratitude

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

INTRODUCTION TO THE FIVE ASPECTS

"Murshid describes these five aspects in his work on the universality of religious ideals. He speaks about these aspects as a common way for human beings of addressing something beyond."

"You have been introduced to Murshid's prayers — the prayers he has been inspired to, that have been prayed by many Murids over many, many years."

"We will look into five aspects of prayer that Murshid introduces us to — that we find in these daily moments when we find ourselves praying outside the ritual prayers. It's these moments when we might try to finish a work and we're not sure if we can make it, and there's a prayer raising in us."

THE FIRST ASPECT — GRATITUDE (SHUKR)

"The first aspect is very close to Earth and what we've been experiencing — and that is gratitude. The aspect of gratitude."

Two Modes of Gratitude

Social gratitude — saying thank you, seeing the other, acknowledging what they've given

Cosmic gratitude — thankfulness for everything dispersed into existence: the air, the Earth, the warmth, the fruit

The Practice of Gratitude

"To connect with this form of prayer means to enter a mode of cherishing everything that has been given. I experience myself and people around me very easily focusing on things we don't have, on things that bother us. And often we find little time to be aware of everything that's there."

"So this aspect of prayer is an invitation to turn our attention, our focus, our concentration on the things that deserve our gratitude."

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Murshid on Earth Personality Type

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

From Murshid's teaching on elemental personality types — specifically the Earth personality:

"A person of the Earth character is calm and quiet, harmonious, serviceable, simple, and good. Also dependable to a great extent." (Murshid)

"Only the person of the Earth character must be told to do something. He will not do anything by himself or by herself. And it is better if you stand by him when he's doing a certain thing and look at him while he is doing it. Then you are sure of getting it done. He's willing to do all he can, but somebody must direct him." (Murshid)

URS'S COMMENTARY

Urs offered this contextualization:

"There is a smiling face in that."

"It's a bit of a caricature of the earthly character, and I'm sure we've met people that we would attribute very strong earthly characters to. But we need to be aware that none of us is just an earthly character or just a fiery character or a watery character."

"We all have all of these aspects in us, but it might be in different strong expressions. And sometimes one aspect might be very dominant."

SHADOW AND LIGHT OF EARTH

"If the Earth aspect is too dominant, it could make us sluggish. But when it's in balance and can produce its very strong side, then it's the element of patience, steadfastness, being there — just being there. What a wonderful quality."

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Murshid on Fault-Finding and Law of Action and Reaction

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ON THE NATURE OF FAULT-FINDING

"When a person finds fault with another, insults another, he does it for two reasons. One is pride — because it satisfies his pride to know, or for it to be known, that he is better than the other. The other thing is that it comes out of cruelty in nature. There is a silent cruelty in the nature of man." (Murshid)

"Satisfaction of which is in causing hurt to someone in whatever form. That person gets a kind of satisfaction out of it. There are some in the world who, by causing hurt physically, by seeing a wound, get a satisfaction. So there are others who get a satisfaction out of hurting someone's feelings. And it is not a rare thing. It is so much to be found everywhere." (Murshid)

THE LAW OF ACTION AND REACTION

"And it must be known that there is action and reaction. Everything that one does has a reaction. It rebounds. Love brings grace. A person — however rich, powerful, highly placed, capable, efficient, supported by many in life, by armies — can be thrown down to the depths of the earth by the smallest hurt he may have caused, which then rebounds. No protection, no support can ward off the blow of the reaction of any hurt a person causes to anybody." (Murshid)

"But one may say there are many people in the world who are quite happy in spite of all the cruelty they have inflicted. But it must be remembered that their time comes. It is nothing but a matter of time." (Murshid)

CONTEXT

This teaching was given in connection with the chivalric rule: *“My conscientious self, do not reproach others, making them firm in their faults.”*

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Body as Vessel - Not Something to Overcome

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Foundational teaching from Urs addressing a common misunderstanding about the body's role in spiritual life:

"Our body is always the first and the last thing we are aware of when we are turning inside. This body is the very vessel that moves us through time and space."

"Our body is not something to overcome to be in touch with other realms. It is that which is given to us to actually host this intelligence and spirit. It is pure expression of it."

"So it's wonderful to be activated and feel this body — and at a certain age, also the limits of this body."

CORE TEACHING

Concentration is not an escape from the body into spirit, but a deepening into what the body already hosts and expresses.

PRACTICE INSTRUCTION

"Every time when you sit down for your practices or stand for your prayer — first be aware of your bodily reality. Be aware of your feet, of your tailbone."

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Concentration as Guardian of the Door

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Teaching following the Buddhist monks story:

"Through concentration, we can build a threshold. Concentration through the mind can be like a guardian of a door that decides who is entering that door and who isn't."

"When a person is bothering you, it is in that moment. But if that person keeps on bothering us in our minds and in our memory — it can be through concentration that we let it go for that moment."

THE POSITIVE REFRAME

Concentration is not passive acceptance but an active, sovereign choosing of what is held in the mind and what is released. The abbot concentrated on the act of service, fulfilled it, and set it down. The young monk concentrated on the transgression — and carried it for an hour through silence.

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Life Force and Concentration - Steering Awareness

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Teaching on how attention directs life force, developed through contrasting examples from ordinary life.

OUTER INFLUENCE: THE COMPANY WE KEEP

"We might experience it with the people around us. Sometimes we are around inspiring people. They help us to change our mood. Maybe we entered a company in an unhappy mood — maybe we have our attention with our sorrows. So the sap flows to these branches that are sorrow."

"Through the company of uplifting friends, one might forget about these branches, and the other branches are filled with energy. And suddenly there is an almost contagious atmosphere and our mood changes."

The Shadow Direction

"I'm sure you've been in situations where everyone was nagging — the mood of complaining about what's happening, what's not good, what's difficult. And it's really hard to withstand it. And one gives energy towards that."

THE INNER DIRECTION OF LIFE FORCE

"There might be a tendency where our life force goes to when we go through our daily life. We might find ourselves giving energy to sorrowful thoughts. And sometimes we might steer it through concentration to more uplifting aspects — like thankfulness, as we discussed before."

"Through concentration, we can actually steer where this life energy goes — what is alive and what we can let go."

BAWA'S TREE ANALOGY - COMMENTARY ON MURSHID

Bawa offered a complementary image to Murshid's bloodstream metaphor — the tree and its sap:

"Murshid compares our minds connected to the bloodstream. Bawa translated it to the picture of a tree with its branches. In a tree, you have thick branches, smaller ones, and

each of them is living through the sap that is running through the tree — giving life to each and every branch, leaf, flower, and fruit. But when one of the branches is not supplied by sap, it withers. It loses its life." — Bawa

"That can be compared to how our mind works. Depending where we steer our awareness, where we steer the life — there something comes to fruition."

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Mind as Bloodstream and Lines - Psychology of Mind

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Central teaching from Murshid on the concentration of the mind:

"Every line which is deeply engraved on the surface of the mind may be linked to a vein where the blood runs keeping it life. And while the blood is running, it is productive of offshoots of the deep-set line. There are moments when there comes a kind of congestion in a certain line where the blood is not running. There are no offshoots. But this congestion can be broken by some outer influence." — Murshid

"And when that congested line is touched by an outer influence, which is related to that particular line, then again it sets the blood running through and offshoots arising, expressing themselves in thoughts. It is just like a waking or sleeping state of these lines." — Murshid

"As a note of music can be fully audible at one time, so one line of offshoots can be comprehensible at a time. And it is the warmth of interest that keeps the blood running in that particular line. There may be other lines where the blood is alive also. Still, if they are not kept warm by one's interest, they become congested and thus paralyzed." — Murshid

"And yet the blood is there, the life is there. It awaits a moment to awaken it. The sorrows of the past, the fears of the past, the joy of the past, can be brought to life after ages and could give the same sensation exactly as one had experienced before." — Murshid

"The more one knows the mystery of this phenomenon, the more one learns to understand that there is a world in oneself. And that in one's mind there is the source of happiness and unhappiness, the source of light and darkness. And that it can be awakened either mechanically or voluntarily, if only one knew how one must do it." — Murshid

"And then one would not blame one's misfortune, nor would one complain of one's fellow man. One could become more tolerant, more joyous, more loving. Because one

knows then the cause of every thought and action, and one sees it all in the effect of a certain cause." — Murshid

"The physician would not take revenge on a patient in the asylum even if the patient hit him, for he knows where it comes from. The psychology of mind is the higher alchemy, and one cannot only study it and not practice it. It is practice and study both that must go together, and this opens the door for every soul to happiness." — Murshid

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Mind as Filter · Soul as Light Source

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

The definitive framework for understanding the mind's role in concentration teaching:

"The mind is the filter for the light of our soul — for what we show in the world of our true being, or what's not shown yet, maybe because the filter of the mind has another focus."

INTEGRATION WITH BREATH AND LIGHT

On the in-breath: imagine how all these imprints through your awareness — led by the mind — stand mirrored by the soul.

On the out-breath: a pure light, the pure light of your soul, shines into this world through this filter.

"The mind is like a filter through which the impressions of the physical world — our bodily, emotional experiences — are given a focus, reflected by the soul."

THE SOUL-MIND-BODY TRIAD

This is the soul-mind-body triad in dynamic form:

- The soul is the source of light
- The mind is the filter (lens) through which that light passes
- The world receives whatever the filter allows through

Concentration is the act of adjusting the filter — clearing, directing, refining it — so that more of the soul's light reaches the world.

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Uruj and Nuzul - Two Directions of Breath

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Teaching from Murshid on the metaphysics of breath:

"Inhaling is called 'uruj,' which means rising. Exhaling is called 'nuzul,' which means descending. And each has its particular part in the life of an individual." — Murshid

"Breath is life, and its work is to take the condition from within to the external plane and to take the conditions of the external plane into one's being." — Murshid

"When one exhales, the conditions of the inner plane are brought out. Their influence first working on one's mind, then on the body, then on surroundings. When inhaling, the conditions of the external plane — harmony or inharmony — are drawn into the body, then into the mind, and then into the soul, which sets the soul either in calmness or in disturbance." — Murshid

"When exhaling, one's feelings and thoughts first work on one's body, then on surroundings. The same is the case with the physical body: it sends out gases with exhaling and inhaling takes in all the fine properties from one's surroundings." — Murshid

PRACTICE INTEGRATION

Urs guided a few breaths with this picture held: breathing in the surrounding — from body to breath to mind to soul — and from soul outward through mind to body to surroundings.

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Murshid on Conscience and Regret

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

“If there is no regret, our conscience is numbed. It loses its sharpness. And with regret, our conscience becomes sharper and clearer, and it refines our moral compass.” — Murshid

URS'S COMMENTARY

“Every mistake we make is an invitation to make another step forward in our life's journey. One could even go so far as to say it's only through mistakes that we learn.”

“When there is a moment of regret, we are actually pointed towards our own true moral compass. And it's like a sign that's steering us to where we're pulled.”

CONTEXT

This teaching was given in connection with the second aspect of prayer (repentance/Istighfar) and the water element teaching on tears that encompass joy, sorrow, and regret together.

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Murshid on Water Personality

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

CHARACTERISTICS OF WATER NATURE

"The person of water character is sociable, imaginative, affectionate, and lovable. Only he will respond quickly to all influences, as the sea responds to the storm. By nature, this person will always be desirable. He or she will show adaptivity, response, and fineness of character." — Murshid

"The person of the water nature is emotional, devotional, generous, but sensitive. There are moments when this person is calm and quiet, and there are moments when this person is quite upset. This person is subject to be misled and yet, if rightly guided, will prove to be most desirable. Creative, expressive, brimming with emotions." — Murshid

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

Urs offered this reflection to accompany Murshid's teaching:

"Where does your water personality express itself? Where is it withheld — because the water can't flow? When the water is stuck in the heart, what can become hard and insensitive. When it's washed by the water of love, it brings up tears."

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Pir Vilayat on Tracing Manifestations to Pure Love

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"Even those manifestations of feelings that we would describe as hateful have their root and source in pure love. Hate is a manifestation of love — a manifestation of love that has become skewed, imbalanced, distorted. But if we track every intention back to its source, we get to something vast, something pure, something divine." — Pir Vilayat

"So the process is to discover: how did such and such a crude manifestation emerge, when what my soul wanted all along was a beautiful expression of its knowledge of the infinite? And by looking back in this way, one can balance a sense of responsibility and vigilance with compassion towards oneself and everyone involved." — Pir Vilayat

CONTEXT

This teaching was shared in connection with the practice of repentance and tracing our actions back to their divine impulse, showing how even difficult emotions and actions can be understood as distorted expressions of something originally pure.

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Teaching on Repentance and Divine Impulse

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ON ACCOUNTABILITY

"Pir-o-Murshid reminds us that if we look back in our past, there are many situations where others have been unfair to us, have hurt us, overstepped. But he reminds us that the accountability in these situations lies with them. We are not accountable for their mistakes."

"But what might it mean to be accountable for the things we did, where we overstepped? Maybe not always, but there are so many moments where it feels so much easier to forgive someone else than to forgive oneself."

THE STUCK PLACE OF REGRET

"Sometimes this regret is so deep that we feel ashamed. We don't dare to look in the other's eyes anymore. And if we remember the one, remember the fact that we're here for a reason — this is probably not the place we are meant to be stuck in, in this moment of regret and beating oneself up for what we did."

TRACING BACK TO DIVINE IMPULSE

"One aspect is to remember that nothing that happens happens outside the one. Every deed, everything we do, is based on a divine impulse. There's nothing that happens which is not based on a divine impulse."

"One step you can take when you have acknowledged that you did wrong to someone — trace your action back to this divine impulse. What of your true being was trying to show itself? It might not have succeeded the way you would wish, and it was hindered by the difficulties of our physical being. Still, the impulse was a divine one. What wanted to be shown? What was it behind?"

PRACTICE FOR WORKING WITH REGRET

1. **Acknowledge the situation:** 'It is how it is.'
2. **When you've been fully present with it,** trace it back to the divine impulse. What of your true being was trying to show itself?
3. **Are there ways to give this impulse a clearer expression** in the love that it was meant to be?
4. **Bring what cannot yet be resolved before the one,** the all-compassionate: 'Let it be held in his loving compassion.'

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Teaching on Tears - Joy, Sorrow, and Regret Together

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE CONVERGENCE OF TEARS

"One expression of water is tears. And we have tears of joy. Sometimes we have tears of laughter. We have tears of sorrow, and we have tears of regret."

"I find there is a very magical moment where all these aspects come together in our tears. And those are moments of ecstasy — when we are truly uplifted in a moment that encompasses every aspect of our human being and our human experience in the light of the one."

THE MOMENT OF RECOGNITION

"Sometimes when you walk and you're just looking at some birds, but you don't see the birds — you see something beyond them. You see an expression of the one, and tears are filling your eyes. And these are tears of joy, sorrow, and regret all together. The joy of the meeting with the one in this seemingly daily situation — but there's also this sweet aspect of regret: why haven't I been there? Why have I been so much away from you?"

ELEVATION THROUGH CONVERGENCE

The convergence is uplifting: when regret stands alone it is heavy. When it meets joy in the presence of the one, all aspects are elevated.

CONTEXT

This teaching was given in connection with the second aspect of prayer (repentance) and the water element, showing how tears become a bridge between the outer water element and inner spiritual states.

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Water Element Teaching - Outer and Inner Dimensions

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

WATER AS CONSTANT FLUX

"With water, we are in contact with a constant flux, a constant movement. And even though we're also taking in the element of earth every day, it's more palpable with water."

MEDITATION ON WATER'S JOURNEY

"Where has all this water already been that we've been drinking today? How many rivers has this water seen? In how many oceans it has already been? How many bodies it has

flown through? How many plants it has nourished? Ever and ever refreshing — again and again."

WATER'S FORMS - URS'S TEACHING FROM NATURE

Urs, walking in snow in the Valais mountains that morning:

"I've been for a short walk today through the snow — in its crystalline form. And slowly the heat of the sun made it melt, and it built small rivers. And it was trickling down, and when I follow it in my imagination, it will end up in little streams, go down to the river, and eventually end up in one of the big lakes."

"Part of this water will be evaporated and will shift in the form of clouds. And other parts will move on to the even bigger vessels — the sea, the ocean. It comes in little streams, seen, streams unseen in the earth. And it also comes with much power, hardly possible to stop."

INCREASING SUBTLETY

"Moving from earth to water, we see an increasing subtlety. It's already much liberated. It chooses its way more quickly, more freely."

INNER WATER ELEMENT

"On the inside of our bodies, it is the predominant element. It's always hard to imagine because with our eyes open, we see a fixed set of body. But when we look inside us, we realize there is so much fluidity, so much water — always in constant movement, a movement that is necessary for us to be alive."

MOVEMENT AS LIFE - STAGNATION AS MURKINESS

"One aspect of water is its movement. If it doesn't move in our bodies, it has dire consequences. When water doesn't move on the street, it builds a puddle. When it stays there for a while, it gets murky and you can't see through it anymore."

"The moment it starts flowing again, it shows its revivifying and cleansing ability — the refreshing."

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Repentance - Outer Expectations vs Soul's Calling

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"I'm aware that the aspect of repentance in the five aspects of prayer is not the easiest one. Many of us have had the experience that throughout our lives, other people have told us what we did right and what we did wrong. And it's sometimes not easy to find a fresh approach to this aspect in life."

"Murshid invites us to differentiate between expectations from the outer and true callings from our soul. It's not so much about moments when we might have let down others due to

their expectations of us. Maybe your parents had a specific wish for what you should become, and you became something much different — but it was their expectation, and it had maybe nothing to do with your true calling."

"But when it's about the soul's journey, and when we feel that in our conscience something is touched — then it can be a guidance. And this calling for healing of regret and sorrow is something truly different."

On Retreats and Repentance:

"Many retreats start with healing practices. One reason is that regrets — especially in these moments when we enter silence — can be very powerful and very present in our minds. And healing is much necessary to let go and be free of things that hold us back."

"Just take your liberty and explore it in all freedom without putting any pressure on yourself, but with curiosity."

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Stay in Conversation with Your Soul — A Gentle Invitation

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

CONTEXT

After sharing the Jataka Tale of *"Myself is Watching"* and the story of Murshid's murid who stopped drinking by realizing he was always in Murshid's presence, Urs offers a deeply compassionate counsel about how to receive these teachings.

THE TEACHING

"Sometimes these stories might be uplifting and sometimes they might put pressure on us because this is not how we experience our life."

"And I think as many of these teachings, they are a very true and sincere invitation to stay in conversation with our soul. Be as much in conversation with this hidden mystery, with your life's purpose, in a gentle and loving way."

"Not with the pressure of, 'Oh, I should be like these beings in these stories.' But with a loving and curious conversation with your soul."

KEY PRINCIPLE

The stories and teachings of the saints are not standards to measure ourselves against — they are invitations to deepen our relationship with our own soul. The approach is:

- **Gentle**, not pressured
- **Loving**, not judgmental
- **Curious**, not demanding

- **A conversation**, not a test

This teaching reflects a core principle of Urs's approach: spiritual practice is not about achieving perfection but about cultivating an intimate, compassionate dialogue with the mystery at the center of one's being.

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Three Stages - Receiving, Assimilating, Representing

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Teaching from Hazrat Inayat Khan

"There are three stages of action which the sincere follower of the message have to pass through, and the difficulty is that each stage has the tendency to keep back the followers from going to the next stage. The reason is that every stage has no end of interest and happiness in it."

"Another thing is that one stage is quite different from another stage, and therefore each stage is a kind of counter-reaction to the stage which was previous. Now, these stages may be called receiving the message, assimilating of the message, and representing the message."

STAGE 1 — RECEIVING

"For a sincere murid, the first stage can be so interesting that one may think it is never enough. That endless knowledge and the heart of the seeker after truth which is never full. Fill it, and there is still a place to fill. May receive for ages, and it's yet never enough. When the receiver of the message is in that stage, then the activity of the further stages remains unaccomplished."

STAGE 2 — ASSIMILATING

"For the next stage, which is the stage of assimilation, patience is most necessary. Very few can imagine how long it takes for the spirit to assimilate knowledge of truth. One assimilates it by the power of contemplation, by pondering over the subjects that one hears, by practicing the teaching in one's life, by looking at the world from the point of view which has been told, by observing one thing in its thousand different positions — one assimilates."

"Many before assimilating the knowledge wish to reason it, wish to discuss it, wish to justify it, and see how it fits in with one's own preconceived ideas. In this way, they disturb the digestive fire of the spirit. For as the mechanism of the body is always working to help assimilate the food, so the spirit is constantly working to assimilate all that one learns through life."

"Therefore, it is a matter of patience and is taking life easily without troubling the mind too much over things, and allowing the knowledge which one has received as a food of the

spirit to have time to assimilate. By trying to assimilate knowledge before the time, one loses one's normal health — just like taking a drug to help digest food, which is not beneficial in the end."

STAGE 3 — REPRESENTING

"But the third process is also necessary, and those who care little for the third stage of representing miss a great deal in life. A person who has seen something beautiful, who has heard something harmonious, has tasted something delicious, who has smelled something fragrant — alone has enjoyed it and yet not completely. The complete joy is in sharing one's joy with another."

"The selfish one who enjoys oneself and does not care for others — wherever one enjoys things of the earth or things of heaven — one's enjoyment is not complete. So it is in the third stage that the following of the message is fulfilled, when a soul has heard and has pondered upon it and has passed the same blessing to others."

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Two Modes of Concentration

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"As you will experience deeper and deeper in the coming months — concentration changes and shows itself in different forms. And sometimes concentration can actually be a mode of letting go. Not being set on a specific point with will, but quite the opposite: with a broadness and openness, with an open awareness."

MUSICAL METAPHOR

"Those of you that have taken up learning an instrument know that there are parts in your study when high concentration is needed — sometimes restless repetition of the same chords. But this kind of concentration wouldn't lead to music."

"So after this kind of concentration, it's the concentration of letting go — being in the music, being very close in this moment where music creates itself and you create the music, and it's not clear anymore where it's coming from."

"This staying in this space between — this is as well a form of concentration, but a different form. And both are needed for music to arise."

THE TWO MODES:

Mode 1 — Willful Focus: Deliberate, repetitive, technical practice. Necessary but insufficient alone.

Mode 2 — Open Presence: Letting go into the music; the threshold where self and sound merge. The fruit of Mode 1.

Both modes apply directly to Sufi practice: the deliberate work of concentration practices (Mode 1) opens into states of expanded awareness and contemplation (Mode 2). Neither replaces the other.

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Urs on the Three Stages in Practice

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

TWO MODES OF RECEIVING

"When you read in a moment where your mind is activated, it is processed very much by the mind — which in some stages of learning is most necessary. But when you do the same reading in a receptive state — maybe you've done some breathing exercise before, or it's in the middle of a retreat — you will experience a different reading. Because it doesn't only resonate with your mind, but with your whole being. And you might understand things that your mind didn't notice."

"When you're sitting in teaching classes like these, the mind is calmer — ideally there's a receptive openness. The mind still has its duties and protects you from being naive. But the mind also knows when it can relax and make way for a deeper truth that is within you and that is in resonance with a message given to you."

ON NODDING OFF IN TEACHING SESSIONS

"Don't worry if you feel tired in these teaching sessions and you might sometimes even nod off. Part of it is because this receptive state is very similar to the state the body is in when it's preparing itself for sleep. So it's not the activated state we're in when we decide to take up tasks. It's a state of resonance, and it uses a lot of concentration and focus not to nod off."

ASSIMILATION AS LIVING PRACTICE

"The assimilation part is already much more active. This is when you go into your practice. This is when you make it your own. All of these teachings are alive in their very own way in the different teachers, and they are alive in their very own way in you. But that needs assimilation — living it, working with it, exploring it. That's what you do when you leave the sessions, when you go back to your lives, or when you're in your mentor groups. Make it your own. Bring it to life."

SULUK AS ALL THREE STAGES

"Suluk is built up this way. It has its receiving parts, its assimilating parts, and its representing parts. As you might have realized, these are not exclusive — they always overlap, and they are never finished. We will always stay students. And it's easier to be a teacher than it is to be a student."

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Fire Element Teaching - Complete

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

HISTORY: THE HEARTH

Urs opened the Fire teaching with a meditation on how fire has accompanied humanity from the beginning:

"Fire has accompanied us as human beings all our lives — from the beginning of the first tribes. And not too long ago, people were not gathering around the light of a TV or a computer, but they were gathering around the hearth, the fire."

"When the work was done, the sun wasn't to be seen anymore. People gathered around the fire in the midst of their homes. The fire was a support for warmth, for light. It was the place where the food was processed. And maybe people looked into these flames in the evenings when the stories were told — some might have already been asleep, and others were still looking into this mystery of the fire."

VIGILANCE AND CONTAINMENT

"Fire needs to be attended, needs to be held. We need the earth element to contain the fire so it emerges its energy where it's nourishing, supportive, and brings things to light. And when we're not vigilant, fire will spread its power in a way that can be most destructive and life-threatening."

Earth and Fire in relationship: Earth is the container that gives Fire its direction and safety. Without Earth's containment, Fire becomes chaos. The elemental sequence is not just parallel — the elements are in dynamic relationship with each other.

INNER FORMS OF FIRE

★ Three inner expressions of fire:

1. **Holy fire in purposeful work** — *"an upright person taking up her work with a holy fire. Without this fire, she might have stayed and watched the scene to unfold."*
2. **Humor and laughter** — *"fire as expressed in laughter; the body heats up; laughter is a combustion of delight."*
3. **Precise intellect** — *"a beam of fire; the focused, penetrating quality of sharp thought."*

"Or it can be experienced in moments of very precise intellect. There is like a beam of fire."

FIRE AS COSMIC PHENOMENON

★ Extended cosmic teaching on fire — three scales: planetary, solar, cellular:

The Fire Beneath Us — Earth's Core

"When we look at the communion of our fire and the fire around us — imagine the earth underneath it, the layers of magma, the core of the planet we live on that is as hot as the surface of the sun."

The Fire Above Us — Sunlight as Vision

"The sun blessing us every day with its warmth and its light — the product of this fire. Remember: when we look around us, we actually don't see the objects. We see the reflected sunlight. So in everything we see, we see the element fire."

The Fire Within Us — Digestion as Combustion

"When we eat, we digest fire that is contained by the plants that have transformed the sunlight to nutritious elements like sugar. And when we eat it and it's burned in the cells, it provides us with energy for every movement."

The fire element thus operates simultaneously at every scale: the planetary core, the stellar light, the cellular metabolism. We are fire-beings at every level of our existence — not metaphorically but physically.

FIRE IN ALCHEMY

"The alchemists know that fire is an important servant for transformation, and she knows the amount of fire that is used to transform one thing into another without burning it."

"And it's the same when we're preparing a meal — the alchemist of the kitchen. This ability to befriend this fire and create something wonderful that nurtures."

The alchemist of the kitchen is a beautiful grounding image: every cook is working with fire daily, calibrating heat, knowing when to increase and when to withdraw, transforming raw matter into something nourishing. Alchemy and cooking are the same art at different scales.

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Fire as Eshk - Love as Consuming Flame

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ARABIC SAYING ON LOVE AS FLAME

★ Full text recovered from transcript:

"Love is a flame. When it befalls the heart, nothing but the face of the beloved remains. Love is a flame. When it befalls the heart, nothing but the face of the beloved remains. It burns up all but the face of the beloved." — Arabic saying

The saying was offered twice — once as a single pass, once as a deliberate repetition to let it settle.

THE MOTH AND THE FLAME

"So in dhikr, in remembrance, there is this fire element that's burning up everything except the one. It's like the moth approaching the flame — becoming the flame."

This is one of the most ancient images in Sufi poetry — the moth (parvaneh) drawn irresistibly to the candle, its annihilation in the flame being the very consummation of its love. In Rumi, Attar, and Hafiz, the image marks fana — the dissolving of the self in the divine. Here Urs connects it directly to dhikr practice: the repetition of divine names as a controlled fire that burns away everything except the one being named.

CONNECTION TO ESHK

"I spoke of the transformative power of fire, and this is also an aspect of the eshk, of the transformative love."

Eshk (عشق), first introduced in C11 as the longing-love of the Earth communion, here expands into the consuming fire of divine love — the eshk that does not hold but burns, does not possess but transforms. The same Arabic word carries both the gentle longing of the Earth breath and the consuming passion of fire.

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Murshid on the Fire Personality

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"The person of fire nature is useful but dangerous. You do not know what he will do from one moment to another. This character is just like a cracker, a firecracker. The silent cracker only needs the touch of a lighted match, and at once will declare that it is a cracker." (Murshid)

"A fire person cannot hide her character. It takes but a moment to bring it out. A least a little excuse will bring him up in a moment. This person is destructive by nature, and the trouble he causes to all others is much less than the harm he does to himself. Her life is as destructive as fire — fire which burns all things and burns itself at the same time." (Murshid)

URS'S REFRAME

Urs offered a careful reframe, consistent with the approach to Earth and Water personalities:

"Murshid touches on the destructive side of fire in people. But again, if we trace it back to the divine origin, it is an expression of the eshk, of the love."

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When the Elements Come to Visit

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

URS'S PERSONAL EXPERIENCE

During the fire element teaching, Urs shares a personal story of how the fire element *"visited"* him that very morning:

"I had the good fortune today to be visited by this fire. I, by accident opened a message from my work, and immediately I could feel the fire rising in me. Fire that makes you alert, makes your mind very present, but also sets the stage to be destructive, to be in this fire as a form of anger."

"And when it happened, I wasn't so thankful yet, but I could really feel how my body was heated up, and that was so amazing that simple words can spark the fire in you."

THE TEACHING

"Maybe you have experienced similar things during these days that when we immerse in one of these elements, they come to visit. And when they visit, I hope we can acknowledge it and be with it and when we've settled again, be with this atmosphere of this element."

KEY INSIGHT

When we practice with the elements — earth, water, fire, air, ether — we develop a sensitivity to their presence. The elements then begin to *"come to visit"* us in daily life:

- **Earth** may visit as a feeling of heaviness, groundedness, or stubbornness
- **Water** may visit as tears, flowing emotions, or adaptability
- **Fire** may visit as anger, passion, alertness, or transformation
- **Air** may visit as lightness, freedom, or scattered thoughts
- **Ether** may visit as spaciousness or transcendence

The practice is not to resist or suppress these visitations, but to **acknowledge** them, **be with** them, and when settled, **remain in the atmosphere** of that element. This transforms everyday emotional experiences into opportunities for elemental awareness.

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Be Mindful of the Transit — Returning to Daily Life

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE TEACHING

At the close of Weekend 3 (the first Urs Qutbuddin weekend), Urs offers this counsel on the transition from retreat back to everyday life:

"We have come to the end of this session. And for some there lies a night ahead, for others the day, but soon you will move out of these three days, and I would like you to be mindful of this transit."

"When you adapt the rhythms again of your daily lives, and go back to all those who have given you this time, be mindful of them as well."

"And I wish you a wonderful time with your practice. Be gentle, but focused, and explore with joy. Take everything like nectar that's given to you, everything you find."

KEY PRINCIPLES FOR THE TRANSITION

1. **Be mindful of the transit** — The shift from sacred retreat to daily life is itself a practice. Don't rush through it unconsciously.
2. **Acknowledge those who gave you this time** — Family, friends, colleagues who held space for your absence deserve mindful gratitude.
3. **Be gentle but focused** — The balance between softness and intention carries the retreat energy forward.
4. **Explore with joy** — Practice is not grim duty but joyful exploration.
5. **Take everything like nectar** — Every experience, whether from practice or from life, can be received as nourishment.

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Concentration and Contact with the Murshid

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"By concentration, by single-mindedness, by sympathy, one can establish a contact with their murshid in which distance would make no difference. And it is for that reason that to some capable of concentration, concentrations are given to contact the murshid in their thought. The qualities of the teacher manifest after that in the murid." (Murshid)

"And as the murid goes onward, the murid feels in himself or herself the heritage of the teacher — as if one had inherited from the teacher the power and inspiration which would help one in the path of truth." (Murshid)

"Many ask: can one not take the direct road to God without the help of a teacher? I say, there is nothing impossible. A ladder is only a means to go from the ground floor to the upper floor, but if one can climb without a ladder, it is not impossible. As the ladder is a convenience, so the teacher takes the same place in the spiritual path." (Murshid)

"It is therefore that in the East, great importance has been given to the guidance under the teacher. And that guidance is considered so sacred — as sacred as one could consider one's

own faith. Because faith in the form of religion is a conception, but when the faith is given in the form of allegiance to a murshid, that is living faith." (Murshid)

"Therefore in the East, it becomes easy for a murid, since those who come under the murshid's guidance know beforehand what a murshid means. They do not need anymore for their objects of concentration the idols of the temple. Once they have come to the murshid, they have found the living example which they wish to follow." (Murshid)

Context:

These teachings from Hazrat Inayat Khan form the foundation for understanding the practice of Fana-fi-Sheikh and the metaphysical basis of the murshid-murid relationship across distance.

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Four Planes of Magnetism

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Each plane represents a distinct form of drawing power that can be perceived and cultivated:

MAGNETISM OF THE BODY

"When someone takes good care of his physique, does a lot of sports, is in good shape — he or she can build a physical magnetism."

MAGNETISM OF THE MIND

"When someone has really put herself, himself to the deep study of a certain matter — when she is most knowledgeable and can quickly combine most complex matters — this can produce a magnetism of the mind."

MAGNETISM OF THE HEART

"When you meet someone whose heart is so open, so responsive — you realize you're seen, your current state is felt, there is a deep resonance and the heart is open. This is a magnetism of the heart."

MAGNETISM OF THE SOUL

"It might be encountered in someone who seems simple, almost naive, but there is something in her glance, in his glance that calls you right away to your source — beyond everything. Immediately your soul is touched by this magnetism of this being."

REFLECTIVE TEACHING

"These are all wonderful magnetisms, and we all have them in us. Maybe we put our concentration on some more than on others. But when we focus on one aspect of our being,

we build up its magnetism. It doesn't need to be exclusive — if one is built, the other doesn't crumble."

"If you explore yourself: where did you put your focus in your life so far? What magnetism did you build? And is there another part inviting your attention?"

"Where was your focus so far? And where shall it be?"

PRACTICE IN DAILY LIFE

"When you go about your lives and you realize suddenly a magnetism of another being is catching you — be curious. What was it? What element of magnetism was it?"

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Inter Esse - Being in the Middle of It

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Etymological Teaching:

"By means of concentration and sympathy — and there's also the aspect of interest — inter esse: to be in the middle of it, so immersed that you become the thing that you're interested in."

Definition:

Inter esse (Latin) — literally 'to be between' or 'to be in the midst of.' The word 'interest' comes from this root.

Teaching Point:

Genuine interest is not a casual preference but a state of immersion — the self entering so fully into the object of attention that the boundary dissolves. Baba Farid's interest in his cow was so total that he literally became it.

Connection to Practice:

This teaching connects directly to the three stages of Fana-fi-Sheikh: each stage is a deepening of inter esse — from looking at the murshid, to being surrounded by the murshid's atmosphere, to being in the midst of the murshid so thoroughly that his qualities express through you.

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Pir Vilayat on Zikr as Murshid

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"When you do the Zikr, don't do it as you. Do it as if Murshid would do the Zikr — and you will feel another power, another energy in it." (Pir Vilayat)

Teaching Context:

This instruction represents the third stage of Fana-fi-Sheikh applied to daily practice. Instead of performing Zikr from one's ordinary consciousness, the practitioner first enters the merged state with the murshid's presence, allowing the Zikr to emerge from that unified awareness. The *"another power"* is not external addition but the natural result of the ego stepping aside.

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Four Aspects of Prayer Mapped to Four Elements

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Urs provided the complete mapping of all four aspects of prayer to the four elements — the first time this full correspondence has been explicitly stated:

EARTH ↔ GRATITUDE (SHUKR)

The first and most grounded prayer; cherishing what is given; earth's gift of carrying

WATER ↔ FORGIVENESS / HEALING (ISTIGHFAR / TAWBA)

The cleansing quality of water; the tear; repentance as a waterfall washing through the heart

FIRE ↔ SUPPLICATION / HAIYA

The prayer of the driven wish; the fire of longing for specific aims and support

AIR ↔ INVOCATION

The subtlest of the four; the longing to be close to the one; reaching out like air in all directions

"We had gratitude with the element earth, forgiveness and healing with water, supplication and the wish for one's aims with fire — and with air, we are with invocation."

This mapping shows how the elemental breath practice corresponds to the complete spectrum of prayer, from the most grounded (gratitude) to the most subtle (invocation).

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Music as Munajat and Teaching

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

MUSIC AT THE CORE OF TEACHING

Urs explicitly framed the session music as integral to the teaching itself:

"Thank you especially Hamad for your wonderful musical inspiration. It's a real blessing that we have with us all these wonderful musicians. I just would like to point out that the music which might seem like an introduction to the teaching is actually very much at the core of the teaching itself."

"While continuing going through the elements and the aspects of prayer, and especially this weekend with the stories of Murshid's life, we might get back to this wonderful aspect of music as a form of teaching."

MUSIC AS MUNAJAT

"This subtlety of longing to be close to the one often reaches us through music — which is also very close to the air element, as it is transported through this element to our ears."

"In the Gayan Vadan Nirtan, there are ragas that contain something called munajat — it's the calling of the beloved, of the lover, in the middle of the night or in the wilderness, when the lover is calling out for the beloved."

THE CONNECTION TO AIR ELEMENT

Music's connection to the air element and invocation creates a natural bridge between the elemental breath practice and the devotional poetry of Murshid. The subtle quality of air corresponds to the subtlety of invocation, both carried through the medium of sound and breath.

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Teaching on Invocation and the God-Ideal as North Star

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE QUALITY OF INVOCATION

"Like air, invocation can be seen as a little bit subtler than the other aspects. Invocation is the reaching out for the beloved — the asking, the longing, the singing for the closeness of the one."

"While in Haiya we are asking for support so that our deepest wishes might be fulfilled, in invocation there is only the wish to be with the one. It's the expression of those sacred moments when the greatest boon is to be in the presence of the one."

"As the saying goes: when you take one step towards the one, he will make a thousand steps towards you."

THE GOD-IDEAL AS NORTH STAR

"This longing is the longing for the God-ideal — which is not the one, but it's like a rung in the ladder, a step which leads us in the direction of the one. It's like the north star. It's our picture of perfection — one that we hold now, and that we let go when this rung of the ladder has helped us to rise further."

"It is like in the Zikr when we say: there is no God but God. We let go of an ideal knowing it's not the one itself — but the north star that leads us."

WHAT GOD LOOKS FOR — BURNING

The core teaching from the story of Moses and the shepherd:

"I don't look at the words. I look at what is in the heart. I want to see burning. Burning is what I hear."

This reveals that the divine response is not to the form of prayer but to the sincerity and intensity of longing in the heart.

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Air Element Character Traits and Balancing

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

AIR ELEMENT QUALITIES

"With air, it's a freedom of thought, being inspired, epiphanies, visionary ideas, and free movement from one thought to the next. There is a liberty and creativity in this."

"And sometimes we experience that it's easy to have a thought, but sometimes not as simple to put these thoughts into practice. So the air element is not so strong in realizing what it creates in the thought. For that, it needs a good balance with the other elements."

THE ELEMENTS IN COMBINATION

When a thought is formed, it needs all four elements to manifest:

- **Air**: The idea itself
- **Fire**: The passion and will that moves it into existence. Otherwise it will just stay a wonderful idea
- **Water**: Takes shape, the down-pouring element that gives form
- **Earth**: Holds this water and gives it clear, concrete direction

"We have been given the gift of all these elements, and sometimes we see one element being predominant in another being, in a friend, and in ourselves. Eventually it's the balancing of the elements that helps each element bring forth its true magnitude, its capability."

The elemental interplay for bringing a vision into reality: Air (the idea) → Fire (the will and passion) → Water (takes form and flows) → Earth (grounds it, gives it concrete direction). All four are necessary; none is complete without the others.

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Murshid on Concentration and Self-Consciousness

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"Real concentration is the forming of the concrete picture of the object of concentration in the mind. Lack of concentration comes from the wavering nature of the mind, and the mind wavers by lack of proper exercise. As the body develops with physical exercise, so the mind develops by concentration." (Murshid)

"The great hindrance that stands against concentration is the thought of one's own being. When one thinks of one's own presence, and at the same time thinks 'I am concentrating on a certain object,' at that time it is impossible to have full concentration. The more one loses the thought of one's own being from one's consciousness, the more one becomes capable of concentration." (Murshid)

"As self-consciousness is the enemy of a speaker, singer, doctor, or lawyer, so it is the great enemy of the one who concentrates. Concentration is to avoid self-consciousness. And at the same time, self-consciousness is the only thing that keeps one from progress. The Sufi, while concentrating, uses abstinence against the constant and uncontrollable activity of the mind." (Murshid)

URS'S COMMENTARY

"As we've already experienced, concentration has different modes or steps. And while in the beginning, concentration seems to be with a focused will, there is another concentration where we are just immersed in the object that we are looking at — so immersed that there is no object and no subject anymore. There's just pure awareness."

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Murshid on the Air Personality

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"The person of air character is moody and imaginative and visionary. At one moment he is your great friend, at the other moment he is your enemy. As the air at the moment before was blowing to the east, and the moment after went towards the west — this person will have material fits and spiritual fits, and spells of virtue and obsession by evil." (Murshid)

"This person will change from time to time. When you think today he is good, tomorrow he will show himself different. When you see this morning he was calm, in the evening you will find him upset. It is the greatest difficulty to keep that person in control. It is like controlling the air, which is always difficult." (Murshid)

"Yes, this person will show wit, quickness in grasping things, capability, efficiency in work. She will act on impulse, she will be adventurous, and if powerful, will be influential in life." (Murshid)

URS'S COMMENTARY

"I wouldn't take it as an invitation to put people into boxes of the different elements, but maybe it can be like a lens through which we sometimes perceive what is in and around us. And when we sometimes realize that a situation contains a lot of fire that has no container — the fire without the container will spread — then the earth element might be helpful to balance the situation."

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Gayan Vadan Nirtan as Companion

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Gayan Vadan Nirtan described as a companion to be opened, not read:

"As Murshid does in his writings of the Gayan Vadan Nirtan — a collection of his pearls of wisdom. It's not a book which you read from the beginning to the end. It's rather a steady companion which you open and see what awaits you. Gayan meaning singing, Vadan playing music, and Nirtan dancing."

"Murshid describes the yearning for the one, the seeking for the friend — writes about longing and absence, separation and remembrance, the pursuit, the trace, the fragrance of the one. The disappearance of the self into the infinitude of the one being — describes the loss of the self and the emergence of the true self."

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Murshid on the Ether Personality

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"The character of the ether person shows all the above-set qualities — the qualities of all the elements — and yet every quality in a subdued form. This person will be serious, calm, quiet, peaceful, subject to sadness and melancholy at times, yet responding to humor and mirth, rhythmic in action, balanced in life, deep in understanding, brave bearing at the same time, thoughtful and considerate." (Murshid)

“Ether is the essence of all the elements, and a person that shows ether in one's character shows wisdom. Where there is wisdom, there is beauty. Wisdom is adorned by beauty. This person will have the power of attraction and expression, together with magnetism expressed through one's whole personality.” (Murshid)

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Bawa - Concentration Is a Sign of Love

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"Concentration is a sign of love." — Bawa

URS'S TEACHING

“We've experienced it in a moment when you see a friend. And when this friend is really there — and you feel that he or she is not preoccupied with a thousand other things, but is there in this moment with you — you're seen. How precious is this? This is also a form of concentration, and with it, an expression of sincere feeling and love.”

THE FINAL SYNTHESIS

This is the final teaching of Concentration 1: the practice returns to where it began — to presence, to being truly with another, to the act of seeing and being seen.

All the techniques have been in service of this:

- The dot
- The colors
- The elemental breath
- Fana-fi-sheikh
- The star
- All visualization practices

They have all been developing the capacity to be fully present with what is in front of you, and to offer the gift of that presence to another.

THE CIRCLE COMPLETE

Concentration is not ultimately about mental control or psychic powers. It is about love — the ability to give someone or something your complete, undivided attention. To be so present that the other feels truly seen, truly met, truly received.

This is perhaps the most profound spiritual accomplishment: to love so purely that your very attention becomes a blessing.

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Murshid on Fana-fi-Rasul - The Self-Made Ideal

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

> *"There is an initiation the seeker gets from one's ideal. And who is this ideal? No living creature on earth, however great, can prove to be the ideal of anyone else. He or she may for a certain time, but not forever." — Murshid*
>
> *"The great ones like Buddha, Zoroaster, Christ, and Krishna, who have been the ideal of humanity for thousands of years — during their lifetime, they gave a sense of being the ideal. They left impressions which afterwards proved them to be the ideal. But during their lifetime, they could not prove it. Why? Because even the perfect human being is limited in the imperfect garb of humanity. Human limitation covers perfection." — Murshid*
>
> *"However great, however deep, however spiritual a person is — that person remains limited. One cannot make oneself as one's pupil imagines one. Imagination goes further than the progress of the human being. Imagination is every person his own." — Murshid*
>
> *"And therefore, one can only make one's ideal oneself. No one has the power to make the ideal of another person. It is the impressions of the great saviors of humanity, it is their goodness — whatever little grain of an ideal they have left behind — that becomes just like a seed. And that seed put into the soil of the devotee's heart develops into a plant that can bear fruits and flowers as it's reared." — Murshid*
>
> *"So in this initiation, there is the ideal of the human imagination. One may call it Christ, or Buddha, or Mohammed, or Moses, or Zoroaster. It is one's ideal. It is one who has made it. It is one's savior. Certainly it will save one, if one considers it to be one's savior." — Murshid*
>
> *"One has to make it. If one does not make it, the savior will not save one. Once one has made one's savior, then one is face to face with that perfection which one's heart has created. Then this impression flowers and grows into a tree and bears flowers and fruit which one has desired. Once this initiation is received, one begins to radiate one's initiator who is within one as one's ideal." — Murshid*

URS'S COMMENTARY

"We are fortunate that many of what Murshid says here are encompassed in the prayer Saum. So practicing Saum will give us the opportunity to go deeper and deeper into this wisdom that Murshid is bringing forth."

This dense and rich passage was recommended for repeated study and contemplation. It reveals the profound psychology of spiritual idealization and the creative power of the devotee's imagination in manifesting their own salvation through communion with the great archetypal guides.

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Murshid on Single-Mindedness

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

> *"Single-mindedness as a nature becomes a great help to concentration. People with a great many responsibilities and a great many interests in life cannot keep up single-mindedness, which indeed is a great power. This nature can be developed by concentration." — Murshid*
>
> *"It is at first essential for one who practices concentration to allow one thought at a time or one action at a time, and to keep mind and body busy together. When a person does something, one should not be thinking of another thing while doing it. And if one wishes to think out something, one must not be doing something at the same time." — Murshid*
>
> *"Single-mindedness is a complete absorption of one's whole being in a single thought, speech, or action. Also, single-mindedness can be developed by dwelling on a subject until the thought is finished — and while thinking on the subject, not allowing the mind to take up another subject. The same law should be observed in speech and in action." — Murshid*
>
> *"In this way, one can develop concentration at every moment of the day and night. And by acquiring this one, acquires mastery over one's life as well as over life in general." — Murshid*

URS'S PRACTICAL GUIDANCE

"Maybe you feel invited to just be aware of this invitation from time to time and develop a habit. Maybe you already have that one time a day where you pour a cup of tea. Then for a moment — just be with drinking this cup of tea. Even if it's a minute where you restrain yourself from scrolling through your mobile. Just for this moment, be with you drinking that tea. And what first might sound like a challenge might be a moment of relaxation, where not everything has to be at once, but only this."

THE PRACTICE

- One thought at a time OR one action at a time
- Keep mind and body busy together
- Complete absorption of whole being in single focus
- Develop through simple daily moments like drinking tea
- A moment of relaxation rather than strain

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Part II · Chapter 8

STORIES & PARABLES

Teaching Through the Heart's Ear

Stories and parables shared by Urs — from the Jataka Tales to the murid who stopped drinking — teach through the heart's ear with warmth and humor.

13 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Story of Ayaz - Teaching on Gratitude

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

As told by Urs, attributed to Pir Zia's telling of a Murshid story, to illuminate the first aspect of prayer — gratitude:

THE STORY

"Ayaz was a young man who worked in the palace of the king Mahmud, who saw so much integrity in his eyes that he kept promoting him. Ayaz had come from humble origins, but eventually he became the prime minister."

"Some of the other workers in the palace became envious, and they looked for the chance to bring him down. They saw that every day he would quietly go into the treasury, and they thought: 'That's it. Now we've got him.'"

"So they went to Mahmud and said, 'We're so sorry to tell you this, but you can't trust Ayaz. He's stealing from you. He keeps going into the vault of the treasury.' So Mahmud said, 'I can't believe that of him. The only way I would ever believe such a thing would be if I saw it with my own eyes.'"

"They made a hole in the wall through which Mahmud could look into the treasury, and there he waited and watched as Ayaz went inside. He saw Ayaz opening a chest. And out of this chest, he took a darp — an old frock, a rag cloth. He took off his jeweled crown, his turban, he took off his brocade robe, and he put that old frock on."

"And he stood in front of a mirror and said: 'Oh Ayaz, this is where you come from. This is who you've been. And everything else — the jewels, the silk, the power, the fame — all of that, it isn't yours. That is all the gift of Sultan Mahmud. So remember this, Ayaz. Remember the kindness of the one who has shown you so much generosity.'"

"One can't imagine what went through Mahmud's mind. He was ashamed of what he did. 'How could I have doubted him?' Feeling a bit ashamed to be there peering through the hole, having succumbed to skepticism, but at the same time now being so deeply moved at this amazing soul who so deeply honored the gifts he had bestowed."

"And he felt such a profound love for Ayaz that he rushed into the treasury and embraced him and said: 'They told me that you were stealing from me, but the truth is that you've stolen my heart.'"

TEACHING

The story illuminates the heart of gratitude: not sentiment, but a living practice of remembering origin, honoring gift, and staying humble before the source of all one has been given.

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Story of Two Buddhist Monks - Carrying Burdens

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A teaching story on concentration as the threshold between carrying and releasing, as told by Urs:

THE STORY

"It's the abbot and a young apprentice. They have both vowed that they would uphold the rules of the monastery. And one rule was not to touch a woman."

"They were on their way to another monastery and were walking for days, and they came to a river. And at this river stood a woman asking for help to cross the river. The abbot immediately offered his help, asked the woman to get up on his shoulders, and he carried her over the river so she didn't get wet. He let her down at the other side and gave his thanks, and they parted their ways."

"The two monks walked on, and the young monk was first slightly irritated. Why did he so willfully break the rule of the monastery not to touch a woman? The longer they went in silence, the more he got angry. He's the abbot. He should know better. Why did he do that? He can't be doing that. What an example is he? And so it went on and on in his head."

"After about an hour of silence, it burst out of him and he said to the abbot: 'Why did you do that? Why did you take this woman and help her over the river?' And he let go all his steam. And the abbot just said: 'How interesting. I put the woman down the other side of the river, but you have been carrying her all this way.'"

THE TEACHING

This story illustrates concentration as the threshold between carrying and releasing - showing the difference between engaging with a situation in the moment versus carrying it mentally long after it has passed.

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Story of the Pious Man Who Tried to Be Moses

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE STORY

“There is a wonderful story of a very pious man whose ideal was Moses. And he knew everything about Prophet Moses, peace be upon him. He tried to be exactly how Moses was — to clothe himself like him, to speak like him, to act like him, to follow the rules as he did. He did this for his whole life.”

“And when he finally passed away and came to the doors of heaven, he was sure that he would be greeted very delightfully. And the angel at the door looked at him and said: 'Oh, it seems you are Moses — but Moses is already here. We're actually expecting you.'”

TEACHING POINT

The story is the answer to the question: what is the work only you can do? The angel was not waiting for another Moses. The angel was waiting for that specific, unrepeatable soul — in its own form, its own note, its own expression.

CONTEXT

This story was told in connection with the rule *“Do not spare yourself in the work you must accomplish,”* illustrating that the work we must accomplish is the unique expression of our own divine nature, not an imitation of someone else's path.

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Iblis Wakes the Pious Man

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

“There was a pious person who followed the daily prayers meticulously — he never missed a single prayer. And one day, being more tired than usual, he seemed to oversleep the early morning prayer.”

“But there was a mystical being by his bedside, waking him up so he didn't miss the prayer time. And he woke up and looked at this being and was astonished. He was expecting an angel. But there in front of him was actually a fallen jinn — Iblis, Satan, who had woken him up.”

“And he asked: 'Why did you wake me up so I don't miss my daily prayer?' And Satan said: 'I knew if you had missed this prayer and woken up, you would have shed a tear that would have been so pure that it would have washed the sins of the earth.'”

Teaching Context:

The story illuminates the teaching on repentance and the convergence of tears — joy, sorrow, and regret meeting in a single moment of the soul. That tear, had it fallen, would have been of a purity so absolute that even the adversary feared its power.

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Murshid's Murid the Alcoholic

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

“It is said that when Murshid asked a murid if he would want to take initiation — because he had attended many teaching sessions and many meetings — the murid said: 'Oh no, I could never.'”

“'Why?' 'Well, you know, I'm a really bad man and after all, I'm an alcoholic. I'm really bound to the drinks, so I could never take initiation.' Murshid asked him: 'And if you would just let go of the drinking when you are in my presence — would that be a possibility?' And he said: 'Yes, of course. I would never drink in your presence.'”

“So he went, and as the story goes, he never drank another day — because he realized that he was always in Murshid's presence.”

Urs's Commentary:

“Sometimes these stories might be uplifting and sometimes they might put pressure on us — because this is not how we experience our life. I think, as with many of these teachings, they are a very true and sincere invitation to stay in conversation with our soul. Be as much in conversation with this hidden mystery, with your life's purpose — in a gentle and loving way. Not with the pressure of 'I should be like these beings in these stories,' but with a loving and curious conversation with your soul.”

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The Distracted Lady

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

“There was a lady who had no concentration in her life, no focus. She was always prone to distraction, never paying attention. And she went on a journey, and at a certain point she wasn't sure which direction she should follow. So she asked someone who happened to be standing beside the path.”

“That person said: 'Once you climb up this hill, there's a cliff, and right beside that cliff, there's a tree. And you can either go right or left, but you should go right.' Now, this lady was prone to distractions. So she asked for directions, but while the person was giving directions, she just stared looking around — half listening to what she had been given.”

“She did remember there was something about getting to a tree. So she climbed up the hill, got to a tree, and there were two paths — one to the right, one to the left. And she thought: 'Now what did that person say? Was it the left or the right? It was definitely one of the two. I can't remember which one. I don't want to go the wrong direction. So I think I'll just go straight.'”

“To go straight in that case meant that she actually had to climb up the tree. So she started climbing — went higher and higher into a very high branch. That branch bent down, and then she was hanging by that branch over the cliff. And she was stuck there for a while.”

“Then someone came along — a lady riding on an elephant — and she passed right under the branch. Here finally was the chance for the distracted lady to get some help. The lady on the elephant reached up to help her down. She took hold of her hand — but was so distracted that she forgot to let go of the branch. She was just holding on to the lady on the elephant and holding on to the branch.”

“So the lady on the elephant got pulled off the elephant, and then just the two of them were hanging there over the cliff on the branch. They were really stuck. Hours passed. There was no help. And finally, to while away the time, the lady who had been riding on the elephant decided to sing a song. And the distracted lady was so delighted by the song that she clapped her hands in applause.”

“And of course, that meant letting go of the branch — and so they both tumbled down into the river. And that's the end of the story.”

Urs noted: *“There's no happy ending, I'm afraid.”* This is intentional. The story's humor contains a real warning.

“It's a reminder that distraction can get us in a lot of trouble. It's a story that encourages attention. Whatever we're doing, whatever's going on — be present, be aware, listen.”

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The Master's Test - Myself is Watching

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

From the Jataka Tales (Buddhist teaching stories)

“'I am poor and weak,' said the master one day to his pupils. 'But you are young and I teach you. It is therefore your duty to find the money which your old teacher needs to live.' 'How can we do so?' asked the pupils. 'The people of this town are so little generous that it would be vain to ask them for help.'”

“'My children,' replied the teacher, 'there is a way to gain money — not by asking, but by taking. It would be no sin for us to steal, for we deserve money more than others. But alas, I am too old and too weak to do it.' 'We are young,' replied the pupils. 'We can do it. There is nothing we would not do for you, dear master. Tell us only how to act and we will obey.'”

“'Young people you are,' said the master. 'It would be nothing to you to seize a rich man's purse. This is the way to do it. Choose a quiet spot where no one watches. Then catch hold of that passerby and take his money. But do not harm him.' 'Straight away we go,' said all the pupils — except one who had been silent, his eyes cast downward.”

“The teacher looked at this youth and said: 'My other pupils are courageous and eager to help. But little do you mind your teacher's suffering?' 'Forgive me, master,' he replied. 'The plan you have explained seems to me impossible. That is the reason for my silence.' 'Why is it impossible?' asked the master.”

"'Because there is no place where no one is watching,' replied the pupil. 'Even when I am quite alone — by myself — myself is watching. I would rather take a bowl and beg than allow myself to see me stealing.'"

"At these words, the master's face lighted up with joy. And he took the young pupil in his arms and embraced him. 'Happy am I,' he said, 'if among my pupils, one has understood my words.' His other pupils, seeing that their master had meant to test them, bent their heads in shame. And after that day, whenever an unworthy thought came to their minds, they remembered their companion's words: 'Myself is watching.' Thus became great human beings, and they all lived happily ever after."

Urs's Commentary:

"Myself is watching."

"This story also reminds us of the distinctions between our outer role we play and who we are in private. The stories we heard are not so much about who we sometimes need to appear as in the work we do or what people expect us to be. It is much more linked to our soul and the being we're ever becoming — we've always been, we always will be, but which is on a path."

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Baba Farid Shankar and the Cow

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A teaching story about Baba Farid Ganj-e-Shakar (c. 1173–1266), the great Chishti saint, here as a young murid of Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki. This story demonstrates the power — and comedy — of complete concentration and sympathy.

THE STORY

"The murshid had many murids, and they gathered with Khwaja Qutbuddin to receive instructions. He said: 'I would like each of you to think of something that you find lovely, something that you find beautiful. Think of it. Go off into a little cell, a little room, and think of something you really love. Take a while — then I'll call you back.'"

"So they each went their way into their little rooms. Baba Farid went into his cell, and he thought for a moment: 'What do I really like?' And then he thought of his cow. His cow back home — a very sweet animal he had always had a special affection for."

"'That cow is really such a splendid creature. I think I will think about that cow.' So he went into concentration."

"Then the time came when all the murids had to be called back, and they all came back pretty quickly — except Baba Farid. He just stayed in that room. So the murshid went to the

door and said: 'All right, it's time to come back now. Baba Farid, come on.' And Baba Farid answered: 'Moo… Moo…'"

"So the murshid said: 'No, no, no — that's over now. You can open your eyes. We've finished. Come on.' Then Baba Farid got up and came to the door — but each time he was about to pass through, he stopped."

"The murshid said: 'Come on now, we've got to come back.' And Baba Farid said: 'Horns too big. The horns too big.' He couldn't get through the door because of his big horns."

"So he had really given himself to the practice. And not only did he think about the cow — he became the cow."

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The Patient Buffalo - Jataka Tales

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

A teaching story from the Jataka Tales, attributed to Pir Sad Nur. A teaching on endurance, the thinking mind, and the patience that calls forth grace.

THE STORY

"A giant-like buffalo with mighty horns lay under a tree asleep. Two mischievous eyes peeped through the branches. And a little monkey said: 'I know a good old buffalo who's sleeping 'neath the tree, but I am not afraid of him, nor he's afraid of me.' And he leaped from the branch on the buffalo's neck."

"The buffalo opened his eyes, and seeing the monkey dancing on his hip, he closed them again as if only a butterfly were on his back."

"Then the rascal monkey tried another trick — jumping on the buffalo's head between his two large horns. He held the ends and swung as on a tree. The buffalo did not even wink. 'What can I do to make this good friend angry?' he thought."

"While the buffalo was eating in the fields, the monkey trampled on the grass wherever he wished to graze. And the buffalo merely walked away. Another day, the mischievous monkey took a stick and knocked the buffalo's ears with it. Then, while he was taking a walk, sat on his back like a hero holding the stick in his hand. To all of this, the buffalo never made a murmur — though his horns were strong and mighty."

"But one day, while the monkey sat on his back, a fairy appeared — a great being. 'You old buffalo,' she said, 'but little do you know your strength. Your horns can break down trees, and your feet could crush rocks. Lions and tigers fear your approach. Your strength and beauty are known to the whole world. And yet you walk about with a foolish monkey on your back. One blow of your horn would pierce him and a stroke of your foot would crush him. Why do you not throw him on the ground? Finish with this play.'"

"'The monkey is small,' replied the buffalo, 'and nature has not given him much brain. Why then should I punish him? Moreover, why should I make him suffer in order that I may be happy?' At this the fairy smiled, and with her magic wand she drove the monkey away, and she gave the great buffalo a charm by which no one could ever cause him to suffer again, and they lived happily ever after."

COMMENTARY - THE MONKEY AS THE THINKING MIND

"In Buddhist tales, the monkey often represents the thinking mind. And it sometimes feels like this when we're sitting and doing our concentration practices — this mind is like the monkey who's trying new and new tricks to distract us."

"But in the story, it is said that the monkey refers to the buffalo as his friend. He's not treating him like this because he doesn't like him. There is love for the buffalo, there is a dependence on it."

"And on the other hand, the buffalo says: 'I do not need my mighty strength to crush the monkey. What would it give me? What joy would it give me?'"

"By this endurance, by this knowing his true strength and letting the monkey be the monkey without giving him more attention than necessary — by not taking the bait, not putting his concentration and awareness to the monkey — by that, the fairy appeared and freed him."

"So don't take the bait and try to stay focused. It can also be sometimes even entertaining to see how clever the mind is to get your attention — and there is something lovable about it. But we don't stay there with our attention."

Teaching Point:

The buffalo's approach to the monkey — patient, un-reactive, rooted in its own nature — is the practice of concentration itself. Not suppression, not combat, not feeding. Just the return, again and again, to the point of concentration. The fairy who appears is grace: it comes not from fighting the monkey but from the quality of patient, dignified presence.

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The Story of Moses and the Shepherd (Rumi)

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

From Rumi's Masnavi, taught in the context of invocation and the many valid forms of prayer:

THE STORY

"Moses, the Prophet Moses, peace be upon him, was walking in the desert and there he saw a shepherd who was calling on God. And the shepherd was saying: 'Oh God, if you would

only come to me, I would darn your socks and wash your cloth, and comb your hair, and kill your lice, and give you milk to drink, and massage your little hands and feet.'"

"Now, hearing this, Moses was greatly taken aback. He said to the shepherd: 'Who do you think you're talking to? Your uncle? You're speaking to the creator of the whole universe, and the words you are using are poorly chosen.' Now the shepherd was struck by these words of Moses and quietly went off to the distance."

"But then a revelation came to Moses and the divine voice spoke and said: 'Moses, you have come between a worshipper and me. Your mission is to bring union, not separation — but you've caused a separation here. Every person, every worshipper has their voice, has their way of expression, and one cannot be for another. Each uses the words that come naturally to themselves. And this was his way of speaking.'"

"'But I don't look at the words. I look at what is in the heart. I want to see burning. Burning is what I hear.'"

"So Moses realized that he had made a mistake. And he chased after the shepherd and said: 'News has come. Wait, wait, just listen. Give your heart's prayer to God.'"

THE SHEPHERD'S RESPONSE

"And the shepherd looked at him and said: 'I've gone beyond that now.'"

The disturbance itself became the catalyst for a further ascent. Moses's rebuke — though mistaken in its form — became the force that pushed the shepherd beyond the rung he had been on. What looked like harm was in fact, within the divine economy, a grace.

TEACHING POINTS

- Every worshipper has their own authentic voice and way of expression
- God looks not at the words but at the burning in the heart
- Sometimes apparent obstacles become catalysts for spiritual advancement
- The mission of prophets is to bring union, not separation
- Even mistakes in guidance can serve the divine purpose

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Story of the Door Knock - "It's Me" → "It's You"

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Classic Sufi teaching story on union, often attributed to Rumi:

"There is a wonderful story that is often told to describe this union. It tells of a person looking for her friend, going to a door, knocking at the door of her friend. And the voice says: 'Who is there?' And she says: 'It's me, your friend.' The voice says: 'There is only room for one in here, so go away.'"

“And after a long time and many years, she returns, knocks again at the door. And the voice says: 'Who is there?' And she says: 'It's you, beloved.' And the door opens. There is only room for one.”

"There is only room for one."

This story is the fifth aspect of prayer crystallized in a single image: the journey from 'It's me' — duality, the self presenting itself — to 'It's you' — the dissolution of the self into the presence of the beloved. The door that could not open for the separated self opens immediately for the one who has become the beloved.

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The Dervish Who Called Everyone 'Ya Murshid'

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

THE STORY

This story comes from Murshid's own life when he was with his own murshid:

Hazrat Inayat Khan sees a dervish approaching him. The dervish says: *“Ya Murshid! Oh Murshid! Oh Murshid! My Murshid!”*

Hazrat Inayat Khan is uplifted, sure that this dervish sees the resonance of his own murshid in him. That's why he's calling him Murshid.

But then he sees the dervish wander off and go to the next person — a policeman — saying: *“Ya Murshid! Oh Murshid! Oh my Murshid!”*

Hazrat Inayat Khan realizes, as he describes, that it was not so much the resonance of his own murshid that the dervish saw — but the dervish was so immersed in the image of his own murshid that all he could see, in everybody and everything he saw, he saw his murshid.

THE TEACHING

This story illustrates the third stage of fana-fi-sheikh — where the murshid is no longer an image held separately, but becomes the lens through which all reality is perceived.

The dervish had reached a state where the murshid was no longer *“other”* but had become his very way of seeing. The policeman becomes the murshid because the dervish sees nothing but the murshid.

This is the living reality of complete absorption in the ideal — where the boundary between self and teacher dissolves so completely that the entire world becomes a theophany of the beloved guide.

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The Little Hare and the End of the World

Source: C20 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

From the Jataka Tales

THE STORY

One day, a little hare sat under a fruit tree and thought, and thought, and thought: *"What will happen to me when the earth comes to an end?"* And at that very moment, a fruit fell from the tree. Off ran little hare as fast as his legs could carry him, so sure he was that the noise of the fruit falling was that of the earth breaking to pieces.

"Brother, brother!" called another little hare who saw him running. *"Pray, tell me what has happened?"* But little hare ran on and did not even turn to answer. The other hare ran after him. At last, little hare stopped a moment and said: *"The earth is breaking to pieces."* At this, the other hare started running still faster. A third hare joined, and a fourth, and a fifth — till a hundred thousand hares were racing through the fields.

As they raced through the forest and the deep jungles, the deer, the boars, the elks, the buffalos, the oxen, the rhinoceros, the tigers, the lions, and the elephants — hearing that the earth was coming to an end — all ran wildly with them. But among those living in the jungle was one lion, a wise lion, who knew everything that took place in the world.

When it became known to him that so many hundreds and thousands of animals were running away because they believed the earth was breaking to pieces, he thought: *"This earth of ours is far from coming to an end — but my poor creatures will die if I do not save them, for in their fright they will run into the sea."*

And he ran at such a pace that he reached a certain mountain in their path before they came to it. As they passed by the mountain, he roared three times with such a mighty roar that they stopped in their mad flight and stood still, trembling. The great lion descended and approached them. *"Why are you running at such a pace?"* he asked. *"The earth is breaking to pieces,"* they replied.

"Who saw it breaking to pieces?" he asked. *"The elephants." "Did you see it breaking?"* he asked the elephants. *"No. The lions saw it."* He asked each in turn — the lions, the tigers, the rhinoceros, the oxen, the buffalo, the elk, the boar, the deer, the hares — until he came to the little hare.

"Did you see the earth breaking?" he asked the little hare. *"Yes, Lord,"* replied the hare. *"I was sitting beneath a fruit tree and I thought: what will happen to me when the earth comes to an end? And at that very moment, I heard the noise of the earth breaking and I ran."*

The great lion thought: *"He was sitting beneath the fruit tree — so certainly the noise he heard was that of a fruit falling." "Ride on my back, little one,"* he said, *"and show me where you saw the earth break."* Little hare jumped on his back, and they flew to the place.

But as they approached the fruit tree, little hare jumped off, so frightened he was to return to the spot. He pointed out the tree. The great one went to the tree and saw the spot where little hare had been sitting, and the fruit which had fallen. *"Come here, little one — now, where do you see the earth broken?"* Little hare, after looking around and seeing the fruit on the ground, knew that there had been no occasion for his fright.

He jumped once again on the lion's back, and away they went to the hundreds and thousands of creatures who were awaiting their return. The lion then told the great multitude that the noise little hare had heard was of a fruit falling to the ground. And so all turned back — the elephants to the jungle, the lions to the caves, the deer to the river banks, and little hare to the fruit tree. And they all lived happy ever after.

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Part II · Chapter 9

QUOTES, SAYINGS & POETRY

Luminous Fragments

Quotes, sayings, and poetry from Urs's sessions, including readings from Murshid on the fire personality, Rumi on the ocean, and the Arabic saying on love as flame.

10 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Key Teaching Quotes from Urs Session

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ON GENTLENESS WITH PRACTICE

"Just be steady, but be kind. Don't push yourself too much, also not too little. And be aware also in these moments where you can't do the practices or the homework — just be aware of what is."

ON DEPTH VS MULTIPLICITY

"Rather just take one — like the pupil with the Alif — than being distracted in every possible direction with the multitude of different exercises."

ON EARTH CONNECTION

"Your next step might be like a kiss — your body kissing the Earth."

ON GRATITUDE

"By lifting something up in thankfulness, it is immortalized." (Bawa)

ON RULES AS INVITATION

"The rules are an invitation. They are not set because these rules change with the ears and the tongues that hear them and speak them. They change with your biography, with where you're at."

"They are like lenses that help us to explore ourselves, our connection with the world, and be aware of our moral compass."

ON DIVINE LOVE

"God is love, and this love is also expressed through our own hearts."

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Amir Minai on Sin and Divine Mercy

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"As my sins arouse the mercy of my Lord, not to sin is a sin of a sort. As my sins arouse the mercy of my Lord, not to sin is a sin of a sort."

— Amir Minai

COMMENTARY

This paradoxical verse points toward the completeness of divine mercy: even the misstep calls forth something healing from the divine. The universe is not lessened by our falling — it is, in some mysterious way, made more complete.

CONTEXT

This verse was shared in connection with the teaching on repentance and the quality of Rahman (the All-Compassionate), illustrating the mysterious workings of divine mercy.

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Quranic Inscription at Murshid's Grave - Divine Forgiveness

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"Do not despair of God's mercy. The divine forgiveness encompasses everything."

— Qur'an 39:53 (Surah Az-Zumar)

CONTEXT

This inscription is found at Murshid Hazrat Inayat Khan's dargah in Delhi and was cited in connection with the teaching on repentance and divine mercy.

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Rumi on Returning to the Source

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"When I am polluted, I return to the source — the source, the source of purity, the ocean. When I'm polluted, I return to the source of the source, of the source of purity, the ocean."

— Rumi, Masnavi

CONTEXT

This quote was shared in connection with the water element teaching and the practice of repentance, illustrating how we can always return to the divine source for purification and renewal.

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"Myself is Watching"

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Quote: *"Because there is no place where no one is watching. Even when I am quite alone — by myself — myself is watching. I would rather take a bowl and beg than allow myself to see me stealing."*

Source: Student in the Jataka Tale of the Master's Test

Context: The key teaching moment in the story where one student recognizes the inner witness that observes all actions, even when completely alone.

Urs's Commentary: *"Myself is watching. This story also reminds us of the distinctions between our outer role we play and who we are in private."*

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Urs Personal Moment - Fire of Anger as Teaching

Source: C15 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

★ Urs shared a real-time personal experience of fire — rare transparency, deliberately offered as teaching:

"I had the good fortune today to be visited by this fire. I, by accident, opened a message from my work, and immediately I could feel the fire rising in me. Fire that makes you alert, makes your mind very present — but also sets the stage to be destructive, to be in this fire as a form of anger."

"And when it happened, I wasn't so thankful yet. But I could really feel how my body was heated up. And that was so amazing — that a simple word can spark the fire in you."

"Maybe you have experienced similar things during these days — that when we immerse in one of these elements, they come to visit. And when they visit, I hope we can acknowledge it and be with it, and when we've settled again, be with this atmosphere of this element."

TEACHING POINT

This transparency models precisely what is being taught: the elements are not abstract or distant. When we work with them, they arrive. Acknowledging the fire rather than suppressing it — and then settling into the element's full quality — is the practice itself.

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Take Everything Like Nectar

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

From Urs Qutbuddin's valediction at the end of the November weekend:

"I wish you a wonderful time with your practice. Be gentle, but focused, and explore with joy. Take everything like nectar that's given to you, everything you find."

Context: This instruction was given as students prepared to return to daily life after the intensive weekend of concentration practices. It suggests an attitude of receptivity and gratitude toward all experiences encountered in spiritual practice and ordinary life.

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Five Poems from the Gayan/Vadan - Munajat

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Five complete poems read by Urs from Murshid's Gayan/Vadan as munajat — the lover's address to the beloved — in the register of invocation, the air aspect of prayer:

POEM I — THOU POUREST WINE

Thou pourest wine into my empty cup.

Wherever we meet — on hills and dales,

on the tops of the high mountains,

in the thick forests, and in the barren deserts,

on the shores of the roaring sea,

and on the banks of the gentle river —

there arises in my heart the unearthly passion

and the heavenly joy.

POEM II — IN THE SWINGING OF THE BRANCHES

In the swinging of the branches,

in the flying of the birds,

and in the running of the water,

beloved, I see thy waving hand bidding me goodbye.

POEM III — IN THE COOLING OF THE WIND

In the cooling of the wind,

in the roaring of the sea,

and in the crashing of the thunder,

beloved, I see thee weep and I hear thy cry.

POEM IV — IN THE PROMISE OF THE DAWN

In the promise of the dawn,

in the breaking of the morn,

in the smiles of the rose,

beloved, I see thy joy at my homecoming.

Every step in thy path draws me nearer to thee.

Every breath in thy thought exhilarates my spirit.

Every glimpse of thy smile is inspiring to my soul.

Every tear in thy love, beloved, exalts my being.

POEM V — EVERY FORM I SEE · WHEREVER I ROAM

Every form I see is thine own form, my Lord.

And every sound I hear is thine own voice.

In the perfume of flowers, I perceive the fragrance of thy spirit.

In every word spoken to me, I hear thy voice, my Lord.

All that touches me is thine own touch.

In everything I taste, I enjoy the savour of thy delicious spirit.

In every place, I feel thy presence, beloved.

In every word that falls on my ears, I hear thy message.

Everything that touches me thrills me with the joy of thy kiss.

Wherever I roam, I meet thee.

Wherever I reach, I find thee, my Lord.

Wherever I look, I see thy glorious vision.

Whatever I touch, I touch thy beloved hand.

Whosoever I see, I see thee in his soul.

Whoever ought gives to me, I take it from thee.

To whomsoever I give, I humbly offer it to thee, Lord.

Whoever comes to me, it is thou who comest.

On whomsoever I call, I call on thee.

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Key Quotes from Urs - Session C17

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ON SULUK COMMUNITY SUPPORT

“There is a reason why we don't travel alone.”

“Let us support each other in our prayers. When we are in our prayers, let's think of each other. And even though we might not know each and every situation our fellow travelers are in — just be in the presence of this group and wish everyone well.”

ON THE LIVING WORLD

"We are not surrounded by dead matter, but we are within an immense living body. And the elements on the outside are like our siblings, our brothers and sisters."

ON CRYSTALLINE SPIRIT

"You could say the elements, our bodies, and our surrounding are crystalline spirit — spirit that became form. And spirit being the abstraction of matter."

ON THE GOD-IDEAL

"It's like the north star. It's our picture of perfection — one that we hold now, and that we let go when this rung of the ladder has helped us to rise further."

ON MUSIC AS TEACHING

"I just would like to point out that the music which might seem like an introduction to the teaching is actually very much at the core of the teaching itself."

ON INDIVIDUAL PRAYER VOICES

"Every person, every worshipper has their voice, has their way of expression, and one cannot be for another. Each uses the words that come naturally to themselves."

DIVINE VOICE ON BURNING (FROM THE MOSES STORY)

"I don't look at the words. I look at what is in the heart. I want to see burning. Burning is what I hear."

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Four Murshid Passages - The Soul's Journey to Union

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Four complete passages read by Urs from Murshid — the soul's journey from prostration before God to calling God 'myself.'

PASSAGE I — FROM LORD TO MYSELF

When thou didst sit upon thy throne with a crown upon thy head,

I did prostrate myself upon the ground and call thee my Lord.

When thou didst stretch out thy hands in blessing over me,

I knelt and called thee my master.

When thou didst raise me from the ground, holding me with thine arms,

I drew closer to thee and called thee my beloved.

But when thy caressing hands held my head next to thy glowing heart

and thou didst kiss me, I smiled and called thee myself.

PASSAGE II — WHY DID I NOT RECOGNIZE THEE?

Why did I not recognize thee when first I opened my eyes on the earth?

Why did I not respond to thee when I heard thy enchanting voice?

Why did I not feel thy gentle hand when thou didst caress my face?

Why did I not cling to thee, beloved, when thou lovingly didst kiss my lips?

When I began to look for thee, in the twinkling of an eye, thou didst disappear.

When I started in thy pursuit, thou didst move away from me still farther.

When I called thee aloud in my distress, thou didst not hear my soul's bitter cry.

Cross-legged I sat in silence, then alone I heard thy call.

PASSAGE III — THE SEARCH (MINARET, GANGES, KA'ABA)

I searched but I could not find thee.

I called thee aloud standing on the minaret.

I rang the temple bell with the rising and setting of the sun.

I bathed in the Ganges in vain. I came back from the Ka'aba disappointed.

I looked for thee on the earth. I searched for thee in the heaven, my beloved,

but at last have found thee hidden as a pearl in the shell of my heart.

PASSAGE IV — I MUST CALL THEE MYSELF

Do I call thee my soul, but thou art my spirit.

Can I call thee my life, but thou livest forever.

May I call thee my beloved, but thou art love itself.

Then what must I call thee? I must call thee myself.

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Part II · Chapter 10

DEEP STUDY & ARABIC TERMS

The Language of the Path

Arabic terms, elemental vocabulary, and deeper learnings from Urs's sessions. Includes Sufi terminology related to the elements, the body, and the murshid-murid relationship.

14 Entries · Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg

Eshk - Love and Longing with Earth

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Term: Eshk (عشق)

Context: Earth communion practice

Definition: In Sufi usage, a consuming, longing love. Here Urs applies it not to divine-human love but to the primal bond between embodied being and the Earth that holds it.

USAGE IN TEACHING

"This communion of the Earth and our bodies is also described as eshk — a form of love and longing."

"Be aware of this eshk when you take your next step. Your next step might be like a kiss — your body kissing the Earth."

RELATED PRACTICE

The term was introduced in connection with the Earth element practice: developing conscious awareness and communion with Earth both as outer support and as the very substance of our embodied being.

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Shukr - Gratitude in Prayer

Source: C11 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Term: Shukr

Context: Five Aspects of Prayer - First Aspect

Definition: Gratitude, thankfulness - the first aspect of prayer as described by Murshid in his work on the universality of religious ideals.

TEACHING CONTEXT

"The first aspect is very close to Earth and what we've been experiencing — and that is gratitude. The aspect of gratitude."

TWO MODES DISTINGUISHED

Social gratitude — saying thank you, seeing the other, acknowledging what they've given

Cosmic gratitude — thankfulness for everything dispersed into existence: the air, the Earth, the warmth, the fruit

PRACTICE APPLICATION

"So this aspect of prayer is an invitation to turn our attention, our focus, our concentration on the things that deserve our gratitude."

Related Zikr: Ashukrillah - *"Thanks be to the One"*

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Uruj and Nuzul - Rising and Descending

Source: C12 · November 21, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Key Arabic terms from Murshid's teaching on breath:

Uruj (عروج) — rising; the in-breath and its inward, ascending movement

Nuzul (نزول) — descending; the out-breath and its outward, expressing movement

Eshk (عشق) — love and longing; used in C11 for Earth communion; echoed here

CONTEXT

"Inhaling is called 'uruj,' which means rising. Exhaling is called 'nuzul,' which means descending. And each has its particular part in the life of an individual." — Murshid

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Lataif and the Breath of Life - Reviving Subtle Centers

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

WATER QUALITY AND THE BREATH OF LIFE

"This water quality is compared to the breath of life — which has, like the water, the ability through its flow to wash through blockades in our subtle centers, in the Lataif, cleaning them, freeing them from residues."

THE BARREN LAND AND THE RAIN

"When we look out and see dry land that hasn't seen water for a while — maybe for a month — no life seems to be with it. And the day the clouds are slowly shifted over this land and the rain pours down, it doesn't take long until this life is seen. The first offshoots of green are seen, miraculously — held by the earth and revivified by water."

REVIVING DORMANT SUBTLE CENTERS

"And this is the same with our breath. When there are parts in us, our subtle centers, that seem to be barren — with the breath of life, they start greening again."

"And maybe this is something that's happening to us in these days: parts in us that didn't get much attention, that were dormant, held by the earth element — show their shoots and slowly become a plant again."

CONNECTION TO KHWAJA KHIDR

"There are those marvelous beings that can create greenery around them — like Khwaja Khidr, who, it is said, when he stepped the earth, the plant started to grow at that point."

CONTEXT

This teaching connects the water elemental breath practice to the activation and cleansing of the Lataif (subtle centers), showing how breath work can revive dormant aspects of our spiritual being.

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Rahman - The All-Compassionate as Healing Quality

Source: C13 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

"The quality of Rahman is always there, unconditionally. The quality of Rahman also is living in the human heart — in our ability to forgive and let go and to love. It's a healing aspect."

CONTEXT

This teaching on Rahman was given in connection with the practice of repentance and working with regret, showing how the divine quality of compassion exists both as an attribute of God and as a potential within the human heart.

The practice suggested bringing unresolved regret *"before the one, the all-compassionate: 'Let it be held in his loving compassion.'"*

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Bodhisattva

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Definition: In Buddhist teaching, a being on the path to enlightenment who delays full liberation to serve the liberation of all beings.

Context from Teaching: Encountered in Stage 3 of the three-stage being visualization in its pre-earthly, non-physical form.

Related Terms: Buddha, enlightenment, non-physical beings

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Iblis (إبليس)

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Definition: Satan; the Adversary in Islamic theology; a jinn who refused to bow to Adam and was cast out.

Context from Teaching: In the story of the pious man, Iblis acts paradoxically to prevent the pure tear — showing that even the adversary recognizes the power of sincere repentance.

Related Terms: Jinn, Satan

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Jataka Tales

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Definition: A collection of Buddhist teaching stories recounting the Buddha's previous lives and moral lessons.

Context from Teaching: The source of 'The Master's Test' story featuring the student who says *"Myself is watching"* - illustrating the inner witness that observes all actions.

Related Terms: Buddhist teachings, teaching stories

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Jinn (جن)

Source: C14 · November 22, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Definition: Non-human, non-angelic beings in Islamic cosmology; created from smokeless fire; occupy a spectrum from fallen (like Iblis) to illuminated.

Context from Teaching: Encountered in Stage 3 of the three-stage visualization as a non-physical being that has never existed on the physical plane.

Related Terms: Iblis, angel, non-physical beings

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Fana-fi-Sheikh and Related Terms

Source: C16 · November 23, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Fana-fi-Sheikh (فناء في الشيخ) — annihilation in the teacher; the Sufi practice of effacing the personal self in the presence of one's murshid, thereby receiving the qualities and light of the entire lineage (Silsila) through that living embodiment

Silsila (سلسلة) — the chain of transmission; the unbroken lineage of teachers through which the light and baraka (blessing) of the tradition is passed from heart to heart, generation to generation

Fana (فناء) — annihilation; the dissolving of the individual self. In Fana-fi-Sheikh, it is specifically the self dissolved into the murshid's being, as a preparatory stage before Fana-fillah (annihilation in God)

Baba Farid Ganj-e-Shakar (1173–1266) — one of the great saints of the Chishti order; disciple of Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki; known as 'the treasury of sugar'; his shrine in Pakpattan, Pakistan, remains a major site of pilgrimage

Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki — Chishti master, disciple of Moinuddin Chishti (Khwaja Gharib Nawaz); murshid of Baba Farid; one of the principal figures of the Chishti order's establishment in the Indian subcontinent

Khatum — the closing prayer of the Inayatiyya; 'O Thou who art the perfection of love, harmony and beauty'; used to seal gatherings and retreat sessions

Inter esse (Latin) — to be between; to be in the midst of; the etymological root of 'interest'; teaching point: genuine interest is not casual preference but a state of total immersion where self and object merge

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Arabic and Sufi Terms - Session C17

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

RUH AL-AZAM (روح الأعظم)

The Great Spirit - The first creation; the universal life in which all individual souls exist as expressions. Not the absolute one (Allah), but the primordial divine breath that is the ground of creation.

MUNAJAT (مناجات)

Intimate address to the divine - The lover's cry in the night or wilderness; a form of prayer that is pure longing without petition. Found in classical maqam and raga as a musical register of nearness.

MAQAM (مقام)

Station - A spiritual rank or degree of attainment on the path. In the story of the shepherd, he reaches a higher maqam through the very disturbance Moses caused. Also the term for the musical modes of Arab and Persian classical music.

HAIYA (حيا)

Supplication - The aspect of prayer as asking for support for one's aims; driven longing for specific fulfillment. Mapped to the Fire element. Distinguished from Invocation (Air) which seeks only nearness.

SHUKR (شكر)

Gratitude - The first and most grounded aspect of prayer, mapped to the Earth element.

ISTIGHFAR / TAWBA (استغفار / توبة)

Forgiveness/Repentance - The cleansing aspect of prayer, mapped to the Water element. Tawba literally means *"turning back"* to God.

GOD-IDEAL

Murshid's term for the personalized conception of God one holds at a given stage of the path. Like the north star: not the destination itself, but the directional image that orients the journey. Meant to be released as one rises.

GAYAN VADAN NIRTAN

The three principal volumes of Murshid Hazrat Inayat Khan's mystical writings: **Gayan** (sayings), **Vadan** (deeper thoughts and meditations), **Nirtan** (the dance, devotional poetry). The poems in this session are drawn from these.

SALAMANDER

In medieval and alchemical tradition, a creature believed to live within fire unharmed and even able to quench it. A symbol of the purified soul that passes through the fire of transformation without being consumed.

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Elemental Philosophy - Crystalline Spirit and Ruh al-Azam

Source: C17 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Urs offered the most comprehensive philosophical framing of the elemental work, drawing together the full arc of understanding:

THE ELEMENTS AS LIVING SIBLINGS

"Stepping into the livingness of the world — we are not surrounded by dead matter, but we are within an immense living body. And the elements on the outside are like our siblings, our brothers and sisters."

"We are not even separated from the elements on the outside, as we ourselves are made from these elements. In our flesh and bones, the fluids, blood, the digestive fire, the air filling our lungs with every breath, running through the whole body."

ELEMENTS IN CHARACTER, SPIRIT, AND SOUL

In character and temperament: persistence like earth; the moved and open heart like water; inspiration and will like fire

In the spirit: traceable in dreams, as a language of the spirit

In the soul: everything reflected there ultimately

CRYSTALLINE SPIRIT

"You could say the elements, our bodies, and our surrounding are crystalline spirit — spirit that became form. And spirit being the abstraction of matter."

THE PENDULUM OF AWARENESS

"In our awareness of these dimensions, it's sometimes like a pendulum — sometimes more leaning to the material world, the palpable, the solid, the concrete. And sometimes we're more aware of spirit, the subtle, the very fine. And when you're doing the elemental breath, you might one day be closer to one aspect than to the other. And sometimes it's all there, present at once."

RUH AL-AZAM — THE GREAT SPIRIT

"This brings us closer to the awareness of being a part of the Ruh al-Azam, the great spirit, the great body. The great spirit being the first created thing — not the one beyond everything and all, but this first creation in which we live."

CLEANSING AND RENEWAL THROUGH THE ELEMENTS

"There is this wonderful quality of the elements: of cleansing, of washing us, of taking from us everything that is burdening, that is heavy, that's not used anymore — everything we can let go of. And the elements giving us back new energy, new magnetism, filling us with life again. A renewal of every aspect of us."

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New Terms from Concentration Session

Source: C18 · December 13, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

Cupid position — The archer's cross-legged seat used in Zikr; right foot tucked behind the left knee, the tendon behind the kneecap representing the bow's string

Position of Sages (Full Lotus / Padmasana) — Both feet placed on opposite thighs, soles facing upward; powerful but demanding posture for practice

Luminous glance — Murshid's teaching that the eye does not only receive light but sheds it; the glance as a beam of inner light cast outward into the world

Still-point — The moment between the exhale completing and the inhale beginning, where the body's natural magnetism is most palpable

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Glossary - New Terms from Session

Source: C19 · December 14, 2025 · Urs Qutbuddin

ETHER / AKASH (आकाश) / ASMAN (آسمان)

The fifth element; the quintessence; sky in Sanskrit and Persian respectively; the primordial space from which all elements emerge and into which all dissolve; no color, no direction, no form — and yet all colors, all directions, all forms in potential

KHAMUSH (خاموش)

Silence; the Persian word Rumi uses to end many poems when language reaches its limit; the fifth aspect of prayer, beyond all words

ISHQ (عشق)

Love; the same word as eshk; used here in the fire context as consuming divine love that burns everything except the beloved. The word carries both the gentle longing of earth-eshk (C11) and the consuming fire of divine union.

MINARET

The tower of a mosque from which the call to prayer (adhan) is given; in the third passage, Murshid searched for the beloved by calling from the minaret — the highest external point — and found the beloved only within, in the heart

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PART III

PERSONAL TRANSMISSIONS BY GUIDE MANSUR

Outside the Classroom · Personal Guidance for Kabir

Guide Mansur is Kabir's personal guide in the Inayatiyya tradition. His teachings — through monthly sessions, personal transmissions, and prescribed practices — form the most intimate layer of the Concentration year. Pod Mentor: Farzana.

Monthly sessions throughout 2025–2026

35 Teachings · 7 Chapters

Part III · Chapter 1

PRAYERS & INVOCATIONS

The Sacred Words That Open the Way

Prayers and invocations as taught through Guide Mansur's personal transmissions — the most intimate layer of practice, given directly for Kabir's path.

2 Entries · Guide Mansur

Khatum — The Closing Prayer

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

"Well Thou who art the perfection of love, harmony and beauty, sovereign of heaven and earth. Open our hearts that we may hear Thy voice, which constantly comes from within. Disclose to us Thy divine light which is hidden in our souls, that we may know and understand life better. Most merciful and compassionate God, give us Thy great goodness. Teach us Thy loving forgiveness, raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us. Send us the peace of Thy divine spirit, and unite us all in Thy perfect being. Om."

USAGE

- Closing prayer for practice sessions
- Part of regular daily practice routine

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The Invocation

When reciting the invocation, bring forth the intention and feeling of **longing** — of union with the One.

It is this inner state that connects the heart to the One. Without it, the invocation becomes only a repetition of words.

> *The invocation is not the words — it is the state from which the words arise.*

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Part III · Chapter 2

BREATH PRACTICES

The Bridge Between Worlds

Breath practices prescribed by Guide Mansur — including Qasab (the reed breath), Hosh dar Dam, and the Five Elemental Purification Breaths in their specific form for Kabir's daily practice.

5 Entries · Guide Mansur

Elemental Breaths — Observed Benefits and Practice

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

KABIR'S TESTIMONY (7 ROUNDS DAILY)

- **Without practice:** brain fog, fatigue, inability to think, wanting to sleep
- **With practice:** energy elevated, channels clear, clarity of thought restored

"It's like medicine. I can see the change." — Kabir

MANSUR'S FRAMEWORK

- **Elemental Breaths** = purification of the body
- **Qasab** = purification of the mind
- Both clear the channels of breath (Nadis — 70,000 in yoga tradition)
- Can do 1 round even in the car before a difficult meeting

PRACTICE GUIDELINES

- 7 rounds each element
- Maximum 10 rounds (Murshid's guidance)
- Inhale through mouth, exhale through nose

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Five Elemental Purification Breaths

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

Mansur gave complete guidance on each elemental breath — direction, visualization, and spiritual principle.

EARTH BREATH

Principle: *"Stones are bones and flesh is clay."* — Principle of solidity.

Direction: Spreading — toward you from every direction.

Practice:

- **Inhale:** Earth spreading toward you; imagine being a mountain buried from waist down
- **Exhale:** Allow gravity (the earth's embrace) to purify the earth element

WATER BREATH

Principle: Pir Vilayat: *"This element is very close to the Holy Spirit."*

Direction: Down.

Practice:

- **Visualization:** Waterfall starting just above the head — high volume, slow-moving water rinsing over and through you

FIRE BREATH

Principle: Pir Vilayat: *"You must burn very hot."*

Direction: Upward

Breathing: Inhale through mouth, exhale through nose

Practice:

- **Visualization:** Bed of glowing coals in solar plexus/belly
- **Inhale:** Like a bellows making coals bright
- **Exhale:** As exhaling light. Convection currents rising above the fire

AIR BREATH

Principle: Atoms are 99.999...% open space — allow the wind to pass through you.

Direction: Every which way / zigzag

Breathing: In mouth, out mouth

Practice:

- **Visualization:** Swirling wind washing through you, cleansing like wind through trees

ETHER BREATH

Principle: The all-pervading life in space — omnidirectional, pervading presence.

Practice:

- Feel the shimmering energy in the body
- *"Through the rays of the sun, through the waves of the air, through the all-pervading life in space, purify and revivify us… Heal our bodies, hearts and souls."* — Prayer of Niyaz

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Daily practice — ideally outside or before an open window. 5 breaths per element. Full, even, natural, unforced.

Element · Pattern · Direction · Color · Qualities
Earth · In nose · Out nose · Horizontal, spreading · Gold wheat · Patience, quiet strength
Water · In nose · Out mouth · Descending · Sea green · Generosity, creativity
Fire · In mouth · Out nose · Rising · Red · Ardor, passion, truth
Air · In mouth · Out mouth · Zigzag · Sky blue · Peace
Ether · In+out both simultaneously · Within · Ultra-fine grey mist · Letting go

Add associated concentrations (direction, color, quality) one at a time — only when they are not a distracting complication.

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Hosh dar Dam — Breath Awareness

Hosh dar dam — "Consciousness on the breath."

Make the breath your home base. Go there whenever your thinking has no meaningful occupation.

This is not a formal sitting practice but a **life-practice** — the breath as continuous anchor of awareness throughout the day.

> *Your life becomes your practice.*

One of the foundational principles of the Chishti path: the breath as the bridge between the outer and inner life.

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Purification Breath Health Testimony

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

PIR VILAYAT'S TEACHING

Pir Vilayat: *"If you do the purification breaths every day, you'll never get seriously ill."*

MANSUR'S PERSONAL TESTIMONY

25 years of daily practice

Sick only twice in 25 years:

1. Once under extreme life stress (selling home, business, divorce)
2. Once briefly with COVID in 2022

All other time: completely well.

This stands as powerful testimony to the healing power of consistent daily purification breath practice.

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Qasab — The Reed Breath

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

Hand position: Right middle finger against right nostril, right thumb under chin. Left hand covers right hand, left thumb to close left nostril. Breath is light but deep, without strain.

SEQUENCE (1 ROUND — REPEAT 1, 3, 5, OR 7 TIMES)

1. Close right nostril → inhale and exhale through left
2. Close left nostril → inhale and exhale through right
3. Close right; inhale left → close left; exhale right
4. Close left; inhale right → close right; exhale left
5. Close right; inhale left → exhale through mouth
6. Close left; inhale right → exhale through mouth
7. Close right; inhale mouth → exhale through left
8. Close left; inhale mouth → exhale through right
9. Lower hands

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Draw as deep a breath as you can without straining.

At the top of inhale:

- Close nostrils
- Keep chest expanded (do not close the glottis)
- Curl tongue along roof of mouth
- Turn eyeballs upward
- Hold for 2× the count of the inhale
- Think HU — or Allah on inhale, Hu on exhale

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Part III · Chapter 3

CONCENTRATION, VISUALIZATION & MEDITATION

Training the Sovereign Attention

Concentration and meditation practices from Guide Mansur — including the Sky of Mind practice, Muraqabah (watchfulness of thought), and the Ideal Guru Contemplation.

3 Entries · Guide Mansur

Ideal Guru Contemplation

Hold the archetype of the **Ideal Guru** using the Sufi ideal that emerged from your own experience.

Remember the being of Pir Zia, as well as the yogi who blessed you long ago.

Such beings manifest and radiate the One according to their revelation.

> *"It can't be taught, but it can be caught." — Mansur*

This beingness is contagious. The contemplation is not intellectual — it is an absorption into the quality of presence that such a being radiates.

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Muraqabah — Watchfulness of Thought

Be watchful of your thoughts.

- When a negative thought arises, **pause**. Ask: where is this coming from?
- Gently release it.
- After letting it go, **REJOICE** — remind yourself such thoughts are not truly part of you.
- Begin mornings by acknowledging your place in this world, accepting that both good and bad exist.
- Return to your breath. Your life becomes your practice.

> *"Hosh dar dam" — Breath Awareness. Make the breath your home base.*
> *Go there whenever your thinking has no meaningful occupation.*

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Sky of Mind Practice

A core practice bridging Shamatha (calm abiding), Vipassana (insight), and Sufi contemplation.

STAGE 1 — WITNESSING

Identify with the Sky of Mind. Watch impressions inject, vibrate, fuse, shift, and scatter — just as clouds form and dissolve. Do not suppress. Do not fully identify. Watch passively.

STAGE 2 — DARK CLOUDS

When clouds are so dense that no clarity remains — a thousand proliferating shapes, endlessly whirling. Recognize this state without judgment.

STAGE 3 — REMEMBERING THE SUN

This is precisely the moment to remember the light. Besides the clouds, there is the sun. **The soul is the sun of the sky of the mind.** Visualize the inner sun dawning, scattering the clouds, bathing the whole sky in warm glow.

STAGE 4 — LUMINOUS CLOUDS

Clouds may remain — but now of a higher order. Wisps of ice crystal that reflect and refract the soul's light in rainbow hues. The finer dimension of thought is not a veil but an illuminated medium. Being becomes luminous thought.

STAGE 5 — RADIATION

Open your eyes. Allow the sun of the sky of your mind to shine out through your glance and radiate upon all you see. See in everyone around you the sun of a soul shining out.

ADDITIONAL TEACHINGS

Notice and observe the arising of thought — simple identification of what the mind is doing.

When thoughts carry you away — notice that, too. Notice and rejoice. That is a victory.

If self-criticism arises, notice it and return to the breath.

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Part III · Chapter 4

FIKR, ZIKR & WAZIFA

The Practices of Remembrance

Fikr practices prescribed by Guide Mansur in a specific progression: beginning with Ya Sabur Ya Wahhab, moving to Ya Fazl Ya Fattah, the preparatory Subuhun Quddusun, and the advanced Ayat al-Qutb.

9 Entries · Guide Mansur

Ayat al-Qutb — Advanced Fikr (Preliminary Version)

This is the preliminary version of Ayat al-Qutb shared by Mansur on March 6, 2026.

Preparatory: Begin with Subuhun-Quddusun fikr before entering Ayat al-Qutb.

REFERENCES

- Gatha II, Pasi Anfas — the first paper in Gatha II is on Fikr
- Link: wahiduddin.net/mv2/XIII/XIII_11.htm
- PDF reference: Ayat al-Qutb (shared by Mansur, March 6, 2026)

Received: March 6, 2026.

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Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah — Blessing Invocation

This practice invokes the great blessing of divine compassion. It can be sung or simply recited.

Word	Meaning
Fazl	Blessing
Mullah	Great
Rahim Allah	Allah's Compassion

Use Mansur's audio recording *Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah.m4a* to receive the melody directly from Mansur.

> *Note: Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah is also **Mansur's own spiritual name** — Great Blessing of Allah's Compassion.*

Received: January 12, 2026.

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Fazl Mullah Rahimullah — Protection and Nourishment

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

USAGE

Kabir used this practice throughout a noisy Indian masala movie — protecting the heart, not getting distracted, treating himself while the family watched.

MANSUR'S TEACHING

"Perfect choice. That practice is all about just embracing yourself. Great blessing of divine mercy — you're bathing yourself in wonderful energy." — Mansur

APPLICATION

- Use in worldly/noisy situations
- Protection for the heart
- Divine mercy and nourishment
- Self-care in challenging environments

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Fikr — Subuhun / Quddusun

Stage: Preparatory — precedes the current leading practice

Fikr: Inhale Subuhun → Exhale Quddusun. Begin with 33 repetitions.

THE NAMES

- **Subuhun** — God as the Glorified One, the One who is Praised.
- **Quddusun** — God as the most Holy, Sacred One. God is infinite Sacredness; the sacredness that saturates the universe enfolds your being.

PIR ZIA'S TEACHING

Return to one's angelic awareness, turned toward God. This is the purification of consciousness from the profanity of everyday life.

Use Mansur's audio recording *Subuhun Quddusun.m4a* to find the melody and tone.

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Fikr — Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah

Stage: Current Leading Practice (as of February 2026)

Fikr: Inhale Fazl → Exhale Fattah

THE NAMES

- **Fazl** (Al-Fazl) — Blessing, illumination. Murshid called this *"the word of blessing."* The attunement you carry inward.
- **Fattah** (Al-Fattah) — The Opener, the Revealer of paths. Carries cosmic attunement into action in the world.

This practice carries your developing attunement to Fazl out into active engagement with the world.

Built on the foundation of all preceding practices:

Sabur/Wahhab (patience/blessing) → Subuhun/Quddusun (purification) → Fazl Mullah (devotion) → **Fazl/Fattah (action)**

Received: February 11, 2026.

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Fikr — Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o

Stage: First / Foundation Practice

Vocal: Ya Sabur-o — Ya Wahhab-o (11 or 33× daily, or as needed)

Fikr: Inhale Sabur-o → Exhale Wahhab-o

THE NAMES

- **Sabur** (As-Sabur) — The Patient One. Meeting life in a friendly way each morning. Open to life as it is, at ease with what it brings.
- **Wahhab** (Al-Wahhab) — The Supreme Bestower. The freely abundant flow of blessings, creativity, innovation, new inspiration, and resilience.

> *"Sabur is meeting life in a friendly way each morning. Wahhab is the freely abundant flow of blessings and life: full of creativity, innovation, new inspiration, and resilience." — Pir Zia Inayat Khan, 2021*

Recite 11×, 33×, 99×, or 101×. What matters most is dwelling deeply in the meaning, allowing the Divine Names to permeate your being.

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Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu — New Evening Practice

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

ARABIC

Subuhun — Quddusun — Rabbana (wa Rabbul Malaika war-Ruh)

MEANING

- **Subuhun** = utterly pure, utterly transcendent
- **Quddusun** = the Holy One
- **Rabbana** = our Lord

INSTRUCTIONS

- Recite before sleep — 33 repetitions (sweet spot; 11 also fine)
- David Lyot: *"Don't do too many — it becomes vain repetition"*
- Take the energy into sleep; let it work through the night (winding the clock)

MANSUR'S DESCRIPTION

"A really, deeply, powerfully, wonderfully intoxicating practice that infuses you with beautiful energy." — Mansur

PURPOSE

- Evening anchor practice
- Infuses beautiful energy
- Works through the night
- Preparation for sleep

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Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah — Breath Fikr Practice

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS

- **Inhale:** Fazl (no *"Ya"* in the silent breath version)
- **Exhale:** Fattah (no *"Ya"*)
- Use *"Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah"* only when reciting aloud

KABIR'S BREAKTHROUGH VISUALIZATION

- **Fazl** = knocking on the doors of the heart (inhale)
- **Fattah** = the door opening (exhale)

MANSUR'S TEACHING ON FIKR MOMENTUM

- **Fazl** = blessing / *"word of illumination"* (Murshid's term — deeper than blessing)
- **Fattah** = opener; releasing the blessing outward into the world

"When you pause — when all your thinking stops — the Fikr just starts up. Because you have planted it there." — Mansur

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Ya Saburu, Ya Wahabu — First Practice Revisited

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

MEANINGS

- **Saburu** = patience
- **Wahabu** = generosity / the outflowing of divine qualities — *“slow motion Fattah”*

PRONUNCIATION

Bawa's pronunciation: Ya Saburu, ya Wahabu (Wahabu always ends in *“u”*)

KABIR'S TESTIMONY

This was the very first practice given — it stopped all internal arguments: *“Have I lost the train? Should I do this? What if I miss something?”* Now: no urgency, no impatience, no internal struggles.

"There's peace in that. A lot of peace." — Mansur

EFFECTS

- Eliminates internal arguments
- Brings peace
- Removes urgency and impatience
- Stops internal struggles

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Part III · Chapter 5

TEACHINGS & WISDOM

The Living Transmission

Personal guidance, counsel, and wisdom from Guide Mansur — the most intimate teachings, given outside the classroom for Kabir's individual journey on the path.

10 Entries · Guide Mansur

Daily Practice Sequence

Mansur's guidance: hold a wholesome discipline while balancing personal practice with self-compassion. This is a marathon, not a sprint.

Time	Practice	Notes
Morning	Five Elemental Purification Breaths	Outside or open window
Morning	Invocation	With longing and inner state of union
Morning/Daily	Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o Fikr	11 or 33×
Preparatory	Subuhun Quddusun Fikr	33× before leading practice
Leading	Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah Fikr	Current primary practice
Throughout	Watchfulness of Thought + Hosh dar dam	REJOICE at every noticing
As needed	Qasab (Cleansing the Chalice)	Refresher during the day
Dedicated	Sky of Mind Contemplation	Or as life-practice

> *"Not every practice we take up will land, and that's normal and ok. We needn't force anything, apart from the healthy discipline of doing the work." — Mansur*

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Divine Presence and Primordial Longing

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

THE SACRED HADITH

"I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. Therefore I created the world that I might be known." — Hadith Qudsi

THE TEACHING

The world was created from primeval longing released into manifestation. That longing IS the Divine Presence.

BUDDHIST PARALLEL

Mansur asked a Rinpoche (Dzogchen tradition) what corresponds to the Divine Presence in Buddhism. After reflection: **"Emptiness."**

Buddhist emptiness = Divine Presence = fundamental reality of the cosmos.

UNDERSTANDING

This teaching reveals that the Divine Presence is not separate from creation but is the very longing that brought creation into being. The longing to be known, to be experienced, to manifest - this is the Divine Presence itself, the driving force of all existence.

The correspondence with Buddhist emptiness points to the universal recognition across traditions of this fundamental reality that underlies all phenomena.

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Ego, Patience, and the Jihad with the False Self

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

THE REAL JIHAD

"The real jihad is the war with the false self." — Mansur

HOW TO MEET THE EGO'S PUSHBACK

1. **Recognize it**
2. **Accept it** — don't surrender, but acknowledge it as normal
3. **Notice without reacting**

"Rejoice when you notice — you are waking up." — Mansur

THE ROLE OF PATIENCE

Patience allows you to notice the ego's locomotive and not carelessly get on board and go wherever it goes.

BUILDING THE SPIRITUAL LOCOMOTIVE

"You're not just fighting the ego locomotive — you're building a locomotive that will swallow that one up." — Mansur

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First Guide Session - Five Elemental Breaths & Spiritual Guidance

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

First one-on-one Zoom session between Kabir and his guide Mansur. This session covered the Five Elemental Purification Breaths in full detail, explored Kabir's spontaneous insight about light as the substrate of the five elements, touched on the Divine Presence and its Buddhist parallel, and provided personal spiritual guidance around patience, maintaining center in the world, and daily practice rhythm.

KEY TOPICS COVERED

- Five Elemental Purification Breaths (complete instructions)
- Purification Breath health testimony

- Kabir's insight on light as building block of elements
- The Divine Presence and longing
- Ya Saburu - practice of patience
- Maintaining center in the world
- Breath as anchor

PRACTICES ACTIVATED

- **Ya Saburu** - First practice given (patience)
- **Elemental/Purification Breaths** - Full 5-element sequence
- **Sky of Mind** - Supports returning to center in the world
- **Daily Invocation** - Fresh meaning each time
- **Breath Awareness in World** - *"Your breath is your anchor"*

KEY GUIDANCE POINTS

- *"You actuate and then you allow"* - approach to spiritual practice
- Every daily practice is a mini-retreat - adjustments accumulate invisibly
- It's okay to pause in conversations - you don't have to keep up
- Think of breath as your big brother - always there, unfailingly supporting

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Guide Session — December 12, 2025

Mansur & Kabir | Journey with the Guide

Summarized: 2026-03-11

SESSION OVERVIEW

First one-on-one Zoom session between Kabir (Ramesh) and his guide Mansur following Kabir's entry into the Suluk Global 2025–2027 program. This session covered the Five Elemental Purification Breaths in deep detail, explored Kabir's spontaneous insight about light as the substrate of the elements, touched on the nature of the Divine Presence, and provided personal spiritual guidance around patience, maintaining center in the world, and the daily practice rhythm.

1. FIVE ELEMENTAL PURIFICATION BREATHS — FULL INSTRUCTIONS

Mansur gave detailed guidance on each of the five elemental breaths, including the direction, visualization, and the underlying spiritual principle.

Earth Breath

- **Principle:** *"Stones are bones and flesh is clay."* Principle of solidity.
- **Direction:** Spreading — outward in all directions, toward you.
- **Visualization:** Imagine yourself as a mountain buried from the waist down; earth spreading toward you from every direction on the inhale.
- **Exhale:** Allow gravity (the earth's embrace of us) to purify the earth element.

Water Breath

- **Principle:** Pir Vilayat: this element is very close to the Holy Spirit.
- **Direction:** Down.
- **Visualization:** A waterfall starting right above the head — high volume, slow-moving water pouring over and rinsing through you, like a smooth river.
- **Note:** Mansur noted this visualization resonates especially because of Kabir's own affinity with water in meditation.

Fire Breath

- **Principle:** Pir Vilayat: *"You must burn very hot."*
- **Direction:** Upward.
- **Breathing:** Inhale through the mouth, exhale through the nose.
- **Visualization:** A bed of glowing coals in the solar plexus/belly. Inhale like bellows into the coals — making them bright. Exhale as exhaling light. Convection currents rising above a fire can be included.
- **Experience:** Breathing in fire, exhaling light.

Air Breath

- **Principle:** We are 99.999...% open space at the atomic level.
- **Direction:** Every which way / zigzag.
- **Breathing:** In through the mouth, out through the mouth.
- **Visualization:** Swirling wind washing over and through you. Wind blowing through trees, cleansing all the dust — the body being cleansed by wind passing through it.

Ether Breath

- **Principle:** The all-pervading life in space.
- **Direction:** No fixed direction — omnidirectional, pervading presence.
- **Visualization:** Subtle; feel the shimmering energy in the body. The line from the Prayer of Niyaz applies: *"Through the all-pervading life in space."*
- **Connection:** Divine Presence / Buddhist *"Emptiness"* (see section 3).

Prayer of Niyaz (closing the Elemental Breaths)

> **"Beloved Lord, Almighty God, through the rays of the sun, through the waves of the air, through the all-pervading life in space, purify and revivify us and we pray. Heal our bodies, hearts and souls."**

2. PURIFICATION BREATH — HEALTH BENEFITS

- Pir Vilayat's teaching: *"If you do the purification breaths every day, you'll never get seriously ill."*
- Mansur's personal testimony: 25 years of daily practice; sick only twice — once under extreme life stress (selling home, business, divorce) and once briefly with COVID in 2022.
- Encouragement to Kabir: Take up this practice. It reveals itself over time.

3. KABIR'S INSIGHT — LIGHT AS THE BUILDING BLOCK OF THE ELEMENTS

> *"Light is the building block of the five elements. The densest is earth. As it transitions — earth to water, water to fire, fire to air, air to ether — the building blocks that hold everything together is light (Nur). Creation is the transition from the most subtle (light) to the densest. Realization is the reverse — from the densest back to the light."*

Mansur's response:

- *"That's a very interesting pairing — sound and light. They go together."*
- *"You can contemplate radiance being resonant and sound being luminous."*
- At a certain level of depth, they are one thing.
- Both Buddhism and Sufism affirm: *"It's all light."* It doesn't mean it's not all sound also.
- *"We discover these things by doing what you're doing — contemplating, looking within, releasing yourself into that subtle world."*

4. THE DIVINE PRESENCE AND THE LONGING

Hadith Qudsi (Sufi tradition):

> **"I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. Therefore I created the world that I might be known."**

The world was created from primeval longing released into manifestation. That longing *is* the Divine Presence.

Buddhist parallel:

- Mansur asked a Rinpoche (Dzogchen tradition): *"What in Buddhism corresponds to the Divine Presence?"*
- Rinpoche's answer after reflection: **Emptiness**.

- Buddhist emptiness = the fundamental reality of the cosmos = Divine Presence (Sufi understanding).
- *"It's that longing that became the world."*

5. EGO AS CONSTRUCTED PATTERNS — THE AI BOT METAPHOR

Mansur offered a framing for the psychological self:

> *"We have fabricated a whole host of bots — emotional and mental creatures — each assigned the task of managing different situations and challenges in our life, based on our history, our trauma. Like AI bots."*

Kabir acknowledged childhood trauma. Mansur offered gentleness: include the patience of an older brother — *"It's okay. You got this."*

6. PATIENCE — YA SABURU — FIRST PRACTICE GIVEN

Kabir's challenge:

- At 50 years old: *"I was born in 1976. I don't have time to waste. I need to achieve, to get to my goal."*
- Internal urgency: not the right mindset.

Mansur's guidance:

- The path is not like a worldly task where you *"put your nose to the grindstone."*
- *"You actuate and then you allow."*
- Like winding a clock (Murshid's metaphor): every day the practices, every day a mini-retreat; adjustments in perspective accumulate invisibly over time.
- Ya Saburu = practice of patience — the very first practice given.

7. MAINTAINING CENTER IN THE WORLD — BREATH AS ANCHOR

Kabir's challenge: When going out (visiting a temple, family time) — losing the inner shield, the centeredness.

Mansur's guidance:

- **The breath is the key.** Even in conversation, keep breath awareness: inhaling, exhaling — the simplest thread back.
- Teaching from Shahabuddin (30 years ago, walking in downtown San Francisco): *"Your breath is your anchor."*
- Think of the breath as your big brother: always there, unfailingly supporting you.

Sky of Mind practice — application:

- Trains the ability to notice distraction and return to breath.

- In the world, when you feel your groundedness slipping: go to the breath. Pause. You don't have to keep up with fast talkers.

8. DAILY PRACTICE AS WINDING A CLOCK

Murshid's teaching on daily practice:

> **"Every day you do your practices. Every day the breathing exercises. It's like winding a clock — like a mini-retreat. There's some little shift happening each time, whether you recognize it or not. You're out in the world afterward, and everything's a little different."**

Kabir's confirmation: *"Each day is a new experience. New revelations every time I say the invocation — a different meaning each time."*

Mansur: *"That's what happens with a contemplative approach — a progressive unveiling of meanings and perceptions."*

9. KABIR'S WRITINGS — BOWL OF SAKI STYLE

- Kabir has been writing short pieces in the style of Bowl of Saki — approximately 70 writings.
- Shared with Pir Zia.
- Mansur expressed interest in receiving these writings.
- Mansur mentioned writing haiku himself as a spiritual practice.

PRACTICES ACTIVE AT THIS STAGE

Practice · Notes
Ya Saburu (Patience) · First practice given
Purification / Elemental Breaths · Full 5-element sequence
Sky of Mind · Supports center in the world
Daily Invocation · Fresh meaning each time
Breath Awareness in World · Breath as anchor (Shahabuddin)

KEY QUOTES

> **"Your breath is your anchor."* — Shahabuddin (through Mansur)*
>
> **"You actuate and then you allow."* — Mansur*
>
> **"I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. Therefore I created the world."* — Hadith Qudsi*
>
> **"You can contemplate radiance being resonant and sound being luminous."* — Mansur*
>
> **"Every day you do your practices. It's like winding a clock."* — Murshid (through Mansur)*
>
> **"It's okay. You got this. It's difficult, some of it's painful, but it's okay."* — Mansur*

PERSONAL GUIDANCE FOR KABIR

- Include the patience of the great being from your dream walking through the desert.
- Your determination and enthusiasm are a great help — add patience.
- Feel free to email any experiences, progress, puzzlement.
- Surgery note: Mansur had surgery that week — reconnect in January.

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Guide Session — Monthly ReBoot — March 2026

Mansur & Kabir | Journey with the Guide

Summarized: 2026-03-11

SESSION OVERVIEW

Monthly ReBoot check-in. Kabir has been through ~3 months of Suluk practice during an intensely busy work period that disrupted his practice schedule. Session covers: practice updates, Fikr experiences, elemental breath testimonial, Qasab with retention, the first practice Ya Saburu revisited, a new evening practice (Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu), and guidance on ego, patience, and sincerity.

Contemplation 1 module with Pir Zia begins March 27–29.

1. SULUK PROGRAM PROGRESS

- Concentration 1 & 2 — complete (Pir Zia)
- Two Urs classes — complete (Urs Qutbuddin)
- Iron Rules (40 Chivalric Rules) — completed
- **Contemplation 1 — begins March 27–28–29 with Pir Zia**
- Pir Zia's write-ups accompanying each Rule were especially valuable for expanded understanding

> *"I'm a huge fan of concentration — it's the most important thing. But contemplation is more mysterious. It develops as our understanding grows. A powerful and challenging way to explore ourselves and our world."* — Mansur

2. WORK-PRACTICE BALANCE CHALLENGE

- Work expanded significantly: new responsibilities, high creative demand, learning curve
- By 6–7 AM already exhausted; practice schedule disrupted
- Brain fog on heavy work days

Micro-practices during the month:

- Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah during coffee breaks and transitions
- Fazl Mullah Rahimullah at a noisy Indian movie (full session — see section 3)

Mansur's perspective:

- The ego is pushing back as Kabir devotes himself more to spiritual practice
- Normal consequence: *"Your false self is not fooled. It knows its days are numbered."*

3. YA FAZL, YA FATTAH — FIKR EXPERIENCE

Practice Instructions (Breath Fikr)

- **Inhale:** Fazl (no *"Ya"* in the silent breath version)
- **Exhale:** Fattah (no *"Ya"*)
- Only use *"Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah"* when reciting aloud

Kabir's Breakthrough Visualization

Fazl = knocking on the doors of the heart (inhale). Fattah = the door opening (exhale).

Mansur's Teaching on Fikr Momentum

- **Fazl** = blessing / *"word of illumination"* (Murshid's term — deeper than just blessing)
- **Fattah** = opener; releasing the blessing outward into the world
- *"What could be sweeter? You take in Fazl, then release it to the world with Fattah."*

> **"When you pause — when all your thinking stops — the Fikr just starts up. Because you have planted it there."* — Mansur*

4. FAZL MULLAH RAHIMULLAH — PROTECTION AND NOURISHMENT

Kabir used this practice throughout a noisy Indian masala movie — protecting the heart, not getting distracted, treating himself while the family watched.

> **"Perfect choice. That practice is all about just embracing yourself. Great blessing of divine mercy — you're bathing yourself in wonderful energy."* — Mansur*

5. ELEMENTAL BREATHS AND QASAB — OBSERVED BENEFITS

Kabir's testimony (7 rounds daily):

- Without practice: brain fog, fatigue, inability to think, wanting to sleep
- With practice: energy elevated, channels clear, clarity of thought restored
- *"It's like medicine. I can see the change."*

Mansur's framework:

- **Elemental Breaths** = purification of the body
- **Qasab** = purification of the mind
- Both clear the channels of breath (Nadis — 70,000 in yoga tradition)
- Can do 1 round even in the car before a difficult meeting

6. QASAB — BREATH RETENTION VERSION

Instructions

1. Close one nostril. Inhale fully (e.g. 4 beats)
2. Hold for 2× the inhale (e.g. 8 beats) — *"Eight beats on either side. Think of it as a circle."*
3. Exhale for the inhale count (e.g. 4 beats)
4. Repeat on other side

Kabir's full current sequence:

1. Elemental breaths (7 rounds each)
2. Simple alternating: in left/out right, in right/out left
3. Inhale through mouth, exhale through nose
4. Qasab with breath retention (4:8:4)

Caution: Do not force breath holding. Full breath, not excessive. Max 10 rounds (Murshid).

7. YA SABURU, YA WAHABU — FIRST PRACTICE REVISITED

Saburu = patience. **Wahabu** = generosity / outflowing of divine qualities — *"slow motion Fattah."*

Bawa's pronunciation: *Ya Saburu, ya Wahabu* (Wahabu always ends in *"u"*).

Kabir's testimony: This was the very first practice given — it stopped all internal arguments: *"Have I lost the train? Should I do this? What if I miss something?"* Now: no urgency, no impatience, no internal struggles.

> *"There's peace in that. A lot of peace."* — *Mansur*

8. NEW PRACTICE GIVEN — SUBUHUN QUDDUSUN RABBANU (EVENING PRACTICE)

Arabic: Subuhun — Quddusun — Rabbana *(wa Rabbul Malaika war-Ruh)*

Meaning:

- Subuhun = utterly pure, utterly transcendent
- Quddusun = the Holy One
- Rabbana = our Lord — *"Invocation of holiness"*

Instructions:

- Recite **before sleep** — 33 repetitions (sweet spot; 11 also fine)
- David Lyot: *"Don't do too many — it becomes vain repetition"*
- Take the energy into sleep; let it work through the night (winding the clock)

"A really, deeply, powerfully, wonderfully intoxicating practice that infuses you with beautiful energy." — Mansur*

9. EGO, PATIENCE, AND THE JIHAD WITH THE FALSE SELF

"The real jihad is the war with the false self." — Mansur*

How to meet the ego's pushback:

1. Recognize it
2. Accept it — don't surrender, but acknowledge it as normal
3. Notice without reacting

"Rejoice when you notice — you are waking up." — Mansur*

Patience allows you to notice the ego's locomotive and not carelessly get on board and go wherever it goes.

10. SINCERITY AND THE LONG PATH

"Sincerity is the most important quality." — Murshid (through Mansur)*

"Steady on. Steady on. Steady on." — Mansur's guide*

"You're not just fighting the ego locomotive — you're building a locomotive that will swallow that one up." — Mansur*

11. CLOSING PRAYER — KHATUM

"Well Thou who art the perfection of love, harmony and beauty, sovereign of heaven and earth. Open our hearts that we may hear Thy voice, which constantly comes from within. Disclose to us Thy divine light which is hidden in our souls, that we may know and understand life better. Most merciful and compassionate God, give us Thy great goodness. Teach us Thy loving forgiveness, raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us. Send us the peace of Thy divine spirit, and unite us all in Thy perfect being. Om."

PRACTICES ACTIVE AFTER THIS SESSION

Practice · Notes
Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah (breath fikr) · Inhale Fazl / exhale Fattah — silently
Fazl Mullah Rahimullah · Use in worldly/noisy situations
Ya Saburu, Ya Wahabu · Continue — first practice given
Elemental Breaths · 7 rounds; max 10
Qasab (standard) · Purification of the mind
Qasab (breath retention) · 4:8:4 ratio — do not force
Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu ✦ NEW · **33x before sleep — evening anchor**

Invocation (Toward the One) · Opening practice
Khatum · Closing prayer

KEY QUOTES

"Concentration is the most important thing. But contemplation is more mysterious — and as our understanding grows, it develops." — Mansur*

"When you pause, the Fikr just starts up. Because you have planted it there." — Mansur*

"The real jihad is the war with the false self." — Mansur*

"Rejoice when you notice — you're waking up." — Mansur*

"Steady on. Steady on." — Mansur's guide (through Mansur)*

"Sincerity. That's one of those qualities Murshid says is the most important." — Mansur*

"Subuhun — deeply, powerfully, wonderfully intoxicating." — Mansur*

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Monthly ReBoot Guide Session March 2026

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

Monthly ReBoot check-in. Kabir has been through ~3 months of Suluk practice during an intensely busy work period that disrupted his practice schedule. Session covers: practice updates, Fikr experiences, elemental breath testimonial, Qasab with retention, the first practice Ya Saburu revisited, a new evening practice (Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu), and guidance on ego, patience, and sincerity.

SULUK PROGRAM PROGRESS

- Concentration 1 & 2 — complete (Pir Zia)
- Two Urs classes — complete (Urs Qutbuddin)
- Iron Rules (40 Chivalric Rules) — completed
- Contemplation 1 — begins March 27–28–29 with Pir Zia

KEY SESSION ELEMENTS

- Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah — Fikr breakthrough experience
- Elemental breath testimonial and benefits
- Qasab with breath retention introduction
- Ya Saburu, Ya Wahabu revisited
- New evening practice: Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu
- Teachings on ego, patience, and sincerity

PRACTICES ACTIVE AFTER THIS SESSION

- Ya Fazl, Ya Fattah (breath fikr)
- Fazl Mullah Rahimullah
- Ya Saburu, Ya Wahabu
- Elemental Breaths (7 rounds; max 10)
- Qasab (standard and breath retention)
- Subuhun Quddusun Rabbanu (NEW - 33x before sleep)
- Invocation (Toward the One)
- Khatum

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Practices & Teachings — Consolidated

Mansur (John Rahm) → Kabir (Ramesh)

Inayatiyya Order · December 2025 – March 2026

> *"It can't be taught, but it can be caught." — Mansur*

CONTENTS

· Section
I · Foundational Orientation
II · Breathing Practices
III · Fikr — Divine Names on the Breath
IV · Sky of Mind
V · Daily Practice Sequence
VI · Sacred Relationship & Journey

I. FOUNDATIONAL ORIENTATION

1.1 — Invocation: The Inner State

When reciting the invocation, bring forth the intention and feeling of longing — of union with the One. Without this inner state, the invocation becomes only a repetition of words.

1.2 — Watchfulness of Thought (Muraqabah)

- Be watchful of thoughts. When a negative thought arises, pause — where is this coming from? Gently release it.
- After letting it go, **REJOICE** — such thoughts are not truly part of you.
- Begin mornings acknowledging your place in the world.
- Return to the breath. Your life becomes your practice.

> **Hosh dar dam — Breath Awareness. Make the breath your home base.**

1.3 — Ideal Guru Contemplation

Hold the archetype of the Ideal Guru — the being of Pir Zia, the yogi who blessed you. This beingness is contagious — it can be caught, not just taught.

II. BREATHING PRACTICES

2.1 — Five Elemental Purification Breaths

Daily, outside or open window. 5 breaths per element. Full, even, natural, unforced.

Element	Pattern	Direction	Color	Qualities
Earth	In nose · Out nose	Horizontal	Gold wheat	Patience, quiet strength
Water	In nose · Out mouth	Descending	Sea green	Generosity, creativity
Fire	In mouth · Out nose	Rising	Red	Ardor, passion, truth
Air	In mouth · Out mouth	Zigzag	Sky blue	Peace
Ether	In+out both simultaneously	Within	Ultra-fine grey mist	Letting go

2.2 — Qasab: Cleansing the Chalice (Preliminary)

Hand position: Right middle finger on right nostril, right thumb under chin. Left hand covers right, left thumb closes left nostril. Light but deep breath, no strain.

1. Close right → inhale/exhale left
2. Close left → inhale/exhale right
3. Close right; inhale left → close left; exhale right
4. Close left; inhale right → close right; exhale left
5. Close right; inhale left → exhale mouth
6. Close left; inhale right → exhale mouth
7. Close right; inhale mouth → exhale left
8. Close left; inhale mouth → exhale right
9. Lower hands

Repeat 1, 3, 5, or 7 rounds.

2.3 — Qasab: Standard Version

Deep inhale without strain. At top: close nostrils, chest expanded (no glottis closure), curl tongue on roof of mouth, eyeballs upward. Hold 2× inhale count thinking HU (or Allah inhale / Hu exhale).

Pattern: Inhale left × counts → hold 2× → exhale right (3×), then inhale right → exhale left (3×), then inhale both → exhale both (3×).

Begin with 3 of each. Increase gradually to 5, then 10. Never exceed 20. Take months. Never strain.

III. FIKR — DIVINE NAMES ON THE BREATH

Recitation is internal, on the breath. Drop *"Ya"* prefix in breath-based fikr.

Fikr Progression

Stage · Practice · Inhale · Exhale · Theme
First · Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o · Sabur-o · Wahhab-o · Foundation
Preparatory · Subuhun / Quddusun · Subuhun · Quddusun · Purification
Blessing · Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah · — · — · Devotion
Current · Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah · Fazl · Fattah · Action
Advanced · Ayat al-Qutb · — · — · Advanced

3.1 — Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o (First Practice)

- **Sabur** — The Patient One. Meeting life in a friendly way each morning.
- **Wahhab** — The Supreme Bestower. Freely abundant blessings, creativity, innovation, resilience.
- Vocal: 11 or 33×. Fikr: Inhale Sabur-o → Exhale Wahhab-o.

3.2 — Subuhun / Quddusun (Preparatory)

- **Subuhun** — God as the Glorified One, the One who is Praised.
- **Quddusun** — God as the most Holy, Sacred One. The sacredness that saturates the universe.
- Fikr: Inhale Subuhun → Exhale Quddusun. Begin with 33×.
- Use Mansur's audio recording to receive the melody.

3.3 — Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah (Blessing Invocation)

- Fazl = Blessing · Mullah = Great · Rahim Allah = Allah's Compassion
- Can be sung or recited. Use Mansur's audio recording.

3.4 — Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah (Current Leading Practice)

- **Fazl** — Blessing, illumination. The word of blessing (Murshid).
- **Fattah** — The Opener, the Revealer of paths. Attunement into action.
- Fikr: Inhale Fazl → Exhale Fattah.

3.5 — Ayat al-Qutb (Advanced — Preliminary Version)

Preceded by Subuhun-Quddusun as preparatory practice. Shared by Mansur, March 6, 2026.

Reference: Gatha II, Pasi Anfas — wahiduddin.net/mv2/XIII/XIII_11.htm

IV. SKY OF MIND

Core and foundational. Bridges Shamatha, Vipassana, and Sufi contemplation.

4.1 — Brief Form

Notice thought → Identify (*"planning"*, *"memory"*) → Release → **REJOICE** → Return to patient waiting.

4.2 — Full Five-Stage Practice (Pir Zia)

1. **Witnessing** — Identify with the Sky of Mind. Watch impressions form and dissolve like clouds.
2. **Dark Clouds** — When clarity is impossible. Clouds dense and chaotic.
3. **Remembering the Sun** — The soul is the sun of the sky of the mind. Visualize it dawning.
4. **Luminous Clouds** — Higher clouds of ice crystal wisps, refracting the soul's light in rainbow hues.
5. **Radiation** — Open eyes. Let the soul's sun radiate through your glance upon all you see.

V. DAILY PRACTICE SEQUENCE

Time	Practice
Morning	Five Elemental Purification Breaths
Morning	Invocation (with longing)
Morning/Daily	Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o (11 or 33×)
Preparatory	Subuhun Quddusun Fikr (33×)
Leading	Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah Fikr
Throughout	Watchfulness of Thought · Hosh dar dam · REJOICE
As needed	Qasab (Cleansing the Chalice)
Dedicated	Sky of Mind Contemplation

> *"Not every practice we take up will land, and that's normal and ok." — Mansur*

VI. SACRED RELATIONSHIP & JOURNEY

Meeting Rhythm: First Wednesday of each month, 12 noon Pacific.

Zoom: https://us02web.zoom.us/j/89432264602 · Passcode: 634942

Timeline

Date	Teachings
Dec 12–14, 2025	Invocation · Muraqabah · Ya Sabur/Wahhab · Five Elements · Qasab · Sky of Mind
Dec 17, 2025	Ideal Guru Contemplation · Sacred task confirmed
Jan 12, 2026	Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah (with audio)
Feb 11, 2026	Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah · Monthly cadence established
Mar 6, 2026	Githa Fikr deepening · Subuhun/Quddusun · Ayat al-Qutb · Refs shared

> *"This is the sacred task we undertake together — to make God a reality." — Mansur*

Compiled by Kabir (Ramesh) · Inayatiyya Order

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Sacred Journey Notes — Mansur & Kabir

Order: Inayatiyya

Period: December 2025 – ongoing

THE BOND

> *"I know how deeply you have been touched by, first, your encounter with Pir Zia, and then these breathtaking teachings that feel like home. I am glad you feel a deep rapport with me, as I do with you. I believe we can work together smoothly and gracefully. This is a sacred task we are undertaking — to make God a reality — and a great spiritual friendship. We go forward together." — Mansur, December 2025*

MEETING RHYTHM

- **Monthly:** First Wednesday of each month, 12 noon Pacific Time
- **Zoom:** https://us02web.zoom.us/j/89432264602 · Passcode: 634942
- Open invitation: write whenever questions arise

NOTE ON MANSUR'S NAME

Mansur's spiritual name: **Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah** — Great Blessing of Allah's Compassion.

TIMELINE OF RECEIVED TEACHINGS

Date · Session · Teachings

Dec 12–14, 2025 · First session · Invocation · Muraqabah · Ya Sabur/Wahhab · Five Elemental Breaths · Qasab (preliminary and standard) · Sky of Mind

Dec 17, 2025 · Second session · Ideal Guru Contemplation · Sacred task confirmed · Deep rapport acknowledged

Jan 12, 2026 · Third session · Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah invocation (with audio recording)

Feb 11, 2026 · Fourth session · Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah Fikr · Monthly cadence formally established

Mar 6, 2026 · Fifth session · Fikr deepened through Githa teachings · Subuhun/Quddusun preparatory · Ayat al-Qutb preliminary · Audio and references shared

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Sincerity and the Long Path

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

THE MOST IMPORTANT QUALITY

"Sincerity is the most important quality." — Murshid (through Mansur)

GUIDANCE FOR THE JOURNEY

"Steady on. Steady on. Steady on." — Mansur's guide

THE GREATER WORK

"You're not just fighting the ego locomotive — you're building a locomotive that will swallow that one up." — Mansur

CONTEXT

This teaching came in the context of discussing the long path of spiritual development and the importance of maintaining sincerity and steadiness throughout the journey.

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Part III · Chapter 6

QUOTES, SAYINGS & POETRY

Luminous Fragments

Key teaching quotes from Guide Mansur's personal transmissions.

3 Entries · Guide Mansur

Key Quotes from First Guide Session

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

FROM MANSUR

- **"Your breath is your anchor."** — Shahabuddin (through Mansur)
- **"You actuate and then you allow."** — Mansur
- **"You can contemplate radiance being resonant and sound being luminous."** — Mansur
- **"Every day you do your practices. It's like winding a clock."** — Murshid (through Mansur)
- **"It's okay. You got this. It's difficult, some of it's painful — but it's okay."** — Mansur

FROM PIR VILAYAT

- **"This element is very close to the Holy Spirit."** — (on Water element)
- **"You must burn very hot."** — (on Fire element)
- **"If you do the purification breaths every day, you'll never get seriously ill."**

FROM KABIR

- **"Light (Nur) is the building block of the five elements. Creation = subtle to dense. Realization = dense to subtle, back to the light."**

SACRED TEXTS

- **"I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. Therefore I created the world that I might be known."** — Hadith Qudsi
- **"Through the rays of the sun, through the waves of the air, through the all-pervading life in space, purify and revivify us... Heal our bodies, hearts and souls."** — Prayer of Niyaz

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Key Teaching Quotes — Mansur & Pir Zia

"It can't be taught, but it can be caught." — Mansur

"Patiently, persistently, patiently, persistently... you are bound to be successful, bound to be successful." — Mansur's Vipassana Teacher

"This is the sacred task we undertake together — to make God a reality." — Mansur

"Not every practice we take up will land, and that's normal and ok. We needn't force anything, apart from the healthy discipline of doing the work." — Mansur

"Sabur is meeting life in a friendly way each morning. Wahhab is the freely abundant flow of blessings and life: full of creativity, innovation, new inspiration, and resilience." — Pir Zia Inayat Khan, 2021

"I know how deeply you have been touched by, first, your encounter with Pir Zia, and then these breathtaking teachings that feel like home. I am glad you feel a deep rapport with me, as I do with you. We go forward together." — Mansur, December 2025

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Mansur Quotes from March 2026 Session

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

ON CONTEMPLATION

"I'm a huge fan of concentration — it's the most important thing. But contemplation is more mysterious. It develops as our understanding grows. A powerful and challenging way to explore ourselves and our world."

ON FIKR MOMENTUM

"When you pause — when all your thinking stops — the Fikr just starts up. Because you have planted it there."

ON PROTECTION PRACTICE

"Perfect choice. That practice is all about just embracing yourself. Great blessing of divine mercy — you're bathing yourself in wonderful energy."

ON PEACE

"There's peace in that. A lot of peace."

ON THE NEW EVENING PRACTICE

"A really, deeply, powerfully, wonderfully intoxicating practice that infuses you with beautiful energy."

ON THE REAL JIHAD

"The real jihad is the war with the false self."

ON NOTICING THE EGO

"Rejoice when you notice — you are waking up."

ON BUILDING SPIRITUAL STRENGTH

"You're not just fighting the ego locomotive — you're building a locomotive that will swallow that one up."

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Part III · Chapter 7

DEEP STUDY & ARABIC TERMS

The Language of the Path

Arabic terms, Divine Names, and deeper study materials from Guide Mansur's teachings, including the Asma ul-Husna and their application in practice.

3 Entries · Guide Mansur

Arabic & Divine Names — Meanings Reference

Source: March 1, 2026 · Mansur

DIVINE NAMES USED IN FIKR

Name (Arabic) · Transliteration · Meaning
الصَّبُور · As-Sabur · The Patient One — meeting life with openness and ease
الوَهَّاب · Al-Wahhab · The Supreme Bestower — freely abundant flow of blessings
سبوح · Subuhun · The Glorified One, the One who is Praised
قدوس · Quddusun · The Most Holy, Sacred One — infinite sacredness
فَضْل · Fazl · Blessing, illumination — Murshid's "word of blessing"
الفَتَّاح · Al-Fattah · The Opener, the Revealer of paths
رَحِيم · Rahim · The Compassionate One (attribute of Allah)

OTHER KEY TERMS

Term · Language · Meaning
Muraqabah · Arabic · Watchfulness, contemplative observation
Hosh dar dam · Persian · Consciousness on the breath
Qasab · Arabic · The reed (flute) — also name for the breath practice
Fikr · Arabic · Thought, contemplation; divine name repetition on the breath
Zikr · Arabic · Remembrance of God
Suluk · Arabic · The path, the journey; spiritual wayfaring
Qutb · Arabic · The Pole; the spiritual axis; the Axial Saint
Ayat · Arabic · Sign, verse (of Quran)
Gatha · Sanskrit/Sufi · A series of secret papers/teachings (Hazrat Inayat Khan)
Pasi Anfas · Persian · Guarding the breath; control of breath in Sufi practice

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Fikr Progression — Overview

The Fikr practices form a sequential progression, each building on the preceding one.

Stage · Practice · Inhale · Exhale · Theme · Received
First · Ya Sabur-o / Ya Wahhab-o · Sabur-o · Wahhab-o · Foundation — patience & blessing · Dec 2025
Preparatory · Subuhun / Quddusun · Subuhun · Quddusun · Purification — angelic awareness · Mar 2026
Blessing · Fazl Mullah Rahim Allah · — · — · Devotion — great blessing · Jan 2026
Current · Ya Fazl / Ya Fattah · Fazl · Fattah · Attunement into action · Feb 2026
Advanced · Ayat al-Qutb · — · — · Advanced (preliminary only) · Mar 2026

> *By Fikr one becomes conscious of one's mind. Through the power of the breath — the lift which carries you to any floor of the house — you rise above the physical and mental planes toward consciousness of the soul.*

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Light as Building Block of Five Elements

Source: December 12, 2025 · Mansur

KABIR'S INSIGHT

"Light (Nur) is the building block of the five elements. Creation = subtle to dense. Realization = dense to subtle, back to the light." — Kabir

MANSUR'S RESPONSE

- Sound and light go together — they are a natural pairing
- **"You can contemplate radiance being resonant and sound being luminous."** — Mansur
- At a certain level of depth, they are one thing

THE TEACHING

This insight reveals the fundamental substrate of creation - that light (Nur) is the primordial substance from which the five elements condense. The path of realization involves tracing this manifestation back from dense to subtle, ultimately returning to the original light.

The pairing of light and sound as complementary aspects of the same fundamental reality points to their unity at the deepest level of experience.

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Appendix A

CLASS SCHEDULE

Concentration comprised 20 sessions taught across four weekends. Part I was taught by Pir Zia Inayat Khan (September–October 2025). Part II was taught by Urs Qutbuddin (November–December 2025). Part III collects the personal transmissions of Guide Mansur, given throughout the year.

Session	Date	Instructor	Part
C1	2025-09-12	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C2	2025-09-12	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C3	2025-09-13	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C4	2025-09-13	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C5	2025-09-14	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C6	2025-09-14	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C7	2025-10-11	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C8	2025-10-11	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C9	2025-10-12	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C10	2025-10-12	Pir Zia Inayat Khan	I
C11	2025-11-21	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C12	2025-11-21	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C13	2025-11-22	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C14	2025-11-22	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C15	2025-11-23	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C16	2025-11-23	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C17	2025-12-13	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C18	2025-12-13	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C19	2025-12-14	Urs Qutbuddin	II
C20	2025-12-14	Urs Qutbuddin	II

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C O L O P H O N

The Book of Concentration — Mount Qaf Companion Handbook

Second Edition — March 2026

Option B: Instructor Sections with Topic Sub-chapters

Compiled from 291 teachings extracted from the transcripts of

20 Concentration sessions, Suluk Global Online Program 2025–2027

Part I: Pir Zia Inayat Khan — 134 teachings
Part II: Urs Qutbuddin Schellenberg — 122 teachings
Part III: Guide Mansur — 35 teachings

Kabir · Class of Mount Qaf
Pod Mentor: Farzana · Inayatiyya

This handbook is for personal spiritual use. The teachings belong to the Inayatiyya lineage and are shared here as a student's learning companion.

The knowledge is held. The path continues.